Forgiveness Has A Price

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/17338421.

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra)

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wlw, Implied Sexual Content, Sexual Content, No Smut, By no smut I mean this story is not meant to have porn and there are erotic themes, Angst, Fluff and Angst, It will end happily I promise

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by TheAmbiguousFool

Summary

Summary: Trapped together, Catra is forced to come to terms with her past. Adora desperately struggles to get through to her and save Catra from the Horde's poisonous and abusive grasp. It is also Adora who must come to terms with the truth and that her intentions were based on ignorance.

Bright Moon is not as strong as they thought and are receiving help from a shameful source. With Catra and Adora gone, it is unknown if the playing field remained the same [2018 REBOOT][CatrAdora][WLW][M][Language][Violence]

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Chapter 01

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“STOP THIS, CATRA!” She-Ra scolded over the sounds of smoldering and falling trees. Trees that were once healing from a previous onslaught now hardened by time. Bright Moon was at constant war with the Horde and the Whispering Woods was no longer a fortifiable defense. She-Ra was forced to dodge another assault from Catra’s battle suit. Her Horde armor enveloped her like a shining knight. Her weapons were almost as advanced as those of the First One’s tech. Her back emblazoned with the symbol of the Horde and her helmet fashioned sharp, spindly horns. From the side of her arm shot another powerful energy blast. Had it not been for the short moment to recharge, she could have hit She-Ra on her recovery.

Catra grinned with crude pleasure behind her armor. She enjoyed the enhanced cat and mouse game and it was clear she had the upper hand. She-Ra couldn’t get close enough to strike with the constant barrage of attacks. She wouldn’t endure much longer. Her breath heavy and her counter strikes were getting slower. The best She-Ra could do was to run deeper into the forest.

Deeper and deeper they went. For a moment She-Ra took cover and Catra needed to hunt. She-Ra pleaded again, “PLEASE STOP THIS! I CAN HELP YOU IF YOU JUST LISTEN TO ME!” Her voice seemed to echo is all directions and Catra began scanning the area with a slow turn of her head.

Catra’s ears twitched and she shouted back, “I’M DONE LISTENING, ADORA! I’VE BEEN DONE FOR A *LONG* TIME!” The scanner in Catra’s helmet chirped in rapid succession and revealed the hidden hero. She opened fire in She-Ra’s direction with a charged blast. A loud and pained groan was Catra’s received reply

as her grin widened victoriously. Catra sprinted toward her, "Not getting away this time, Adora!"

She-Ra was left crawling away on the ground and had only been protected by the shield she carried. Her shield blackened yet still in tact. Every muscle in She-Ra's body trembled and felt as if on fire, though she pushed on. She kept crawling towards a First-One's temple hoping to take shelter but Catra was right behind.

Catra taunted, "Aww, thanks, Adora! You just led me *right* to another temple that I'm going to destroy." She cackled, "How can you be so stupid?" Catra couldn't help but scoff at She-Ra's ongoing effort to reach the temple in a saddened desperation. As she walked towards her, "You'll never get there at *that* pace. Here, LET ME HELP YOU!" With the enhancements of her suit, she lifted She-Ra, sprinted to the door, and slammed her body against it. A howling scream followed by a muffled and shuddered cry.

Several shallow breaths to recover and to will the pain away, "C-Catra…, d-don't you *DARE* go inside!" She gasped at the pain as she spoke, "You'll regret it! I *SWEAR* you'll regret it! YOU HAVE-" she coughed hard. It was both a reaction to the pain that had only caused her more pain. She forced herself to suppress it. "You *have* to listen to me, *please,* Catra."

Catra narrowed her eyes on the fallen heroine and grabbed her by the throat and lifted her. She-Ra tried to gasp and struggled against the tight grip. "You say 'no', I say 'go'." She forced the door to open and threw She-Ra into the temple. Catra followed her in with a smugness that signified her victory, "GEE, DO YOU FEEL SAFER NOW!?"

It hadn't been more than six steps in did the thick metal doors come to a forceful close again. The walls began to glow and a force field shrouded the room.

She-Ra cried out, "I'm sorry Catra, I'm so sorry!" She-Ra groaned, "I tried…, I tried so hard to convince you. I'm sorry."

Catra observed the room from the corners of her eyes, “What are you going on about!?”

She-Ra took several breaths, exhaling harder with each one. She strained a moment. A growing glow to a blinding brightness encased her. With her shield still in hand she charged at Catra at an amazing speed. Far too quick for Catra to react and her enhanced armor shattered against the crash. She-Ra followed through with a spinning, back-handed fist to Catra’s helmet. Catra’s body spun and tumbled back like a rag doll in a flash and sloshed to a stop as did every limb of her body.

She-Ra threw her shield to the ground and transformed back to Adora. She raced with an agonizing limp to Catra’s side, “Please be okay, please be okay!” She placed an ear to Catra’s chest to hear her heart and was relieved to hear it was still beating. She removed any of the pieces of armor that remained clung to Catra’s arms and legs. Adora, in a hasty panic, looped her arms underneath Catra's armpits and dragged her to a place where she could help her. Every step to move Catra’s body sent painful tingles through Adora's legs and ribs but she endured. She endured for Catra.

~oO0Oo~

There was a sound of white noise humming from the machine's in the temple's medical bay. Catra groaned and her ears twitched violent flicks for a brief moment. Adora woke in the chair beside her and leaned forward to grab her hand. “Catra, I'm here.”

Catra groaned again. Adora's voice seemed to blur and distort as did Catra’s vision when she tried to open her eyes. The intense pain in her head pulsed with each beat of her heart. She let out a very discomforted and loud moan.

“Not again, not again,” came Adora's worried voice. Adora lunged for a small pail as Catra turned to her side and emptied what fluid was left in her stomach. Adora did her best to catch it but most of her effort went in vain. She was left to clean the mess from her hands and floor. Adora let out a heavy sigh, “Whatever, it's fine.” It took her a moment to realize Catra was still leaning over the edge of the bed unconscious. Adora quickly wiped her hands with a rag and lifted her back in bed, “When are you going to get better?”

~oO0Oo~

Another day had passed. Adora stayed by Catra’s side and waited. Hunger was on her mind but she pushed the thought away. It was like old times when they were at the Horde. Unfortunately, it wasn't long before her mind glimpsed to a memory of palace food. She groaned into her hands thinking of all the pastries, sweets, and a slew of exotic meats. Adora complained in a whisper, “Mmmrrr, so hungry.”

A mumbled, “Me too,” startled Adora.

Adora spoke quickly and held a worried tone in her voice, “Catra! How-how are you feeling? Are you still nauseous? Do you think you can drink some water? The temple has-has-has all these things to make you better but you weren't getting better and I-I-I was so worried you weren't going to be the same. Do-do you know your name? Do you know my name?”

Another groan as Catra held her head, “Do shut *up* , Adora.”

A brief pause followed by a glowing smile, “You remember!”

“I'm pretty sure I said, ‘shut up’. You're so loud! Ugh!” Even the sound from her own voice hurt.

A quiet mutter, “S-sorry.”

Catra rubbed her face and tried to look around. Her vision was still fuzzy but she could make out some of the objects. The bed, that was clear. The various tubes connected to her. She spoke sourly, “Am I going to set off any alarms if I pull this out?”

“They jus-” Adore cleared her throat and quieted her voice, “They hydrate you. I can get you some food. We can-”

“Shush.” Adora did while Catra continued to look around. She took her time to disconnect herself from the medical machines. She realized she was wearing a headband and began to remove it as well. That was until she felt even greater pain in her head and cried out in agony. She clutched her scalp as it panged hard to a point of making her ears ring.

Adora lunged toward her to affix the headband again, “That one, you might want to keep on a bit longer. It helps suppress the swelling in your head. You can walk around with it on, though.”

Adora's eyes locked to Catra’s for a single moment and Adora was then shoved away, “Don’t touch me!”

The temple floor glowed a faint cerulean and the walls had the marks of ancient scriptures. To her, it looked like meticulous hieroglyphics etched into the walls. And seemed unreadable by anyone except Adora. They were, in fact, instructions on how to operate the equipment. But, to anyone else, it looked to be ancient stories from the First Ones.

Catra sat on the edge of the bed and rubbed her face again. The last thing she remembered was that awful bright light right before everything went dark. *I lost. She beat me, AGAIN!* She tightened a fist in anger.

Adora noticed and placed a gentle hand on Catra’s shoulder only to feel it pulled away followed by a scornful look. Adora couldn't help feel the tug on her heart with that forceful jerking away from

her hand. Catra stood up from the bed and stumbled a bit as she did so.

“Catra!” Adora attempted to help her but was, again, shoved away.

“I'm fine! I don't need your help!” Catra had no destination, she wanted to distance herself from Adora. She assumed she was in one of Bright Moon’s prisons. She'd need to concentrate on escape if Adora would *just* leave. She pretended to be fascinated with the etchings on the walls as she looked around. She left the room stale with silence.

Adora assessed that Catra was finally okay enough to leave her alone. No immediate care was needed. Now that she was able to stand and walk around on her own, she felt it safe to leave. Adora took a nervous breath, “I’m-” cautious to speak, “I’m going to get us some food. Please wait here,” she thought about the words she chose. *Of course, now that I said that, she’ll probably leave and get lost.* With some quick thinking, “Or not! Whatever. Do whatever you want…, but if you want food, I’m bringing it back here. Okay! I’m… off to get the food… to bring back here. If you get hungry, this location… is where the food...is-WILL BE!” Catra looked at her with a twisted, confused, and annoyed glare. Adora facepalmed, turned on her heels, and left.

Catra waited until Adora’s footsteps were nearly muted by distance before peaking around a corner at the doorway. No one was around in the well lit hall. She looked above and around for any obvious sensors. Nothing. She looked at the floor and tested for any pressure plates. So far so good. She took careful steps forward down the small hallway to peak around yet another corner. Nothing. Feeling more confident at its emptiness she walked faster down the next hall. All doors she passed by were closed with no way to see beyond them. There was no clear way to open them either. She could hear approaching footsteps and tried to continue on. She hoped to find some way out until she was face to face with Adora again and startled her in the process.

Adora dropped a few boxes of food as she jumped at the sudden but not entirely unexpected encounter. “Don’t scare me like that!” She bent down to pick up the few boxes of dehydrated. As she came back up, “Look, are you hungry or aren’t you? You’ve been out for two days, it would be wise if you ate.” Adora handed her a box with a roll of her hand and a glare that encouraged Catra to take it.

A brief moment of hesitation before she swiped at the box to take it, “Fine,” she grumbled.

“Come on, we can eat at a table.” Adora led her to a few more doors down the hall until she stepped in front of one. She placed her fingers in what appeared to be decorative grooves, a recess in the door, and pulled downward. And downward the door went that revealed the entrance to a small dining hall. She placed the boxes on a table and took out the tiny pellets. She went to get hot water behind her. As she was filling a cup from a grooved faucet, she spoke over her shoulder, “It’s not much. But, with the way you’ve been throwing up, we should first see if you can hold the food down.” She brought the cups of water to the table and spilled some of it over the dried food and watched it take its time to swell.

“Throw up?”

“All over me.”

Catra knew she was trying to lighten the mood but she would have none of it. She refused to speak again. She took a small bite of the food but her tongue desired more. Quicker, she took larger mouthfuls at a time having not realized how hungry she was until that first bite.

“Whoa, slow down! You’re gonna-” The very next moment, Adora, again, was covered in what was projected from Catra’s mouth. Adora closed her eyes a moment and released a heavy irritated sigh, “WHATEVER! I’m used to it!” Adora got up with a gradual rise and carefully took off her red jacket. Luckily it seemed to be

the only garment hit while Catra coughed and spit the rest on the floor. Adora got up and washed her hands and brought another cup of hot water back, “This time, eat slower...., please.”

They spent the next hour in silence. They ate a small part, waited and ensured their stomachs could handle it, and then tried more. When Adora had her fill, she could feel her mind clearing. Yet it wasn't enough to relieve her exhaustion from watching over Catra. She stood up, “I’ll clean up later, I really need to rest. I’ll be two doors down on the right. I’ll leave the door open. Speaking of, to open these ridiculous doors, it’s pull down from the center recess and, to close, it’s pull up from the recess in the floor.” Catra glared at her without a word as she walked off. “One last thing,” Adora added, “try to take it easy for a couple days. You should rest.”

~oO0Oo~

Adora approached the edge of her bed and let gravity take her to it. Her face smashed against the pillows and expected a quick departure from consciousness. But, she was beginning to realize, with each uncomfortable toss in her bed, that sleep was not coming. Overtired and filled with worry, her eyes began to well with tears as she muffled her muted sobs. She was no longer confident with her decision to stay with Catra. She wondered and worried if the Horde’s forces were still advancing. Bright Moon could not handle a repeat of Catra’s first attack. And now, now She-Ra was unable to be with the other princesses. With desperation, she tried to force these thoughts away. Every decision she made felt like a mistake and thought back to six weeks ago.

~0~

Glimmer held Adora's hand firmly, "I think this is a really, really…, *really* bad idea." Both Glimmer and Adora watched Bright Moon guards march into the temple carrying supplies. Any princess tied to a rune stone were busy enchanting and inscribing scriptures in the outer walls with their magic. Beads of sweat poured off of them as they worked on the large structure.

Adora turned to Glimmer, "This is the only way. Without Catra, the Whispering Woods can heal. The rebellion can take care of the remaining forces. You won't need She-Ra so long as I can get Catra." She gave a brief pause to assure herself that this was the right and only way. "And I will."

"But you only have enough supplies for-"

"I know, Glimmer, but I can accomplish a lot in a year. She won't have a choice but to listen. And I know this is hard to believe, but she's not bad. She's… she's…," Adora fought hard for the right words, "she's hurt." She knew this didn't make sense to Glimmer. She tried, with added effort, to abate Glimmer's worries, "You guys fought without She-Ra for a thousand years and with a broken alliance! Now you can fight the Horde and protect the woods. I believe in you guys, don't you believe in me?"

"OF COURSE WE DO! BUT-" Glimmer's eyes began to tear, "BUT *THIS?"*

Adora remained silent. The vehicles hummed a soft whirring as they passed her. More and more supplies were being loaded in. Soft whispers, no longer threatening to her, spoke with a gentle shushing. "Imagine…, just imagine how powerful we could be if I could get through to her. And…, she's my…, I can't turn my back on her. She needs my help. The Catra that *I* know isn't evil." If Glimmer didn't stop trying to change her mind, she was going to break down and cry with her. She had to stay strong. "Besides, if this plan didn't have a chance, your mom would never agree to it. We're stronger now, with or without She-Ra."

Glimmer grasped Adora's jacket, "It's not She-Ra I want! It's YOU!" She sobbed on her shoulder, "Sh-she's going to hurt you! PLEASE don't do this, Adora!"

Adora hugged her, "You know I have to." She gave one more consoling squeeze and released, "It's not like I'll be gone forever, and who knows, maybe we'll be out sooner." She tried to give a reassuring smile. Her own words rang in her mind, *Assuming Catra doesn't kill me first.* "Trust me, I can do this."

Glimmer sniffed hard as she stood up straight, "You better! And it's not just me. Don't forget about, Bow," she began counting on her fingers, "Perfuma, Mermista, Frosta, Seahawk, and-and…, EVERYONE!" She threw her hands up.

Again Adora smiled, "I won't forget anyone."

~0~

Tears seeped out of Adora's eyes as she told herself, *I can do this. I can.* She gripped the pillow hard and muffled her cries. She tried to calm herself with deeper breaths. As she did, she finally felt the wave of fatigue that would guide her to sleep. She placed a heavier pillow at the foot of her bed so she could rest easier. It didn't have Catra's warmth when she slept with her at the Horde barracks but it was enough to convince her brain to rest.

~oO0Oo~

Catra finished her food in silence. Silence - it was this that was so peculiar. There were no guards, no other prisoners, no visible sensors or alarms. Nothing. Absolute silence all around. She got

up and decided it was time to figure out where she was. Adora was to the right, so she went left. She came to and approached the first door she encountered. She stared at the recess for a moment and placed her fingers in it as Adora had. She pushed down and stood back. Down it went and she entered. It was a bathroom with a large tub. The walls marbled and the shelves stocked with soft towels, perfumes, and soaps. Catra had never seen anything like it and her eyes darted around in confusion. Beside the tub was what appeared to be a toilet except it had soft curved recesses. She walked in and examined it more closely and stared at the ovate shape. A gentle touch to the seat and it immediately began to hum, "Gah!" She took a few steps back and saw it had done nothing. She tested and touched the seat again with her hand and noticed the warmth it radiated. She sat herself down slow and felt the heat on her thighs, "Ohh ohh, okay." She huffed a breath and went. As she relaxed into the seat she reminded herself not to get too comfortable. It was time to move on. As she leaned forward, a soft towelette, of a sort, dispensed out from the wall. Catra poked it with her finger and felt its softness, "PFAH! Are you kidding me!?" She snatched and used it. "I guess I shouldn't expect anything less from spoiled princesses." She got up, avoiding the sink as she left. Perhaps the hieroglyphic inscriptions on the wall right above it were too complicated to spend time figuring out.

The next room she found was a small garden that shined red and blue lights over some growing vegetation. She left for it did not interest her. She moved on down the halls, not finding an exit. Each room seemed to have their own clear theme. A dining area, a kitchen, and what appeared to be a host of games and puzzles. It kept going and going until Catra stumbled upon where she last fought Adora. She approached and picked a shattered piece of her Horde armor and then discarded it. Not far from it was She-Ra's shield. This puzzled her. Why was this not right next to Adora. She couldn't believe she'd discard it and leaving lying there in the open for anyone to take. For *her* to take. Anger took hold of her, though. She picked up the shield and threw it as hard as she could. "FUCK YOU!" she screamed out and then was immediately

startled and pushed back by the boom of the force field as it hit. The collision caused the field to glow bright and pulse and wobble. It seemed to not only absorb the impact but displace it.

It soon began to register to Catra why she was free to roam the halls and rooms. She approached the door she entered initially. Where she was told - no, *warned* not to enter. She-Ra's voice echoed in her mind, "I SWEAR YOU'LL REGRET IT!" A tingle of fear washed over her and her mouth became suddenly dry. She raised a hand and slowly attempted to bring it to the door. In an instant the force field reacted to the touch and pushed back, hard. "NO!" she screamed. The insurmountable rage built inside her at the realization there was no escape.

~oO0Oo~

Catra grit her teeth and rushed back to Adora's room. Adora was completely asleep until Catra lifted her by the collar of her shirt. She slammed Adora's body against the wall, "GET ME OUT! NOW!" She screamed at Adora's face as the startling pain disoriented her. "YOU TELL ME HOW, RIGHT NOW!" She breathed in great huffs on Adora's face. The waft of each breath was like fire.

Adora tried to groan out, "I-I-" she coughed hard, "I CAN'T!"

Catra dropped her and Adora landed hard. Catra was ready to kick her ribs, "WHAT DO YOU MEAN YOU *CAN'T* !? I WILL *KILL* YOU!"

"Then-" she groaned at the pain, "Then you'll be alone. Everyday," she coughed again, "Never knowing how anything works. You'll be left in a prison that could give you everything you need without ever getting it and taunted by the fact…" She stopped herself.

Fuming, she growled, "By the fact *WHAT!?* "

Adora hesitated. It was going to be the most painful thing. “That I…,” Adora forced herself to meet Catra’s eyes from the floor, “I won.”

Catra screamed at her. Her expression displayed she had every intent to harm Adora. And she did. A kick to the ribs, a punch to the face, she clawed her legs, and threw her to the other side of the room. Catra then left the room to the sound of Adora’s pained and tortured cries.

~oO0Oo~

Catra went back to the entrance hall and picked up the shield and slammed it against the barrier. Again, the force field wobbled to the impact. “FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!” she slammed the shield into the barrier again. “FUCK YOU!” She was beginning to panic. The fear of no escape consumed her. She went looking for another door but, as she approached the walls of the outer rooms, she was pushed back by the same force field. “There has to be a weak point, I’ll find it, I’ll find it! Do you hear me, ADORA!? I’LL FIND IT!” *Adora.* She finally realized the condition she left Adora in. *I don’t care. I don’t owe her ANYTHING!* Except, she did. She pursed her lips as she allowed herself to flip a coin in her head as she eyed the hallway back.

~oO0Oo~

Catra stood over Adora who was bleeding on the ground and trembled at the sight of her. Catra’s face was still painted with hatred and fury. She approached closer and Adora groaned at the pain as she tried to protect herself. Instead, she was lifted and carried out of the room to the medical station. She placed Adora

on the bed where she once laid earlier. The first thing Catra needed to do was to stop the bleeding but she didn't know where anything was. She looked so furious at Adora, "How do I stop…, this?" she waved a hand at the wound.

Adora raised a shaking hand and pointed to a cabinet.

Catra sprinted to the cabinet but it had some different mechanism to open it. Irritated, "How do I *OPEN* it?"

Without a word and still with that trembling hand she motioned her fingers with a thrust and a swipe to the left. Adora's vision was doubling and blurring. She wasn't going to last much longer.

Catra imitated the motion and grabbed a packet. "What do I do with this?" There was no response. "Adora! What do I do with this!?" Nothing. *Great.* She tore the pouch open and looked at it. It contained strange, multi-colored crystals. She dipped a finger in and found the substance was dry to touch, but when mashed together, it would become like a sticky adhesive. She understood enough and poured it over the open wounds. Now, she needed to apply pressure. She watched Adora scream with a muted agony. Catra's hand was covered in the sticky substance and couldn't shake it off but for the most part, it served its purpose. She had more time to look through the cabinets and figure out if she could help her other injuries. After rummaging through for several minutes, she discovered a cold-pack that was activated when you squeezed it. A frustrated mashing of items in the cabinet helped enlighten that discovery. She applied them on Adora's face and ribs.

Roughly an hour later came a whispered, "Thank you, Catra."

Catra's brows furrowed, "Whatever." She got up, "Looks like you're fine now. I'm going to your room since I don't know where mine is. Don't bother me, I need to think." Catra walked off.

Adora remained on the medical bed with no ability to move around yet. She rested as much as she could. She wrestled with

the idea that she should have fought back. And that enduring the pain and risking her life was unbelievably stupid. But for the purpose of her mission, she needed to be vulnerable and completely open to Catra.

She understood everything the day she was stuck with Catra. The day she searched for Light Hope changed everything. Catra's abuse was getting dismissed for too long. It had shaped her and changed the way she believed people thought of her. Catra's only option was to fight back, be independent, and take control. Adora felt foolish for not realizing it sooner. *I'll show you, Catra. It doesn't have to be like this.* Adora closed her eyes and rested. She'd apply gauze to her wounds after she built-up enough energy to do so. For now, the amateur quick-fix Catra did with the chatoyant powder would be enough.

~oO0Oo~

Catra stared at the blood on the floor with disdain, anger, and surprisingly, guilt from the foot of the bed. She wrapped her tail around herself and tried to think about her next steps, but she was distracted. Rolling and rushing questions invaded her mind. *What did she mean she can't!? She didn't answer. What did she mean!?* The blood was still drying. It was browning around the edges and she watched it congeal in the center. She wanted to clean it up but the 'how' and 'with what' were issues that led to more issues. She'd have to talk to Adora again to find out. The blood felt as if it spoke to her and enhanced her guilt. *She didn't resist. I caught her by surprise. She could have fought back. Why didn't she?* She exhaled an irritated groan. *I'm trapped… with her. I don't know what her plan is. I don't know how long I'm staying here. And she can't break the barrier. She imprisoned… herself? I DON'T GET IT!*

She got up and walked to the med station once more but she saw Adora sleeping. She had lain on her side and it was unclear if she was breathing. Catra took a silent step in and then heard gentle sighs. She left the room in response. *I'll get her to tell me tomorrow.*

~oO0Oo~

Adora woke in the middle of the night. Her legs, chest, and face throbbed. She needed to give herself better care. She got up with a careful and gradual rise. She knew well if she got up too fast she'd fall over and hurt herself more. She limped on the balls of her feet and rummaged through the cabinets. She brought out a cylindrical device, gauze wrap, and a thin, flat, but bendable contraption that would wrap around her torso. She tossed them on the bed and then fetched a cup of water. She set the cup down and the first thing she grabbed was the cylindrical device. She held it to the wound on her calf and held a thumb over an inscription. An immediate pulse and she let out a relieved sigh. Her leg no longer felt as if ants had been biting her skin. Next, she brought the device to her face, and again, it pulsed with a wave of relief. The downside was that her face now drooped on the affected side. The device provided temporary pain relief by relaxing any muscle and numbed all nerves within the chosen area. She wanted to use it on her chest and abdomen but doing so would completely immobilize her. She first needed to wrap up her leg. She took a sip of water and began applying the bandages. By morning, the wound would be sealed and mostly healed. Finally was her chest. She wanted to verify there was no internal bleeding and the bendable screen that wrapped around her was a non-invasive way to find out. In a moment it was revealed she was clear of any internal damage. Finally, it was time for her chest to relax. At least the First One's tech was on her side. Difficult times were ahead, Adora knew this.

Chapter End Notes

I binge watched the reboot and simply had no choice but to write a fic. I mean, I just had to.

Please note, I do have a B-Story. Some people did not like I have a B-Story and dropped the fic. PLEASE KNOW that Chapter 6 is pretty much where this happens. BUT AFTER, I've done a lot to taper back on the B-Plot - like... A LOT. So, if you don't like Plot B, it's easy enough to skip (even though it sorta ties together in the end). It's not even the whole chapter 06.

I will take another look at chapter 6 again at some point and see if I can shrink the b-plot some more for you.

As you can probably tell, this is my raw, slightly revised draft of my first chapter. I'm sure there's a lot wrong with it but I would not mind at all if you reviewed it. In fact, I highly encourage it. The more feedback, even negative, the better.

Please know that I fully intend to have this end with CatrAdora, happily, but I will be throwing them under a bus a few times. I am doing this to explain Adora's and Catra's perspectives - it gets deep.

Anyway, please let me know what you think. I'm sure there's a lot of confusion as to what's going to happen next but hey, that's the point *finger guns and winks* And if this story doesn't float your boat, please let me know what chased you away :)

Chapter 02

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Morning came, although it was difficult to tell. The walls of the temple seemed to glow ever so slightly brighter in the morning. Adora was surprised to find herself with a gentle smile as she woke. Her eyes not yet open, she recounted to herself that it had been one of the best nights she slept in a long time. She considered it was a combination of having not slept for two days straight and her body finally allowing sleep. That and possibly the fact she managed to numb all of her injuries. She stretched her legs slowly and cautiously and was surprised how well they were feeling. That was until the pillow at the end of her bed no longer felt like a pillow. She squinted and finally opened her eyes to find Catra sleeping at her feet. She quickly pulled her feet in and hugged her knees, wide eyed.

Catra took a gentle breath and opened an eye, "Whatever you're thinking, you can *forget IT* ," she blinked her other eye open and glared sourly, "I can't sleep in a room filled with your blood and you still needed to recover. *This…* means *nothing.* Got it?" After she received an acknowledging nod from Adora, she stretched hard, yawned, and left the med station.

Adora's smile was now fighting to stay above a frown. She was disgusted with herself. She felt stupid to think anything had been even remotely abated from the night before. She buried her face in her hands and slowly wiped away. "Fine," she said quietly. She pushed to get up and tested her leg with slow stretches and flexes. She still needed to take it easy but the Bright Moon's medical supplies were phenomenal. All the medicine they had were based on First One's tech and some of which were enchanted. *I might actually survive this.* She brought herself to a mirror and noted the dark bruise on her face. Not much she could

do about it. She lifted her shirt slightly and felt the swelling there as well. She tsked and decided to find Catra.

She suspected she'd find her in her bedroom and wasn't too surprised to see she was right. There she was, staring at the dried blood stain with her tail curled around her legs. Adora's mind flooded with questions, *Was she sorry? Did she feel any guilt?* She knocked gently on the door frame and spoke softly, "C-can I get you some breakfast?"

A soft scoffing huff with a shrug, " *Sure* ."

Adora brought her voice to a whisper, "Can um…, can we eat together?

Catra turned her head towards Adora and looked at her dead in the eye, "No."

Adora didn't expect that response to hurt as much as it did. Her mind screamed 'mistake' and she blinked as she turned away but not before a cracked and whispered, "Okay," escaped her throat.

Catra sneered, "Where's Adora!?"

Adora turned, "W-what? I'm-"

"No!" Catra got up and got up to her face causing Adora to take a few steps back, "Adora fights back!" she shoved Adora back, " *Adora* isn't *scared* of me!" she shoved her harder causing her to trip to the floor. Adora placed a hand on her bruised chest as Catra approached closer, " *Adora* doesn't imprison herself with the *enemy* !" Catra placed a clawed hand on Adora's throat, "So answer me this, who the hell are you?"

With a worried and shaky breath, "I'm Adora," she spoke quicker, "I can be She-Ra, I can tell you stories that only *you* and I know. Catra, I'm Adora."

She narrowed her eyes, "First One's tech scanned our memories and made everything an illusion. They played it back LIKE A

RECORDING! You’re going to have to do better than that.”

Adora pursed her lips and grabbed Catra’s wrist with both hands and quickly twisted her hand away from her throat. She followed through kicking her legs out and flipping her behind her and finally pinning her on the floor. She quickly jumped off as Catra’s reflex counter was going to claw her face. “I’m Adora!” she kneeled on the floor with her head down and her hands slightly raised to surrender, “We both know you’re stronger than I am and without She-Ra I’m completely vulnerable. But I’m not really in the mood to die so can we please just eat!?” She raised her eyes slightly to see if she would stop.

Catra stood up, “Fine, you’re Adora.” She walked off but not far. She opened the door to the dining hall and entered.

Adora relaxed her muscles and sat on the floor to recuperate. Her chest and back ached even more now. Adora took a deep breath and released. She got up and went to the kitchen to cook a simple breakfast. When she was done, she brought it to the dining hall and placed a plate on the table in front of Catra who's feet rested next to it.

Catra looked up with her eyes and watched Adora turn around to leave with another plate in hand, “And where do you think you're going?”

Adora stopped and looked back, “Y-you said- I-I thought you didn't want to-”

“I don't. I have questions, so sit.” Catra took her feet off the table and stared at her food. She poked it with her finger and sniffed it.

Adora sat down across from her, “They're just eggs.”

Catra quickly swapped Adora's dish with hers, “Are they now?”

Offended, “You think I'd *poison* you?” She glared at Catra expecting the worst.

Catra looked up and performed the same poke and sniff test, “Wouldn't you?”

Adora slammed a hand on the table, “I would never!”

She smirked, “I would.” Catra waited until Adora took the first bite of her food before she dug in. When Adora finally dismissed the retort, Catra watched her shove a few forkfuls in her mouth and turned away, still offended. She scoffed a laugh at the silliness of it and ate a few bites for herself.

“Whatever. What did you want to ask?”

Catra kept her eyes on her food, “What are you allowed to tell me without lying?”

“Everything. I won't lie to you, Catra, *ever* .”

“Is that so? Then why don't you start with your plan.” She tilted her head to her shoulder lazily and pointed the fork at Adora.

Adora opened her mouth, then quickly shut it. She tried again but could only utter a broken “Uh.”

“Is there a *problem* ?”

Adora looked away and thought a moment before answering, “Look, it's not exactly easy to talk to you and the last time I did, I nearly died!” She watched Catra tighten a fist in the table. “I'm sorry, I just meant, you got really angry. And that's…, that's understandable.”

Catra glared, “I'm still not hearing this ‘everything’ you're talking about.”

Adora sighed and tried to say something that wasn't going to be seen as ‘bad news’, “You're not a prisoner here.”

Catra quickly chuckled incredulously, “Oh really? You certainly fooled me!”

With a raised hand, she corrected, “Kind of! Here,” she pointed downwards, “I'll do everything you ask. Think of me like-like-like-” she fought for the right words, “a servant! Treat this place like a spa! It has everything you need! Food, water, bubbling tubs of steamy water, I'll even wipe your ass if you want! My point-”

“You’ll *what* ?”

“I won't even question it.” They stared at each for a solid ten seconds before Adora continued, “Let me first give you the tour. Let me show you how things operate here so you’ll know what do if you ever decide to-” Adora stopped herself from continuing, “Nevermind, food is getting cold.” She took another forkful but suddenly jumped at Catra who swiped her food away and let it crash against the adjacent wall. Adora slammed her fists on the table and froze. Frustrated and fearful of being hurt again.

“You're not making *any* sense, Adora! START MAKING *SENSE!* ”

“I'M TRYING!” Adora got up in a huff and left hurriedly.

“Where are you going!” She got up and chased her.

Adora heard clattering of clawed feet rapidly encroach behind and picked up her pace. She went to the entrance hall where everything started. She ran to her shield and shouted the words, “FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL”. Catra froze in her tracks and was ready to defend any attack She-Ra had to throw at her. But She-Ra didn’t attack her. Instead she transformed her shield back into a sword and struck the forcefield with a shining beam of light. She poured more and more of herself into the energy and screamed as if all the energy within her was being sapped out until she just stopped. She collapsed to one knee and breathed heavily. They both watched the forcefield ripple more and more, tighter and tighter until it seemed to collect at the very spot She-Ra fired. And, with a loud and deep thundering growl, it projected and displaced the energy all throughout the temple. Both Catra and She-Ra were forced to shield their ears from the deafening

blast as it rippled back at them. They both collapsed to the ground screaming.

Minutes went by as they took the time to recover. Their hearing slowly returning with an ongoing ring. She-Ra stood up and transformed back to Adora while gyrating her jaw. She approached Catra, "I can't leave. I can't escape. But…, *we* can. Together." Adora was still breathless.

Catra stared at her. Completely in disbelief at the sheer stupidity of the stunt she just pulled but she had something more important to say, "You're STILL not making any SENSE!"

"SHUT *UP* !" Adora breathed heavily, "That took a lot out of me, just…," another deep breath, "just give me a minute." Adora sat down in front of her on the floor with her sword still in hand. Another deep breath, "I've done a lot of bad to you," she stared at her own reflection in the blade as she set it to the floor, "Not intentionally. I swear it. But I've wronged you, I know that much." There was a long pause. Catra didn't know if that was it or if she was still recovering until she finally spoke again, "I just *didn't* know. I was so naive and stupid. We were just *kids* ! I-I didn't know any better! All *I* wanted was for you and me to be together, to get each other's backs and I *thought* I was. I didn't know Shadow Weaver was hurting you when I wasn't there. I didn't know. I should have, it's so obvious now. But even if I did…, I don't know if I could have done anything different. And I hate myself for that. And then *this* ?" she gestured to the sword, "I never wanted this. It called for me, it showed me what the Horde was doing. I have these visions, these *nightmares* , of what the Horde has done and I couldn't ever go back to that. I didn't leave *you* , I left the *Horde* . But then you wanted to stay and I just…, I got desperate."

Anger was slowly rising in Catra once more, "What… did you do, *Adora* ?"

"And we've been fighting for years. I just couldn't take it anymore! You were hurting thousands, TENS of thousands of people all

around you. You destroyed lands, poisoned resources, wreaked havoc wherever you went. What choice did I have! What choice did you leave me?"

"WHAT DID *YOU...DO!?"* Her hair began to stand on end.

"I had powerful enchantments placed on this temple. No matter what you do, what *anyone* does, in or out, the barrier can't be broken unless…, unless you forgive me for everything I've done to you." Adora looked down and away until she heard Catra huff followed by a incredulous laughter.

Catra cackled, "You're crazy… stupid and crazy!" She stood up and was ready to leave.

"I know it isn't easy to forgive me, to believe me, at all. That's why I pledge my loyalty to you. I'll do everything you say, without question, so long as I'm capable. I'll endure any punishment for as long as I can," Adora positioned herself to kowtow while offering the sword, with both hands, to Catra.

She was absolutely stunned. "You…," she huffed again, "You imprisoned me to *force* me to *forgive* you?" Adora remained silent with the sword still offered. Catra paced a step one way and then another step back. She scratched her scalp with both hands furiously and squinted hard to process this information, "You crazy, stupid, asshole. Unbelievable!" She kicked the sword out of Adora's hands, "I don't want your fucking, useless sword!" Catra was completely beside herself. She stomped off back to the bedroom but not before Adora shouted out.

Tears welling in her eyes, "What were you going to accomplish!? Huh!? You take Bright Moon! Then what!? Huh!? How 'bout the world!? You rule the world now, Catra, what next!?" She shuttered a cry and screamed louder, "YOU'D BE A SHITTY LEADER, CATRA. YOU'D CONQUER US ALL BUT YOU'D FAIL!"

Catra froze in place for a moment and then turned to storm right back. She grabbed Adora's jaw, "THIS!? Coming from someone

with the *WORST* judgement. STOP FOOLING YOURSELF, ADORA!" She pushed Adora's face away and spoke softer, "We are never getting out of here because I will *never* forgive you for *this* ," she threw her hands up referring to the imprisonment. "The only thing I can look forward to now is your punishment. So *stupid. "* And off she went, with nothing left to say.

Adora sniffed hard and tried to convince herself that her plan will work but confidence was swiftly fleeting. She needed to get her mind straight. She wiped the tears that seeped out. Her stomach began to grumble and whine as she had yet to eat. Exerting herself just moments before did not help either. As much as she wanted to just do nothing she forced herself to prepare another breakfast.

~oO0Oo~

Adora opted to finish a box of dehydrated food and went to see Catra. Their eyes immediately met when she approached the entrance. Catra furrowed her brows as she didn't want to see her. Catra's tone was still sour, "What is it now!? Your *master* would like some *privacy! "*

Adora pursed her lips at the constant resistance to talk with some civility, "If she so chooses, I will be on my way."

"THEN LEAV-"

"BUT," she quickly interrupted, "I would *advise* my master to consider touring the accommodations we have here so she isn't bored out of her mind." Adora held her glare waiting for her answer. It was going to be a year of hell but she still wanted to put in the effort. Maybe it was all for nothing. Maybe the world would need to wait for another She-Ra in a thousand years. The energy of the barrier would at least dissipate by at least half that time and another candidate could discover the fallen sword.

Civilization survived for this long without her, they can do it again. “Well? What does master choose?”

Catra looked at her, “What? No bow?”

Adora quickly rolled her eyes and performed an exaggerated bow toward her.

Catra got up from the bed and pushed Adora out of the way, “Fine, what do you want to show me first?”

Adora didn’t speak again. She only lead Catra back to the medical station. “I think it’s important that you understand how to use the equipment here. If…,” she didn’t want to continue, “if you intend to punish me, you’ll be responsible for putting me back together again.” Catra only flexed the bottoms of her eyelids. Adora continued to show what each item did and made sure Catra was paying attention as she was known to dissociate and bore easily. Her life literally depended on the accurate reception of her teachings. She talked about how to properly use the powdered crystals by using warm water to melt them rather than mashing them into a wound. She spoke of what to do if there was infection, the unlikelihood of disease, delirium, broken bones, and various other types of injuries. As a soldier, Catra knew what to do in most cases but handling the foreign, albeit advanced, equipment was another matter. After the very lengthy tutorial Catra groaned out of boredom.

Adora tsked, “Well, I wouldn’t have to explain everything if you knew how to read the instructions,” she pointed to the hieroglyphic inscriptions on the wall.

“ *Those* are instructions?”

“What, you thought those were just some ancient fables?” she scoffed, almost a laugh.

Catra grabbed her by the collar, “Are you in any position to mock me?”

Adora closed her eyes tightly and put up her hands, "No. I'm sorry. I forgot my place. May I continue?" Her eyes opened slowly to look for approval.

Catra let go, "Fine." She watched Adora tremble slightly when she touched and referenced the equipment that she assumed would be needed to heal her. She could see Adora was trying to be indifferent as she spoke but it could be heard in her voice. That familiar fear. The fear she once had as a child, trembling to the power of her abuser. "Stop! I need a break. Show me something else. I promise not to harm you in a way I won't know how to fix. Okay? I can't take anymore! UGH!"

Adora was both relieved and disturbed by this. Some of the equipment she already explained can heal terrible damage. Did Catra hate her that much? She forced herself not to think about it any longer than she already had. "Alright, does my master-"

"Shut *up* , Adora. Just say my name. You are *so* annoying!" Catra emphatically rolled her eyes along with her body.

"You haven't exactly given me any guidance on how to treat you. I was serious! I am at your will. And… and I'm actually scared. We were… we were so close," her voice trailed off with sadness that suggested how confused she was. How it was even possible to be apart at all. Adora looked at her with pleading eyes. She couldn't help it. It had been a very emotional few days. It had been an emotional few years. Constant war and finally she was able to talk with her for more than a few back and forth taunts and threats. It just poured out of her.

"No! Stop it," she waved a hand at her to drop the subject, "You want guidance? Then take me to a place where I can relax. Go!" She pointed to the doorway behind her.

Embarrassed, she turned her head to the side and lead the way to the pools. They had to pass through the entry hall to gain access to another hallway. Through there, they were able to enter a vast room with three different pools. There, the first pool, closest to

them on the left, was filled with floating flowers that had fallen from flowering vines above them. The walls grew bioluminescent shrubs that illuminated the room with a glow of pale orange and pink. The crystal clear water was cool to the touch and wrapped around the entirety of the left curve of the wall. As the wall curved inward, it led to another pool that bubbled slowly from flowing gases that escaped the heated vents in the rock-bedded floor. A unique moss, accented with a color of cinnabar, curled in various directions. It grew plentifully between the rock beds, cushioning the areas it flourished. And lastly was a small corner pool that rained a waterfall. The sound echoed through the room and the mist flowed softly across the room. The cool water seemed to flow into the calm pool to the left. Dead center of the room were stone shelves, artfully carved with ancient deco that housed soft towels, robes as soft as silk, and slippers. Beyond the shelf was a table, cushioned and shaped for lying down and being massaged. There were bowls and oils stocked next to dried and scented petals for mixing.

Catra raised her brows, " *This* is something I can get used to." Catra walked in and immediately felt the small spurts of cold from the waterfall as she walked by. With a scrunch of her nose, it was obvious she did not like this. She continued on towards the heated pool instead. She stood at the slope of the pool and stripped herself of her clothing. Adora stared. It was not as if she hadn't seen her without clothing before. The Horde didn't have much privacy. No, Adora stared because she was intrigued. It may possibly have been the first time she would witness Catra relax. But that was still yet to be seen; she still needed to get in.

"Are you coming?" a softened growl of her voice. She eased herself into the bubbling waters slowly and allowed her body to get used to the heat before submerging fully.

"I didn't think you wanted me near you," she looked away nervously.

She smirked, "Don't get your hopes up, you're going to make yourself useful and rub my head." She quickly became more

serious, “And as a reminder, it means *nothing* . Not like anyone else is here.”

Adora acknowledged and came to her. She took off her pants so she could rest her legs inside the pool and sat behind her. Catra sank herself until she was neck deep and rested her head against what seemed like a moss pillow. Adora positioned herself and hovered her hands over Catra’s head, unsure where to begin. She thought back to the days when she consoled her sobbing friend. It always made Catra feel better to stroke against her hair. She began with that. She was surprised how thick her hair had gotten. She worked through the thick strands and enjoyed the fact that her old methods still worked.

That was until, “I’m not that child, *Adora* . Try to be a little more creative.”

It panged her heart to hear Catra like this. Was she so set on being angry with her? Adora adjusted her strokes and fanned her fingers around and behind Catra’s ears, “Is this better?”

Catra sighed a little as she forced the rest of her muscles to relax, “It is…, good for you,” she patronized.

Adora concentrated at the task at hand. She reached behind Catra’s neck and dragged towards the top of her head with her hands alternating in succession. Catra’s head gently rocked back and forth.

She chuckled softly, “I’m surprised. You’re actually good at this.”

Adora was afraid to respond, she didn’t want to ruin the calm moment. The calm moment she doubted would happen often, if ever again. She continued and eventually moved on to stroking her ears. She gently let her fingertips drag against the edges and tugged lightly to a pinch. It brought a smile to Adora’s face. She didn’t care if it meant nothing to Catra. It meant something to Adora. Her fingers traveled to their next destination over her eyebrows and down her cheeks. She began to feel more

comfortable as she got into the groove of the task. If every day was like this moment, even if Catra didn’t reciprocate, she would not mind it at all. In time, came Catra’s soft breathing. The type that sighed gently, almost meditatively, and made the most pleasant of shushes. Catra was completely asleep and Adora was thrilled. It filled her with a sliver of hope that if Catra could relax to her touch that perhaps she could trust her more.

Adora ran her fingers through Catra's soft tufts of hair lazily just to feel its texture. She took the moment to pretend they weren't enemies and suddenly realized she'd need to do this to keep her sanity. If, in the worst case scenario, she fails to win Catra over, she'd have to spend every calm moment pretending their lives were always at peace. All the way up until they run out of food.

Her fingers began to tangle in her hair. Catra was getting too hot and sweat in response. It mildly alarmed Adora and she decided to wake her. She got up and stepped in front of her. She reached out and gently rubbed her cheek, “Catra?” she softly asked, “Catra, I think you should get out of the pool to cool down,” she rubbed her jawline a little harder. Catra gave a deeper breath through her nose and smiled ever so slightly as she woke to her touch. Adora rubbed her cheek with her thumb and cupped the rest of her face. As she gently jostled her head, she felt the smile widen in her hand. It was glorious until Catra opened her eyes. She quickly grabbed Adora's wrist and pushed it away. Adora stepped back with her hands up defensively again, “I just didn't want you to overheat. Okay?”

Catra stood up quickly in defiance but quickly felt light headed and her body just gave out. Adora lunged forward and caught her before Catra hit her head on the edge of the stony pool. “L-let go of me,” Catra tried to struggle against her but was too weak at the moment, “I don't need you to-”

Adora snapped back, “I'm not helping you, I'm serving my master. Shut up and let me get you out.” Adora lifted her, bridal style, and walked over to the massage table and carefully placed her on her side as not to accidentally crush her tail. “I'm going to get some

towels.” Adora quickly brought some over. She wiped and covered her.

A weak voice came out, “What’s in that water? What did you do to me?”

Adora huffed hard in disbelief, “Are you serious? You just spent too much time in there. Just relax a minute to cool down, you’ll be fine in a minute. I’ll get you some water.” She quickly grabbed a bowl from underneath the table and went to the falls. When she returned, she held Catra’s head up and pressed the bowl to her lips only for Catra to swat the bowl away. “Damn it, Catra! What now!?”

“ *You* drink it!” she snarled.

She grabbed another bowl while shaking her head and picked up the one on floor. She filled both, and again, she returned. She drank from the bowl quickly, spilling from the corners of her mouth and swallowed. She released an angered but satisfied “Ah,” and asked, “can you *please* drink now? It will make you feel better.” Catra looked away and returned to lock her eyes with Adora’s. She gave a single stern nod. “Good. Drink it slow.” Again, she lifted her head and pressed the bowl to her lips to sip from.

Catra could feel herself regaining her strength almost immediately. She could feel the fluid travel to her stomach and outward to the rest of her body.

“I’m sorry I didn’t get you out sooner,” Adora then spoke softer, “I had probably gotten used to it after what Shadow Weaver did to me.”

Catra found this peculiar, “Shadow Weaver?”

“I don’t want to talk about it. Are you feeling better?” Adora tried to dodge.

Catra sat up on her elbows, dropping the towel that covered her, “Oh no, we’re talking about it. *She* favored you the most. You’re

telling *me* she did something to *you* ?"

Adora swallowed hard, "Yes…, she did."

"Pff, like what?"

Adora closed her eyes, the memory now in full swing in her mind, "She made me run laps in what felt like boiling pools of polluted water whenever I failed to keep you out of trouble." She ground her teeth hard, "Whenever you didn't show up for training," she shuddered, "whenever you couldn't remember the answer to a question," she tightened her fits to her sides as her voice shook, "whenever all of us didn't do our training right." Without a word Adora rushed to grab her pants and stormed out of the room.

Catra watched her leave and muttered under her breath, "Yeah, right." *You can't make me feel sorry for you, no matter how hard you try.*

~oO0Oo~

Not far from the pools did Adora enter another room. It's purpose served to train or exercise or, if she so wished, vent. As it was the case, she did. The large, hollowed husks of fruit rind had hung from the stone ceiling to which Adora's fists pounded on until she tired. The voice of Shadow Weaver taunted her in her head, *Oh Adora, how you disappoint me. I thought you WANTED to be Force Captain.* Adora's breathing became heavy, not due to exhaustion, but fear. *If only you could JUST be BETTER! Why do you make me DO this Adora?* "STOP IT!" Adora screamed. She thought she spent enough time away from the Horde to no longer be haunted by these thoughts. She screamed louder and furiously punched. She had not worn any protection and her hands bruised to the point of bleeding against the thick rind. She could hear Shadow Weaver's tongue clicking in disappointment, *The Horde has such high hopes for you. If you'd JUST learn not to disappoint*

us. "FUCK YOU!" *Insolent child.* " *FUCK YOU!"* She screamed harder. Adora stopped and fell to her knees and then to her back. Her chest heaved, out of breath, and she was filled with regret. A few minutes of catching her breath she uttered, "I was right… to leave."

Catra entered wearing a white silken robe and found Adora lying on the ground. She stood over her. She looked down and spoke with a mocking tone, "Hey, Adora. Wow…, you're pretty fucked up."

Adora sat up quickly and rolled to a stand, "What do you want!?"

Catra placed a hand on her hip, "To finish the tour."

"In a minute. Please. I just need some time," she looked at Catra and waited for an approval. She didn't know whether to show she was so vulnerable or do what she was trained to do and hide how deeply hurt she is. She tried to push her feelings down, not for Catra, but to recover from her thoughts. She needed a distraction. Finishing the tour would help but Catra wouldn't.

Catra looked her over and watched a couple droplets of blood drip from Adora's knuckles that hadn't completely scabbed over yet. She saw the distraught face that looked back at her. It was a face of regret. "Fine. I'll give you a chance to clean up…," she waved a finger at Adora's hand, "that. Maybe you can clean up the mess in your room too. I'll be there when you're ready." Catra turned and quietly left with a soft swaying of her hips.

Adora looked at her hands and hadn't realized the damage done to them. She stamped a foot and spoke under her breath, "Damn it." it was one thing to show vulnerability but it was another to show Catra that she was not dealing well with the places her mind went.

~oO0Oo~

Adora washed up but didn't apply any bandages. It wasn't necessary. She went to a storage room that was next to the hallway bathroom nearest to the med station and retrieved a bag of some compost type substance and a large spatula item with towels. She walked into her room without knocking, without a word, and without looking at Catra who only raised a brow and traced Adora's path to the bloody mess on the floor. Adora lightly sprinkled the compost substance and let it sit a minute. She waited in silence with her back turned and hoped Catra would let her be.

But, of course, she didn't, "Dirty Dora." Adora snapped her head towards Catra angrily. Eyebrows knitted and furrowed and her glare displayed just how offended she truly was. Those words hurt more than the wounds she received the night before. Catra continued, "That's when it happened, didn't it?" It wasn't a taunt. It was just something she surmised. When they were children, the squad was surprised to find a horrendous smell when they woke up and discovered it radiated from Adora from time to time, thus the name.

Adora turned back to the mess and began scraping at it with angered ferocity. After the blood stain came up, she wiped it with towels to get the remaining residue. When she was done, she carried it out but not before telling Catra never to speak of that again, "I know what I said earlier. I meant it, I'm loyal to you, I'll take my punishments, and I will never lie, but *that* is off limits," she looked at Catra with a promise that she wouldn't allow her to bring up the subject ever again.

Catra only looked back with a dismissive glare. After little hesitation, she flexed her brows, "Whatever."

"I'll be back in fifteen minutes to finish the tour," Adora bent down and grabbed the door and raised it shut. She went to the dining hall to clean up the messes there as well. She thought it would clear her head but the mundane task only made her mind race

more, *How dare she say that name! How do you think I felt? HOW DO YOU THINK I FELT!* She caught herself wiping the table too hard and tried to force herself to think about anything else until she heard a door open in the distance, *I can't deal with this now.*

Catra's toenails clicked against the floor as she walked and as she got closer, Adora tensed. The slow striding approach that Adora knew was unavoidable. "Hey. Show me where I can find those tasteless water-bricks and you can have the rest of the day to yourself."

She was a little shocked Catra would be so kind but she agreed nonetheless, "I'll show you where everything is stocked" Adora threw a rag she'd been using on the table and left with Catra. She took her to a large door and used both her hands to drag it down. It revealed a large warehouse-like space. Shelves were filled with dried food of various kinds of breads, fruits, vegetables, and meats. If it could be dried, it was there.

She stared in and tried to calculate, "How long are these supposed to last?"

Adora hesitated but spoke before Catra lost her patience, "About a year."

Catra muttered the same words back. She pressed her lips together hard and nodded to herself. She flexed her brows, "You can leave now."

"Right," came a whisper. It was obvious, no matter the time span, the news was never going to be light enough to receive. Adora would deal with it, and similarly, so would Catra.

~oO0Oo~

It had been several hours and Adora had finished cleaning the dining hall and the medical station. She started to get hungry and thought to get some food for herself but didn't want to risk bumping into Catra again. Some distance, she thought, might be good for today. She convinced herself it was unlikely she'd be around. She passed by Catra's room and realized she still hadn't shown her. She sighed and decided not to delay any longer despite her need to stay away. She went to her room but Catra wasn't there. She searched each door down the hall until she came back to the stock of food and supplies.

She went down an isle. She looked left and right, and knowing her, up. She called out, "Catra? You in here?" No response. She went down a few more isles, "Catra!?" She stopped looking and headed for the door until she heard a very gentle thump behind her.

"What?" she said dryly.

"Gah! Nothing… I mean, hi, um…," she tilted her head, "Have you been here the whole time?"

"What of it?"

Adora cleared her throat, shook her head dismissively, and thought to get back to the reason why she wanted to see her, "I realize I still haven't shown you your room. Do you want to see it? I won't bother you anymore."

She eye-rolled, "Pff, sure."

"Okay." She headed to the door, "Follow me."

~oO0Oo~

She stopped at the door and paused a moment. “Before I open this, I just want to say I-I tried to think of you. I um, I don't want you to think- I was trying really hard to accommodate for all your needs.”

She narrowed her eyes, “Adora? Why are you being weird?”

“I just don't want you to be offended,” Adora quickly got out.

Catra shook her head like Adora was crazy as her eyes closed and opened wide, “Just open it.”

Adora dragged the door down and let Catra enter. The room was gargantuan. The floor shined in the grain of the glossy marble floor. A staircase hugged the curved wall on the right and then just stopped. Then, onward, looking up were platforms that protruded from the walls as it curved around. Higher and higher it went. Between them and all around were poles and cables that looped to be swung on. On floor level were large heated stones from the temple's energy. Pillows and cushions from Bright Moon's palace littered the area. On the left wall were books housed in in-wall shelves. Catra was never interested in reading, but given she was unable to leave, her mind would be the only place she could escape. Adora truly tried to think of everything.

Catra looked around, expressionless, and took a few more steps in. She noticed there were stone columns that didn't have the distinct smoothness the rest of the temple had. In fact, they were quite rough to the touch. Catra approached one and placed a hand on one and then was compelled to drag her claws down. She gave a subtle shiver and tried to hide how much she enjoyed the feeling.

Just as dry as before and without facing Adora, “You built this room for me?”

“Yes…, I did. I really didn't want this to be a priso-”

“Shush!” She placed her hand on the column again and dragged down slowly. She remained still for a moment, “Why didn't you

eat? I can hear you grumbling. It's annoying."

Adora held her stomach with a hand, "I wanted to show you this first."

"Go…, and close the door on your way out."

Adora silently left and closed the door. She couldn't help spend time dissecting Catra's reaction to the room. Her voice was cold but the obvious reuse of the column made her more confident Catra liked it. She wondered, now, if she'll ever talk to her again. Catra had enough knowledge to explore the temple herself. If she had questions, Adora would obviously be available. But besides quick understandings of how something might work didn't make being with her easier. And then, after a year, that's it. Complete failure.

After cooking and eating her meal she was still lost on what to do next. She allowed more time for her thoughts to wander. Occasionally, her free thought would give her an idea. But it was not the case now, "I need to lie down." A decision in response to the lack of ideas in the dining hall.

She made her way to her bedroom but found her bed missing. Adora, stood there frozen. She was still processing the missing bed. Did Catra hate her room so much that she had to take away her bed? That's ludicrous!

"CATRA!" she shouted from her room. No reply was the obvious response. Adora stormed off and knocked hard on Catra's door. "Catra! Come on! If you didn't like the room, we could have just switched!" a moment passed, "Catr-"

The door opened, "Hey Adora."

"I'm *sorry!* I *thought* you'd like it. Did you *really* have to take my bed?" Adora outstretched her arm in the direction of her room.

A twitched ear, "Yes."

Adora pleaded, “Can I please have it back? I can try to make your room better.”

“Sure.”

Adora was a little confused and tried to stay calm, “O…kay, where can I find it?”

Catra turned away and went up the stairs but pointed to the center of the room on the floor, “Right there but you aren't moving it back.” Before Adora could say anything Catra jumped from platform to platform until she reached the highest. She shouted down, “Now, don't bother me!”

Adora continued to blink in confusion but convinced herself it was okay to approach the bed. She didn't see any pillows and decided to get them later. She lain herself to rest and closed her eyes until a pillow landed right on her face with a loud - *paff* -

“BAH!” Adora sat up quickly and was startled by the attack. She could hear Catra cackling in the distance. Adora only groaned, but at least, now, she had a pillow.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much for reading. Thank you to those who have given me feedback! I really appreciate it! Again, please let me know if something seems off or starting to deviate away from what you were expecting/wanting - I am one who does welcome negative (constructive) reviews.

I have 6 chapters written so far, working on my 7th which should be posted on Monday Evening. I aim to do weekly updates until my fic is done but it is likely to be every other week. I'll post a chapter a day until I have nothing left in queue.

You can follow me on twitter or tumblr (same name) for "she-ra deep (utterly stupid and silly) thoughts" and updates so you aren't left wondering when the next chapter will be out.

Chapter 03

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora woke. Another morning with Catra at the foot of her bed again. It had been three weeks and four days since she'd moved into Catra's room, still uncertain why. Catra still remained cold and distant to her up until it was time to sleep. Adora would be in bed, alone, while Catra stayed in the high platforms and only when she woke had Catra appeared by her feet again. Perhaps it was just a habit neither of them could break. Perhaps it had been the first time either of them had been able to sleep in a long time.

Adora took a deep breath and stretched as she normally does each morning. She smiled at the scratching columns behind her. The damage on them, as they slowly got more noticeable, showed Catra used them frequently, albeit secretly. She held her smile a little too long as she was hit in the face with a pillow, "Hey!"

"You're being weird again, Adora!" Catra narrowed her eyes at her. She did her own stretch routine as she was waking up.

She looked around sheepishly, "I-I uh I wasn't- I didn't say anything." She sat up on the side of the bed with a shifting of her eyes

Catra did the same next to her, "Just get breakfast ready."

Adora rubbed her tired eyes and cleared her throat. She looked at Catra and bumped against her shoulder which earned her a sharp glare, "Hey, I'm glad you like them."

Catra got off the bed with a bit of irritation, "Whatever."

Adora didn't let it get to her. What did eat at her was that there had been no progress since the start and she had yet to broach the subject, any subject, to get a conversation going. She just

wanted to talk to her, with her, and everything in between but wasn't yet ready to try to initiate it. Instead, she did what she was told. As she went off to make breakfast, she could only hope Bright Moon was making better progress than she was.

~oO0Oo~

"GLIMMER!" Bow shouted at her as she blinked out of existence. Four Horde soldiers surrounded and pointed their weapons at him. He took a defensive stance and prepared to fight until his last, abled breath. *Glimmerrrr, any time now.* Out of arrows, he tried to calculate who first he'd attack and who first would attack. Two of the soldiers opened a space in front of him as their commander stepped forward. Scorpia approached him happily. Genuinely cheerful to greet him, "Hi, Bow!" She gave a small wave with her claw.

Bow relaxed ever so slightly. He was not going to win a fight with Scorpia and was now preparing for the venomous sting from her tail. He responded weakly, "Hi, Scorpia. Like I told you last time, we don't know where Catra is. And, if you've noticed, Adora isn't around either." He forced and pleaded a smile, "Think you could…, I dunno…, let me go? Maaaybe stop attacking us?" He paused a moment, "You know?"

She let out a cheerful laugh, "HA! I like you, Bow, I do. You're the funny one. And yeah! I did notice that!" another laugh, "Buuut, I know you're lying-"

"Only partially!" he defended, "We *really* don't have Catra!"

She took a step closer to him and held her smile, "But you know where she is and I have a *good* feeling you know where Adora is too."

He held his hands defensively and nervously, "Only sort of!"

She raised her tail while she held that gleeful smile and chuckled, “Sssstart talkin’”

“Do you *have* to sting me with that *every* time?” His voice cracked a little as it rose in scale.

“I mean,” she chortles, “ya! That's kinda my thing. You take us to her, we let you go, everything will be fine, no big. I mean… unless Catra wants to use you as a tactical advantage. *She* is *really* good at that. Did you know she had already planned for the next ten attacks. She's really smart!” She laughed adoringly. “Anyway,” she nudged her head toward her waving tail, “What's it going to be?”

Bow tensed up and squinted hard and prepared himself for the inevitable. He hummed a groan as he remained loyal to Bright Moon and Adora.

Scorpia shrugged and spoke with a sing-song voice, “O… kay.” She lingered on the word as she brought her tail back. Bow groaned out louder, knowing full well it was coming. The forward swing came fast but hit nothing. “Hey, where’d he go?” She and the small squad looked around pointing their weapons in the direction of their aimless search.

Bow suddenly felt tree bark on his back and legs. He opened his eyes and gasped. He was about to shout but a hand quickly covered his mouth and could only muffle a “GIMMRR!”

“Quiet!” she loudly whispered, “We aren't far from them, I just… I just don't have the energy.” She was breathing deeply and heavily. She then heard the Horde squad on the move. Glimmer peeked around the tree and her heart could only skip as Scorpia appeared to lock eyes directly at her and smirk. Glimmer froze her glare and clung a little harder to Bow. She watched them march on.

“Glimmer, what is it?” he whispered with worry.

“Shh, it's nothing.” *I hope.* “We need to find a way back. I can't-I can't do much more.” She took a few more breaths. “I need to

recharge and you need to resupply.” She closed her eyes, “I just need to catch my breath.”

Sounds of the ground crunching underneath heavy tanks sent shivers down their spines. The destruction the Horde left behind, their advancement closer and closer to Bright Moon, it felt as if they were going to lose this time. They needed She-Ra. Bow reflected on this, “I hope Adora's doing better than we are.”

Glimmer shuttered a, “Yeah, me too.”

~oO0Oo~

A few more weeks of the same thing. The bitterness from Catra never getting any sweeter. Adora couldn't believe she could hold such a grudge against her so strongly. She thought to re-enter the temple's library to see if the if there were any ancient scriptures on how to resolve conflicts. She thought to check with Catra first if she wanted any books or, in the off chance, she'd want to join her. “Caaaatraaaa,” Adora called out lazily in her room, “I'm going to the library, you want me to get you anything?” she then muttered under her breath, “Maybe something on talking to an old friend… or forgiveness…”

Catra met face to face with Adora upside down as she hung from a low hanging pole. Adora stepped back, mildly startled by the not-entirely-unexpected encounter. It seemed Catra did this often. And, with her usual sourness, “No.” She did a sit up and dismissed her.

“Maybe you'd like to go with me?”

Quickly, “No.”

Adora whined, “Caaatraaa! Come on! Are you going to be angry with me the whole time?”

Catra came down and walked up to her with a clawed finger to Adora's forehead, "Ya… I thought it was pretty obvious," she then flicked her nail and pushed Adora aside and left the room, "I'm going to the pools. You do… whatever."

Adora sighed at how frustrating it all was. She gave Catra some distance and eventually went off to the library by herself. She didn't expect to find anything useful. She only wanted an excuse to invite Catra to do something with her.

The amount of remaining supplies hung on her mind. They had enough to last another ten months which was exactly on par with how they've been managing their diet. The problem was the daunting absence of food as they worked their way through it. The sheer lack of progress with Catra was more than a little worrying. Was Catra so hard set on starving to death? The only thing Adora was particularly thankful for, when she combed through ancient scripts on diplomacy, was that she had yet to be punished. Catra's voice echoed in her mind, *You never did have any faith in me.* Adora didn't think much of those words right away. She was part of the Horde. *Leading* them no less. She became more ferocious in battle. She was accomplishing her nefarious goals. What was she supposed to think of her friend?

Then it hit her. She never had faith in her friend. And how it hit her hard. When she was with the Horde, Adora remembered that she never trusted her *best* friend, her girlfriend. She *did* think she was second best. She considered this was due to Shadow Weaver's influence, but even if it was, the fact of the matter was, Catra grew up with no one believing in her. Adora cringed to herself in front of the vast shelves in the temple library.

She dropped the book in hand and hastily went to the pools. She looked straight ahead when she entered but didn't see Catra in the bubbling pools. A quick, "Hey, Adora," directed her attention to the cooler, calm pool to the left of the entrance. A subtle but clearly confused look appeared on Adora's face to the unexpected location. Catra didn't like cold…, right? "Yeah, it's actually pretty refreshing, you should try it."

Adora, while still completely clothed, walked into the cool water towards Catra.

“Adora! I didn't mean *this* second!”

Adora placed her hands on Catra’s bare shoulders and looked directly into those two toned globes, “I'm sorry. I'm sorry I didn't believe in you.”

Catra attempted to push her back, “Well, it's a little la-”

“No!” She gripped her shoulders tighter, “I'm sorry I thought you would punish me, how I feared you. I'm sorry. I'm sorry I'm so easily fooled. I'm sorry I didn't understand.” She stared into her eyes until Catra spoke.

“Are you done?” Catra did punish Adora, her tongue could inflict wounds that would leave long lasting scars. Adora shook her head subtly.

“I'm sorry I thought you were the same girl that needed healing when it's me that's been dying to have your affection. I'm… I'm- I'm sorry I trapped us here,” tears began to pool, “I should have proposed a truce, I should have tried harder to talk to you. I shouldn't have done *this!* ”

Still emotionless, “ *Now* , are you done?”

Adora took her hands off Catra's shoulders slowly and buried her own face in them instead. She gave a nod and heard Catra slowly getting out of the water. Adora just stood still in the cold water, hands limp to her sides, and stared at the floating flowers as they trailed Catra’s exiting path. A shiver ran down her body and she finally made herself move. She took off her wet clothing and opted for the robe. She was so easily dismissed when she poured her heart out. It left her hollow. It was unbearably difficult to process. She exited the pools and made her way to the bathroom to shower. There, she silently let her mind drift and reflected on what just happened.

~oO0Oo~

Catra peeked over her high platform that evening and saw that the key owner of the bed below was missing. She grumbled that she ‘didn't care’ to herself but it left her restless.

The following day, Catra continued her routine. When she was hungry, Adora made food. When she made a mess, Adora cleaned. When she wanted to relax, Adora massaged. But when she slept, Adora was not in her room. This continued for seventeen more days until Catra was too miffed to take another night alone. She went off to search for Adora in the middle of the night with a quick stomping stride.

Off she went to Adora's old room with brows furrowed and eyes searching. She entered the room and found it empty. She checked the med station, the supply room, dining hall, one by one, and couldn't find her. She continued to the library and finally found Adora hunched over whilst sleeping over a book. Catra pursed her lips just before slamming her hand to wake Adora. Her hand went down with a “Wap!” and Adora's head flung to a rise.

“What!? What!? Nothing! What?” she sniffed a deep breath, “I'm up! I'll get breakfast!” Her head drooped with her eyes closing.

Catra slammed her hand in the table again, “Adora!”

“Gah! What!?” Her head sprang up as it did before. “Stop doing that!”

Catra looked at her sternly, “Go… to...BED!”

Adora took a deep breath but calmly answered, “No.” She rubbed her eyes with her palms.

“ *Wh* at?” she spoke through gritted teeth and leaned in.

Another breath, Adora turned to face her with the same answer, “No.”

Catra tilted her neck and looked ready to pounce, “Looks like you're breaking your promise to me.”

“I'm not.” She stood up, causing Catra to rise as well. She met her gaze without fear.

Catra reiterated her initial command, “Then go to bed.”

“I can't,” was her simple and calm response.

The tension in the air was getting thicker by the second. Catra’s muscles tensed and she scratched her nails against the table without looking away, “Explain exactly how disobeying me is not breaking your promise.”

“I *will* do everything you ask of me, IF I'm capable. I told you I'll endure your punishment for as long as I can. I can't now. I can't be near you like *this* . *I* said you'll be responsible for putting me back together again. And…, until then…, I'll be here,” Adora sat back down and flipped through a few pages of her book while Catra fumed beside her. She was somewhat fearful that Catra would attack her but a part of her was confident she wouldn’t. Catra tried to think of a way to show dominance but all she managed to do was create more wrinkles on her forehead.

Catra finally broke her silence, “What do you want?” again, through gritted teeth.

Adora stopped reading. She hid her surprise that Catra was willing to listen. She turned to her and looked up without trying to be demanding and she offered what she needed, “I need us to talk, Catra, and if you want me back in your room, I need to hold you to sleep or be held. It doesn't matter but this edge of the bed thing when I'm already asleep is bullshit. I know what you're doing and there's no need to lie to me.” She turned away and went back to the book. She spoke over her shoulder, “But I won't fight you if you say no. If you care for me, even just a little, you'll

let me heal, either this way," she waved her hand over the book, "or you agree to my proposal."

Catra continued to process the undeniably ballsy demand. "You want me to talk?"

Without looking and as if to speak to the book she was pretending to pay attention to, "No lying either. I want an honest conversation with you. If we don't, we'll go insane. It's part of the reason why I'm here." She didn't dare look at Catra yet. She knew if she did, she'd make Catra think she was manipulating her by attempting to show some form of superiority. She wanted to make sure she was not seen as her captor. She turned a page she'd been skimming. It was a First One's book about portals. She had several books piled on top of each other as well. Some of them even Catra could read. Although, Catra hadn't noticed the one about heartbreak.

It took about two minutes before Catra spoke again and Adora just simply read to pass the time. It was a quiet and angered, "Fine," almost like she'd been defeated. Her ears fluttered and twitched briefly as she held in her irritation. She didn't feel in control despite never really losing it. "I… will hold you." She faced away, unable to look in Adora's direction.

Adora wasn't sure she heard right and remained still. She tried to push down her beating heart as the words, 'I will hold you', were repeated in her head. She smoothed out a page of the book in front of her with a gentle hand and got up. She looked in Catra's eyes from the side as Catra's head was still turned away, "Thank you."

A very unconvincing, "It-it doesn't mean anything," came out.

Adora didn't push her. She only responded with a gentle, "Maybe. But it means a lot to me and I appreciate it." A beat, "I'm going to wash up. I'll be right there in a few minutes. I also want to make a final note on something interesting - if that's okay with you." She wanted to allow Catra some space and avoid a lengthy and

awkward walk back to the bedroom together. She also wanted to celebrate in secrecy. It was unknown how much longer she could suppress the smile that had been fighting her lips since Catra's agreement. She truly did not have any expectation she'd find herself back in Catra's room again. It wasn't just thrilling, it was an enormous relief. Sleeping over a table and books did a number to her back and now she'd finally be able to sleep in a normal bed. The feeling was overwhelming.

Catra tsked, "Don't be long." Her voice was still sour but, to Adora, it no longer mattered.

The very moment Catra left the library Adora could hardly contain herself. Her eyes began to tear but she quickly stopped herself should Catra turn around for any reason and catch her. But, she was happy. *She cares! She actually does!* She took a deep breath. *Nineteen days, I didn't even think I could last that long.* She let out that breath slowly. She made her needed note from the book and left to go wash herself.

~oO0Oo~

Catra was already in bed when Adora arrived. Neither of them could make eye contact as Adora approached. Adora thought it would be similar to the times before and she'd crawl into bed first and allow Catra to come down from whatever platform she perched from. Not this time. Catra took Adora's words seriously but her eyes remained on the pillow. Adora somewhat froze and took longer to get in than expected.

Catra seemed to exhale a word to Adora, "Sit."

Adora then rolled into bed without a word. Her head gently rested on the pillow and it was only a short moment before she felt an arm wrap around her waist. Catra pulled her in tighter to get more comfortable and rested her face against the back of Adora's head.

One thing Adora definitely had not expected was Catra's tail resting on her hip. Adora tensed momentarily as she felt the tip of Catra's tail wag softly against her pelvis. Then, Adora just melted. Catra felt every muscle in Adora's body soften against hers and oddly it felt comforting. Both of them, within a few minutes, had drifted off to sleep.

~oO0Oo~

Catra woke first but she did not move from her pillow. Instead she watched Adora sleep. She softly raked the ends of Adora's hair through her fingers as she watched Adora's face exude a sense of peace with its stillness. Catra was conflicted with a feeling of desire and repulsion. Of course she wanted Adora in her life but her level of ignorance was unforgivable. Catra stared at Adora's closed eyes and was prepared to quickly leave should they open. But for now, she watched and occasionally pulled Adora's blonde strands to her nose. It was toxic to be with her, this close, and it was toxic being apart. Adora's words repeated in her mind, *If you care for me, even just a little, you'll let me heal.* Catra couldn't help but think what an unbelievable asshole Adora was.

Adora suddenly took a deep waking breath, wrapped her arms around Catra and held her in tight as she stretched her legs. Her eyes fluttered open to see Catra's wide-eyed glare staring in return. Adora nudged Catra back, "I'm sorry," a brief pause, "I'll get breakfast ready." Adora quickly got up and noticed the continued glare from Catra. Adora's eyes bounced around the floor, the bed, Catra, and the doorway unsure if she should apologize again. She said nothing and hastily exited.

~oO0Oo~

Catra sat in the dining hall and Adora eventually came in with breakfast, "Made our favorite tasteless and bland eggs." Adora set Catra's dish down first but continued to hold hers, "Can I… eat with you?"

Catra raised her eyes as she stuck a fork in her food, "You wanted to talk, didn't you?"

"It doesn't have to be now," she shrugged, "I want *us* to talk… about anything." She continued to stand there, waiting, awkwardly, to be dismissed or invited.

"Just sit, Adora." How it annoyed her to ask permission for everything. She watched Adora sit and it was suddenly more uncomfortable for the both of them. What to talk about? Everything seemed like an awkward and awful choice that would trigger some unnecessary argument. Catra took the 'attack the elephant with fire' approach, "Do you want to talk about *it* ?"

Adora was trying her best to play it safe and casual. She thought to herself, *Heard any new music over the years? How's Lonnie been? Pretty crazy couple years, right? But no, had to throw it out there.* "Only if you're comfortable talking abou-"

"I'm not, Adora. At no time will I be comfortable. But the last thing I want to do is spend the remaining months we have tiptoeing around the subject…," she rolled her eyes and added an emphatic 's'. "So, get to it."

Adora arched her head back and wished it could have been more pleasant. More tiptoeing wouldn't have been so bad. "Fine," she exhaled. "I *want* to start over," Adora quickly continued before Catra could jump in, "WHICH I *know* is impossible. I really messed up…, obviously."

A sarcastic, "Ya..., y'did," quickly followed.

Adora tightened a corner of her mouth but continued anyway, "I *thought* I could make it up to you. I really did. I told you, I'm sorry for being so stupid. I know I'm wrong. That's at *least*

progress, *right* ?" Catra stared blankly back at her without answering, "I never wanted to hurt you and I *thought* you'd just come with me. I saw an opportunity, for *us, not* just me. Look, I didn't know how to handle it all."

Catra huffed expressionless, "And if I wasn't sent to get you, assuming we're talking about you," she finger quoted, "'leaving the Horde', how were you going to get me?"

Adora threw her hands to the side, "I don't know, Catra! You were already there. I didn't have a *chance* to even think that far ahead." *You can't cut me a LITTLE slack?* "What would you have done if a magical sword was in your *head,* telling you to find it? I thought I was going crazy! I didn't want you getting hurt because I might have been hallucinating."

Catra rested her arms on the table, "What would I have done? Really? *First,* I would have taken you with me so that I wouldn't die alone in the woods because of a *possible* hallucination." She looked at Adora like it was obvious. "If I found the damn thing, I'd make damn sure you saw it too. Whatever it was, we'd do it together."

Adora quickly snapped, "Shadow Weaver said I needed to keep you out of trouble! *That* was trouble."

"Since when did we ever listen to Shadow Weaver?"

Adora's heart felt as if punched. "I'm sorry." She picked up her plate and got up, "Th-thank you for talking to me," she said with a quiver in her voice. She exited the dining hall and went to the library as quickly as she could. Adora couldn't continue any longer. It would be one stab in the heart after another if she did.

~oO0Oo~

Adora tried to suppress her sniffles and gasping cries. *Well, that went terribly.* She tried to force herself to read the book on creating portals but her vision blurred the more her tears formed. She pounded a fist on the table out of frustration and caused the plate of food to jump. She took deep breaths to calm herself. The chores, the solitude, the constant negative and toxic feedback was not making her well. She pushed away a pile of books and opened another, *Failure is just a step towards success. Don't give up. We learn and we always remember, 'I don't want to be THAT person. I want to be better. And I will!'* She wiped her tears away with the palms of her hands and sniffed hard.

"What are you doing here, Adora?" Catra entered the library

Adora could only jump at the unexpected walk-in. She her hands balled into a fist. Frustrated. Embarrassed. Heartbroken. " *Trying* to be better." She snapped her head towards Catra with bloodshot eyes, "Is that okay with *you* ?"

"Sure," she said dismissively. "Adora?"

Right this second was not the time Adora wanted to talk. A couple more breaths to steady herself, "Yes?"

Her head tilted toward a shoulder, "What did you honestly hope to accomplish here? Months and months of being with you, I'd become so desperate that I'd just fall into your arms? The Evil Horde's *veil* over my eyes would be lifted?"

"Please stop." A drop in her voice as it escaped her breath.

Catra took a few steps closer to her and continued, "That without me on the battlefield, you'd have a tactical advantage? I didn't do much and there's worse than me out there."

"Catra…"

She did not cease, "Being my dumb, obedient servant for a year would ever make up for complete obliteration of our relationship?"

Tears seemed to stream from Adora's eyes, "I FUCKED UP!" she screamed at her.

Catra's expression completely unfazed, "Like I said, 'Ya…, y'did.'" Catra turned around and walked casually to the exit, "Nice talk, we should do it again some time."

Before Catra could reach the doorway, Adora stomped quickly to her and shoved her hard. Catra flipped and rolled on the floor. She immediately spun to get up and brandished her claws. Adora gasped before shouting, "HOW DOES *THIS* HELP!? I'M *TRYING* TO BE BETTER FOR YOU!" No longer could she hold back her cries, "WHAT ARE *YOU* DOING!? ATTACKING INNOCENT LIVES OVER A *FUCKING* GRUDGE!" She sobbed harder and her voice became hoarse from screaming, "YOU WEREN'T THE ONLY ONE THAT WAS HURT! YOU WEREN'T THE ONLY ONE WHO COULDN'T UNDERSTAND WHY IT HAD TO BE THIS WAY!" She collapsed to her knees and covered her face.

Catra was frozen, stunned, and further hurt. Adora fell apart in front of her and she didn't want to admit in the slightest that Adora was right. She pursued a path of power the only way she knew how. So long as Adora wasn't there, she felt accomplished in manipulating others and getting closer to the top through destruction. A very small smidge of guilt had crept through. She questioned if she could have done something different. She questioned if it even mattered now. The worst of it was the fact that she meant every word. Being a servant was stupid, expecting forgiveness by forcing it was even dumber. By putting the needs of strangers she just met above their relationship since childhood was positively unjustified. And yet, that guilt grew.

She approached Adora and placed a hand on her shoulder but was quickly swatted away. Adora screamed, "DON'T TOUCH ME!"

Shame consumed her and she noted, *So that's what that feels like.* She slowly turned away with a saddened frown and walked off. She left Adora, alone, to sob at the doorway. Even farther down, she could hear her cries echo through the halls as if

inescapable. As if to invade her mind and remind her of the pain she just dealt.

~oO0Oo~

Alone again in her room, Catra paced anxiously as she did for the past two weeks since “the talk.” Unable to sleep without Adora. Unable to eat regularly. She hadn't even used her scratching posts. Every day, between the both of them, had been an artful skill of avoiding each other. Adora was no longer a servant. She didn't cook or clean for Catra or see her in the pools. And Catra didn't demand her to be around either. But the one thing that truly weighed on Catra’s mind was that damn bed in the center of her room. Adora was still sleeping in the library. Why she didn't sleep in the med station or somewhere more comfortable than hunched over a table was unknown to her. And she checked, every night, sneaking around to see if she was still physically alright. She couldn't take it anymore!

She opened her door and went back to the bed and began to drag it out. She stopped in the hallway and looked left towards Adora's old bedroom. She gripped the post on the bed and gave it a small tug but then stopped. *Damn it!* she screamed internally. She looked the other way towards the entrance hall and began dragging. With the floor no longer as smooth as her room, the bed screamed in agony against the friction. As she neared the library, her emotions transitioned between anger, hurt, and guilt. Adora’s earlier cries wrang in her head down the long hall. She didn't want to feel this way any more. She was sick of it now. The howling of the bed being dragged mimicked the struggle of her life. She opened the library door and it seemed to scream a whisper against the smoother floor and it now stood there, like Catra, only a few feet away from Adora's stunned face.

Adora froze not to the appearance of the bed but to Catra's teary face. Catra stood there not knowing what to do. Her tears seemed to flood her eyes now. No sense holding back. Catra opened her mouth to speak and at first came nothing. She swallowed and forced herself, “P-please just s-sleep…,” she sniffed hard, “w-with me.”

Chapter End Notes

> So, I did not know notes stack on top of each other. I thought it would be isolated for each chapter. I will try to keep my end notes to a minimum as I don't want the end of each chapter to start looking ugly.
>
> Let me know if there is something here that's preventing you from adding this to your subscriptions. I definitely want to hold your interest! For those already loving it, Thank you! Thank you! :)

Chapter 04

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora walked slowly and cautiously to Catra and wrapped her arms around her shoulders. She held her tight as she felt the hug returned. She allowed Catra some time before speaking. She waited until Catra's shuddering chest calmed and the hot breath against her neck to slow. Adora whispered, "I don't want to hurt you Catra, I never want to hurt you, but…, but you can't be here." She felt Catra's arms tighten around her body. "I have to work, Catra." She raked her hands through Catra's hair. "I need to study."

Catra loosened her squeeze around Adora, "I-I don't understand. Study what?" She took a deep trembling breath and exhaled slowly. She released Adora to look at her.

"I might have found a way out," her voice still soft but she did not reciprocate the emotional exchange Catra had. It wasn't cold but it didn't hold the need for Catra's affection any longer. It was as if she gave up. She reiterated, "I *might* have."

Catra's eyes darted between each of Adora's, searching for sincerity. A shred of hope to escape, "H-how?"

"I'm not making any promises, but these books…, there's teachings of making portals. I can't but She-Ra might be able to use the power of the sword to get you out. Look, Catra, you can't be here. Please go back to your room." Adora waited firmly. She was not open to having a fight but she wasn't open to the emotional toxicity that often came from being together. It was clear to her now, away was better than together. "Thank you for bringing the bed, Catra. I do appreciate it."

Catra closed her eyes and held in the pain, "So, that's it, then?"

Adora sighed, knowing she wasn't going to escape this. She didn't want Catra hurt but she didn't want to be dragged down either. Their last encounter had opened new wounds that were still healing. She marked a note beside a book and invited Catra to sit on the bed with an outstretched hand to it. She waited for Catra to sit before speaking. "I don't know what either of us want. We need to have a serious conversation about *us* but I can't handle it. I can't handle what might come of it. I'm tired of pointing fingers. I'm tired of making mistakes. I'm so tired. Right now, we're not good for each other." Catra remained silent as her brows knitted sadly. Tears began to fill her eyes again as Adora continued. "I don't know what you want," she reiterated, "If it's me back at the Horde, I'm not doing that. I can't. I would love for you to join us instead and *fight* the Horde. But you don't want to. That's your choice but that won't make *us* work." Adora rubbed her face. She was exhausted but she made one last effort, "We could take neutral ground. Be together, neither of us taking sides, but then…, then I'm back to being old Adora, abandoning friends just like I abandoned you," she came nearly to a whisper, "I don't want to be that person anymore."

Catra's voice seemed to croak out, "You want to be *better* ." Adora nodded subtly. Catra looked at the books on the table and then back at Adora, "How long?"

Adora, too, glanced in the direction Catra was looking, "I don't know. I'm just hoping I can get you out before the food runs-"

"How long before I can talk to you again?" Her teary eyes looked back into Adora's.

"Oh…," it had caught her off guard. "Um, why don't you let me come to you?"

A cracked whisper was all Catra could muster, "Fine."

Catra was about to get up to leave but Adora had one last thing to say. She tried to look encouraging, she tried to make it sound like it was not a conversation about giving up even though a part of

her - only a small part - already had. “Let’s...let’s take this time to think about what to say to each other. Figure out what we want. You know, figure out if we’re just wanting the old versions of ourselves. I promise we’ll talk again.” With a silent nod, Catra left the room but not without Adora hearing the quiet grunt in her throat to stop a cry.

~oO0Oo~

Two guards ran down the hall towards Bright Moon's queen. Their armor clattered loudly with each foot fall. Upon finally reaching her presence they quickly bowed down to a knee, “Your Majesty, a Horde soldier approaches. She appears unarmed and traveling alone. We have several lookouts to see if there are others hiding.”

Queen Angella held her gaze to think. She extended a hand and gently flexed her fingers up, “Rise,” they did, “Do we know who it is?”

“The soldier is unmistakably Scorpia. She walks to us with arms in air.” They remained stiff and awaited their orders.

The queen stood from her throne and descended down the hovering steps, “Summon my daughter, Bow, Perfuma, and… Kyle.”

The guards gave the briefest of hesitation upon hearing of Kyle but quickly hastened to carry out her order.

~oO0Oo~

They met in the war room with an overlay of the land on the circular table. The walls reflected a chatoyant rainbow as everyone entered.The enormous gold arches glimmered against the sunlight that stubbornly made its way through the Horde’s smog covered skies.They took their seats and waited for Queen Angella to begin.

Kyle was nervous, as per usual, but he steadied himself next to Bow. After he decided to switch sides a year ago, mainly for the affection, he's been loyal to Bright Moon. He had even found a way to be useful as an engineer. He talked more and thrived with this new nurturing way of life. He’d often told Bow how no one would talk to him and how everyone saw him as a constant failure. Bow thought this was odd as Adora mentioned how much everybody used to talk to him until he shut everyone out. At the time, that’s when he began to fail. It was later assumed this was the work of Shadow Weaver and her ways to manipulate the squad.

Perfuma and her people had taken refuge in Bright Moon’s castle with few remaining behind to protect the Heartblossom. Perfuma had gotten much stronger over the years but it was still not enough to push the Horde’s advances back. The most she and everyone else have been successful doing was slowing them down.

Glimmer, too, had strengthened. Capable, now, to teleport four people and farther. But this was the maximum she could do at full charge. There had been too many close calls for her to consider risking her life with less power.

Bow had made significant advances designing and making his arrows. With the help from Kyle, he’d been able to design cluster arrows, flares, concussion types, and Kyle’s favorite, Cluster Spark. An arrow designed with the use of cluster arrows and electrical magic to render anyone within its range to suffer a shock strong enough to stun but remained non-lethal. It was successful in rendering the Horde’s vehicles useless as well. But to build them was lengthy and complicated.

Queen Angella briefed the team on the high level details. Scorpia was heading towards Bright Moon and seemingly alone as the scouts that had been sent out had confirmed to the best of their abilities that no other Horde enemy was near. The objective was to contain her in Bright Moon's levitating prisons, high above the ground. Glimmer was instructed to first take Kyle there to prepare to Interrogate Scorpia. Kyle was chosen as the interrogator because Angella felt he'd be more familiar with her tactics and possible manipulations. Glimmer would then take time to recharge before heading out with Perfuma and Bow to meet Scorpia half way between Bright Moon and Scorpia's current location. Perfuma would then restrain Scorpia with thick vines and bow would point a concussion arrow in her direction to ensure she wouldn't try to fight against the vines. Finally, Glimmer would take the opportunity to teleport Scorpia to the secured location to be interrogated. But, not before Glimmer teleporting back to Bow and Perfuma to take them up as well. Once it had been confirmed that Scorpia had no way to attack, Queen Angella would meet them all there.

~oO0Oo~

Scorpia's eyebrows rose excitedly to Glimmer, Bow, and Perfuma coming to view. She waved her clawed hand in the air happily, "Hey guys!" Glimmer teleported Bow and Perfuma within shouting distance to Scorpia. Again, a cheerful smile widened on her face, "Hey! 'Bout time you got here, I thought you were going to make me walk the whole way!" Glimmer nodded to both her friends. Bow took an arrow and pull back on his bow while Perfuma narrowed her eyes and grew vines from just beneath Scorpia. "Hey! Whoa, okay I gotcha." Scorpia felt the vines wrap tightly around her legs, arms, and tail. "I get it, I get it, I can't be trusted, but be careful with tail, okay? That's... *personal* ." Glimmer blinked out of existence only to appear within a hair of Scorpia's face. Glimmer wrapped her arms around Scorpia the

best she was able and grunted hard at trying to teleport her. Scorpia was legitimately unsure of what was going on. “Wow, what a welcome. Didn’t expect that. I’m a hugger too!” Glimmer began groaning harder until finally they both disappeared. The vines flopped to the ground and Bow released the tension of his weapon slowly.

~oO0Oo~

Glimmer let out a loud relieved but exhausted huff and jumped back from Scorpia. She leaned on her knees to catch her breath and weakly signaled to Kyle to let her out of the cell. Kyle had opened the forcefield that had divided them and quickly sealed it again as soon as Glimmer was out.

“A-are you okay, Glimmer?” He rested a hand on her back, not fully confident he should.

With a deep breath and a slow exhale, “Y-yeah,” she huffed, “I’ll be fine. Thanks.” She nodded to him with a polite smile. “I’m going to, oof, I’m going to quickly recharge and get Bow and Perfuma.” Again, Glimmer blinked out and disappeared.

Scorpia stood up, “Kyle! Is that you!? How’s it goin’! You’re lookin’ good! I’d give ya a hug if I could buddy!”

Kyle gave a wave of his hand and a sheepish smile in return, “I can talk to you more when the others get here. For now I have to get back to work.”

“Oh sure!. No, I understand. Good seein’ ya.” She spoke to herself quietly, “So that’s where he went. Thought he died... Good for him.”

~oO0Oo~

Perfuma and Bow were on high alert and slowly walked back to Bright Moon until Glimmer could teleport them away faster. Then suddenly both jumped to Glimmer's surprise presence and with a bellowing effort, she held onto both of them tightly and whisked them back to Castle Bright Moon.

As soon as they appeared in the castle halls, Glimmer quickly fell to her knees. Bow could only react fast enough to catch one of her arms. "Glimmer!"

"Just need a sec, Bow," she was heaving heavily. "Scorpia is *really* big. It was like carrying two and a half people." It was obvious that Glimmer charged herself up enough to get Bow and Perfuma to safety. Now she had a chance to recharge completely before getting to the prison.

Perfuma looked at Bow, "Come on, let's get her some help."

Bow agreed, "Right."

~oO0Oo~

"Hi again," Kyle greeted Scorpia through the forcefield. Bow, Glimmer, and Queen Angella appeared beside him like bodyguards. Scorpia returned a smile and a gentle wave of her hand. "So, um, obvious question," he began scratching the back of his neck, "What brings you here?"

"Oh, heh, um, well…," she mimicked him and scratched the back of her head as well, "So, Catra's been missi-"

Bow chimed in, "WE… DON'T… KNOW! How many times do we

have to-" Angella placed the back of her hand to his chest to stop him. Kyle looked at her and she gave the approval to let him continue. Instead, he passed that allowance to Scorpia.

Scorpia looked around a moment, "No, I get that. But…, I'm worried about her. I…, miss her." She began to wear a frown, "It's been like four months since I last saw her and looks like your She-Ra is missing too - aren't you guys wondering?" her eyes searched each of them but was only met with an untrusting gaze. "I know you know something. So here's what I propose."

Angella spoke a firm, "No. We don't negotiate with the enemy."

"So uptight, jeez. Look, I'm just saying-"

"No," came the immediate and cold reply.

"I'll tell you stuff about the Horde!" She threw her claws to the side of her bumping in the wall behind. It subtly shook the cell and the floor. She was a lot stronger than people perceived and there was a slight moment of worry that she could just easily break out if she wanted to.

Kyle spoke again, "We're worried too."

Scorpia felt defeated, "So, you really don't know how to get to her do you?"

Kyle shook his head 'no'. Her brows dipped and she turned away to hold herself. "Do-do you know if she's hurt." Silence was her reply. "What if I told you Catra's plans? Would you be surprised if I were to tell you they weren't to weaken you?"

"We're listening," came Angella's untrusting voice, "but expect no information from us."

Yeah, we'll see about that. "Fine," she turned back to face them. "Is this place secure from outside magic? Are we being watched?"

Angella twitched a brow, "We have taken measures for secrecy."

“Hey,” she put her hands up, “it’s not that I don’t trust you. Actually, it’s exactly that. You don’t know how powerful your enemies really are. Horde Prime? Not a forgiving kind of guy, let me tell you. My life’s at stake here. Are you *sure* ?” The worry in her face, the grinding of her teeth, the small beads of sweat let them know she might be being honest.

Kyle jumped in before Angella could reply, “You can trust me, Scorpia.”

Scorpia exhaled, “Just saying *that* could have ended me,” a breath, “You might want to grab some chairs.”

Angella was losing her patience, “ *Get* on with it.”

Scorpia rolled her eyes and began to explain that the repeated attacks against Bright Moon never made them advance. She explained while it appeared she advanced in some areas of the Whispering Woods, other areas would retreat. This alternating attacks achieved several goals. One of which is to display the illusion of advancing power to Horde Prime. The other was to strengthen Bright Moon against the Horde. Each attack did immense damage but in doing so, allowed the whispering woods to get stronger and tougher to navigate through when it healed. She told of various ways the Horde had manipulated Bright Moon’s armies with ambushes and illusions so they could better prepare for them. Yes, there were casualties and it was an unfortunate sacrifice. But there was a much bigger picture, to end the Horde.

Angella was in complete disbelief, “And you expect me to believe you? You traveled here, in the open, and you don’t think the evil Horde was watching?”

“Oh, heh, *that* , yeah I told Horde Prime it would be a smart plan to grab a piece of First One’s tech. The worst case scenario is that I’d die on the battlefield. He was very okay with that. Go figure, right?” She looked to the side with a shrug and a smirk. “You just need to give me a small piece of First One’s tech and let me go.”

Angella was taken aback, “Are you out of your *bloody* mind? Let you go? *Give* you First One’s tech? On what plane of existence would I *ever* allow that?” She looked at her wide-eyed with pinched brows.

She frumped her face briefly, “This one…, obviously. Kyle, you follow, right bud?”

“You,” Angella pointed, “are going to rot here to pay for the crimes you’ve committed!”

“Look,” almost a plea, “If you don’t let me escape, Octavia is going to start running things and she’s a lot meaner than I am. You will not be able to defend against her *and* the Horde. It’ll be wave after wave of poison, gas, psychotic episodes,” she huffed, “by the time Octavia is even half way, your armies will be so messed up you’ll be attacking yourselves. And without She-Ra, your rebellion just… can’t.” Scorpia paced a moment before sitting on the side bench, “You’ve got about a day to decide, maybe less.” She shrugged, “But I wouldn’t recommend waiting until the last minute before letting me break out of here. And if you do, you can go nuts shooting at me. It’ll be a blast!” she smiled with encouragement.

Angela stared at her silently until she gave a new order, “Glimmer, Bow, Kyle, I believe we have a few things to discuss in private:”

“Good luck!” Scorpia waved enthusiastically at them as they left.

~oO0Oo~

Queen Angella sat stiff in her chair. The team had relocated to a nearby office-like room near Scorpia's cell. She remained expressionless until she finally spoke, “Let's entertain the idea that she's telling the truth. If she stays, we will be swiftly overcome by the Horde. Our scouts have confirmed in the past that they have

the facilities to do this. And… when they've came back…, they were not quite the same. So-”

“Wait,” Glimmer found this news rather shocking. She glared at her mother, “we've *confirmed* this? Why didn't you tell us?”

Angella rose a calm hand, “Glimmer, we were already fighting a very large wave at the time. It was not the right time.”

Glimmer couldn't believe it, “And when was the *right* -”

Angella snapped, “Now, Glimmer! It's *right* now!” However, it was not time to have a petty argument. There was no breathing room left to make a very tough decision. “So,” she calmed herself, “they're is evidence to support her claims. They don't know of Kyle's improvements to our defenses but we are still not ready to defend against what she describes. And…, as much as I hate to admit it, we *have* learned of their tactics during this war.” Glimmer appeared to be thinking hard as if to be keeping information secret. Her mother immediately noticed this, “Glimmer, is the something you'd like to add?”

She looked a little bit away and then back to meet her mother's eyes, “No?” A stern glare was her reply. “Fine, fine. A couple months ago we ran into Scorpia. I was low on energy and Bow was surrounded. I needed to rest and then Scorpia started talking to Bow and Bow was ready to take a hit and I pushed myself to get him out of there behind a tree. But it wasn't far. I went to look and I think Scorpia knew where I was, where we were, but she let us go.” She looked nervously at her mother who was getting very uncomfortable at what she was hearing. “Am I in trouble?”

Angella closed her eyes to contain her anger, “You *think* she knew or you *know* ?” She tightened a hand over her first.

Glimmer spoke quickly, “Sh-she looked right at me and smiled as she marched on. She could have pursued us and won without much effort.”

Angella pushed this troubling news down. “Does anyone have any ideas? *Any* at all!?” She gave a short pause. “Are we *really* considering letting her go with First One’s tech? People have died because of the forces *she* commands!” She quickly snapped her head towards Kyle, “Kyle! You know her best. Can you give me *any* shred of confidence that she can be trusted *at all* ?”

Kyle was in the spotlight and he had trouble communicating. He looked to Bow who gave a thumbs up and a smile. When he met Angela's stressed glare, he answered, “I've-I've not n-known her to lie and…”

Angella tried to be more sympathetic by changing her expression to something more pleasant. She gently coaxed him, “Yes?”

“Sh-she's a princess.” Saying that out loud, he realized, was probably not the smartest words to utter.

Angella tried to remain calm but all she managed to do was flex and clench her hands. “I suppose the next topic to discuss is what *tech* we should allow her to escape with. Anyone want to volunteer a suggestion?” She pursed her lips hard and raised both her brows high as she looked at everyone.

~oO0Oo~

After several hours of tense discussion, Angella, Kyle, Glimmer and Bow stood in front of Scorpia’s cell again. Scorpia was anxious to hear what they’ve come up with. With a smile, she clasped her hands together, “So…, *guys…* ,” she jostled her head around a bit with eyes looking upwards, “what’s it going to be?”

Angella took a swift and calm breath, “We would like to know more of your advances. You say you’re strengthening us. How long before *you* think we’re ready to take on the Horde? When

exactly ," she put extra emphasis on the word sounding condescending, "will you fight along with us?"

Scorpia smirked, "First, you tell me what happened to Catra. You don't know where she is now but you know what happened. I'd like to know." She leaned back lengthwise on the cell's wall-seat. "Time's a'tickin' guys."

Angella was going to dodge the question with a counter offer but Kyle spoke first, "Adora, I mean, She-Ra trapped her in a temple. The woods," he looked to the floor as he spoke, "the woods make it impossible to find again. Only She-Ra can navigate to it. But…," he stopped.

Scorpia leaned forward, "But?" *Whatever happened to not negotiating with the enemy?*

"Catra, she- there's enchantments that will only break if Catra… forgives Adora for leaving the Horde."

Scorpia guffawed, "HA! Are you serious?" she got up and paced in a small circle completely astounded, "WOW! I can't even *IMAGINE* how pissed Catra must be! F-f-for how long?"

Angella stood straight and allowed Kyle to answer. He cleared his throat, "They have enough supplies for about a year."

Scorpia placed her claws on her head, just completely, utterly astonished, "And then?" All of them seemed to look to the side with a grim sort of face. "WOW! You guys," she huffed, "you guys are *really* stupid."

Glimmer defended with almost a snarl, "Adora will convince her. They'll come back!"

"Are ya *real* sure about that?" Scorpia could only gawk. She dismissed it all. It troubled her, though, and she pondered how could they all think being forced to forgive was, at all, an intelligent and well thought out plan. She missed Catra. And now, news of possibly never seeing her again. The news that She-Ra, a

much needed ally to accomplish their goals. It was all just absurd to a point where she questioned even trusting any of them. Their judgement was terribly lacking in her eyes. She forced herself, she had to move the mission forward, *Fine. A deal's a deal.* She told them the next attack would be poisoning the air and suggested planning a defense. She went on to say how the Horde are mind manipulators with extremely powerful tech of their own. If they could create enchantments to keep Catra in a prison, if they can keep this prison secret, they should be able to protect themselves from being manipulated. She spoke of how the attacks were going to be run by first attacking the Kingdom of Snow to distract the Rebellion away from Bright Moon. The following attacks would be done through their more advanced robots to attack the Whispering Woods again but from underground.

Scorpia was surprised they really haven't thought of better ways to protect themselves. She thought them foolish to only rely on the Rebellion and the woods to protect them. The only way to win against the Horde was to know how to defend against it first. "The next attack begins in three days. I *highly* suggest taking measures to prepare. And I shouldn't have to say it, but I'm going to, because you don't look like you're going to think of it yourselves, *try* to do it secretly. Horde Prime is always watching."

Angella narrowed her eyes at the insult but needed to ask a burning question before she considered handing over a piece of First One's tech, "Why are you helping us? Your ancestors joined the Horde and gave them the Black Garnet, why *wouldn't* you want to conquer us?"

And now Scorpia was pissed, "Are you SERIOUS? My family was FORCED to *comply* with the Horde! You ignorant, stuck up, little *ASS* ! My ancestors turned to the rebellion for help! But *YOU* turned your backs on us. All because we creeped you out! Maybe your dumb soft sausage appendages you call 'HANDS' are gross! Ever think about *that* ?" She waved her claws around furiously.

Angella gasped at what was said, "OUR ancestors-"

“Went into *HIDING. MY* people were slaughtered at the mere notion of resistance. Look, we’re wasting time! Give me the tech and you can start shooting at me and cause all kinds of fun!”

Angella was paralyzed with the inability to make a decision. There was a period of scriptures that seemed to be conveniently missing that could have shed light on where the Rebellion was at that time. How it may have fallen apart. Angella couldn't make up her mind. So Scorpia made the decision for her. Scorpia got up, punched the wall just behind the panel to disable the forcefield. It dented with a loud crunch and the forcefield fizzled away. Alarms blared immediately, “She-Ra is back. NOW is the time to strike back at the Horde. And you better hope Adora and Catra come back because this mission depends *literally* on *them!* Now give me the tech!” Scorpia outstretched a hand.

Kyle, Glimmer, and Bow, all of whom were shocked at how easily Scorpia was able to break free, looked to Angella who took a deep angry breath at what she was about to do. She nodded once to all three of them and all three handed over a fragment of First One’s tech.

Angella spoke, “We severed the pieces. Someone skilled can put it back together. We beg you to not use it against us.”

Scorpia huffed while she shook her head. Her eyes locked to Angella, “We begged too.” She took all three pieces. “You’ll be fine so long as you prepare.”

“How will you escape? This prison is built to stay unseen in the sky. The fall will surely kill you.”

“Well, you’re not going to like this…,” she pounded several times on the back wall of her cell. The prison shook like bombs exploding to the power of her strikes. She possessed an amazing strength and managed to punch a hole through the remarkably thick stone walls. She had to shout over the blaring alarms, “But you’re gonna need to trust me!” She grabbed Glimmer who yelped to her grasp and jumped out.

Angella, furiously wide-eyed quickly jumped out and gave chase. She was tempted to blast Scorpia right out of the sky, but Glimmer was used as a shield. She could do nothing but try to free her from Scorpia's grasp.

Glimmer screamed at the top of her lungs, "What are you doing!?"

Scorpia shouted back, "Just teleport us to the ground! Which is coming at us a lot faster than I want, so ANY TIME NOW!"

Glimmer grabbed on and screamed at how much energy she needed to balance out the momentum and find a location where they could land. Angella was just a hair away from grabbing her daughter right before Glimmer finally made them both vanish. Glimmer and Scorpia quickly re-appeared on the ground but there was still lingering momentum. They landed hard. Scorpia twisted and rolled in an attempt to protect Glimmer as they seem to bounce over the hard terrain. They finally rolled to a stop. Scorpia could hear Angella screaming in distress getting frightfully nearer. She gave one quick glance at Glimmer and dashed off into the woods. Angela went to her daughter and screamed at the woods, "NEVER TOUCH MY DAUGHTER! *NEVER!"* Her eyes were enough to haunt Scorpia for several nights. She turned to glimmer who was completely sapped of energy, "Glimmer," she softly cried, "Oh Glimmer, Glimmer!" A deep breath to refocus and she carried her off to the Moonstone gem.

A barrage of fire from Bright Moon's guards entered the woods towards Scorpia and hit nothing but trees and foliage as she quickly vanished. Angella raised force fields around the castle with all her might. A mother had never been so scared and furious, especially at herself.

Scorpia took her chances navigating through the woods. She was confident that following the smoke plumes would guide her back to the Horde. She made one last conscious decision to hide one of the First One's tech shards. She clamped the thick bark of a tree for reference and stashed the shard beneath a root. She hoped it would be enough to buy Bright Moon more time.

~oO0Oo~

Angella had summoned all her sorcerers and warned them of the oncoming attacks. When her sorcerers were sent away to the ancient libraries in the castle, she kept one behind. Her husband's sister, Castaspella.

Queen Castaspella waited until all sorcerers had left before speaking, "So…, how has the Rebellion been doing? I wouldn't know since no one talks to me - not that I haven't observed you and checked up on you."

Angella released a stressful sigh, "Casta, please, not this again."

She raised a hand to feign understanding, "No, no, I get it, you're very busy,"

How that one irked Angella but now was not the time to let it get to her. "I need you Casta, please?"

A short sigh, "Alright, what is it?" She gave enough pause to allow Angella to open her mouth but not long enough before following up, "Talking to me any other time is far less important."

Angella snapped, "Enough! You want to know why? Because every time I look at you I see my husband! I don't have time to GRIEVE!" she turned away to hide the sadness building within her but her voice could be of no help. It softened, "Don't think I don't care but it pains me to no end. And... , I almost lost Glimmer…, *again* ." That hurt the most. A repeated failure and a living nightmare. She turned back to face Castaspella with forced composure, "As I said, I need your help."

Castaspella took a breath and exhaled. It was difficult to believe that all this time. The avoidance was just simply heartbreak. Castaspella now realized she was a constant reminder of the failed

Rebellion. “Angella, I’m so sorry.” She opened her arms to console but was stopped.

Angella raised her hands and turned her head to the side, “No…, no please, that isn’t necessary. Thank you and I will try to be better, I promise. But now, now we need to prepare and you are the only one who can protect my soldiers. You’re the only one that can protect… Glimmer.”

Chapter End Notes

> If I could get some more reviews on this chapter I'd appreciate it. I saw a bit of a drop on FF after this chapter was posted and was wondering what might have deterred people.

Chapter 05

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Another month apart. Awkward passings occasionally occurred when both Adora and Catra went to get food at the same time or encountered the need to use the bathroom as if their bladders had been synchronized. Or the times they both wished to exercise and use the same equipment - that was, until Adora stopped exercising entirely. It was uncanny how often they just bumped into each other when Adora tried her best to avoid Catra. But eventually Adora finally made a breakthrough and it was time to share the news.

"CATRA!" Adora ran down the halls to Catra's room. "Catra! I need your help!" her voice carried soft laughter.

Catra was then caught, at last, red handed, scratching her posts as the door flew down. Adora smirked. She couldn't help it. Catra glared with pursed lips and raised a clawed finger, threatening that Adora better not say a word. This had only made Adora's smirk turn to a grin. Catra only rolled her eyes sourly but Adora let it go.

"Catra, I need your help, come to the library." A bright smile widened on Adora's face. A face that was bonier than Catra remembered and her eyes seemed more tired than they should. With more than just a moment to study her face, Catra was becoming more aware of Adora's condition.

Catra dismissed it for now and raised a brow instead, "With…?"

Adora approached and grabbed her hand, "Just come."

~oO0Oo~

Adora walked hastily with Catra back to the library. Catra tried to coax an answer but only received small giggles and chortles. Once they arrived, Adora handed Catra a bowl, “Okay hold this.” Adora picked up her sword that was laid on the table, closed her eyes, and transformed silently into She-Ra. She no longer needed to shout the words. She had only needed to feel it. But this was not what she wanted to show off. “Okay, ready?” Catra gave a confused look with a scrunching of her face and shrugged. Adora only laughed in response. “Okay, here we go.” She-Ra suddenly gripped her sword tightly and with great concentration, aimed the weapon at some void over the table. A portal. Small in its size, no bigger than either of their heads, formed in front of them. With some struggled grunting, “T-toss it! Toss it in! Quick!”

Catra threw it in the hole and very quickly had the bowl come falling down from the ceiling above them. The bowl thunked and bounced on the table and She-Ra released a relieved, “Ah!” She dropped the sword from her hands, turned back to Adora, and fell to the table, barely strong enough to hold on to it. The portal quickly shrank into nothingness.

Catra stared at the bowl as it wiggled its last wobble. She was astonished. Impressed. Her head slowly turned to Adora’s and screamed out, “YOU ACTUALLY DID IT!”

Still breathless, she managed to let out a small laugh, “Yeah.” She slid to floor and passed out.

“Adora!”

~oO0Oo~

Catra paced in front of Adora. She had taken her to the med station and, to the best of her remembrance, applied what she

could to Adora to make her better. She made another note at how much weight Adora lost. It was obvious she was skipping meals. The question was, why?

Adora's eyes soon fluttered open. Catra seemed to call out to her but the sound came muffled and thick. A deep breath and her senses suddenly began to sharpen, “Hey…,” it came out weakly but at least it came.

Catra went to her side, “Adora…, you idiot, are you okay?” Catra no longer held the distasteful tone she always carried.

Adora nodded, “Yeah,” a beat, “I'm gonna do it, Catra. Just need a little more time.” Adora kept her eyes closed. Hope was growing again and it showed as a subtle smile.

Unfortunately that subtle smile was met with some irritation, “Why haven't you been eating? It's probably why you passed out!” Catra waited for a reply but all she saw was Adora turning her head to avoid the question. Did she really think Catra wouldn't persist? “Adora?”

“Time.” She let the word escape.

Catra shook her head and huffed, “Idiot. You should have told me.” She was angry at Adora, but again, it lacked the hateful tone. “I'll be right back.”

It wasn't long before Catra returned. Adora had rested her eyes and Catra cleared her throat to make herself heard, “Are you able to sit up?”

Adora nodded with eyes still closed. Adora pushed up on her arms weakly and then slowly opened her eyes. Catra looked back at her with the same irritation, that was expected. The plate of food she held, however, wasn't. It carried two servings.

Catra was firm, “Eat. And don't fight me, I *will* slap you.”

Adora gave a slow nod, “Thank you.” She added a heartfelt smile too.

~oO0Oo~

With food in her stomach, she felt strong enough to talk, “Catra,” she said gently, “Don’t waste the food on me. I’ve got it under control.”

Catra stood up, took a crumb from her plate, gave her a brief glare, and then finally flicked the crumb at her nose.

Adora squished her head back and scrunched her nose while waving her hands in front of her aimlessly, “Hey!” she protested.

Catra turned away and sat back down on a chair next to the bed, “Stop being stupid.”

She did her best to reason with Catra, “Today was a breakthrough but I don’t know how long-”

Catra folded her arms and looked grimly towards Adora, “I’ll *give* you more time, Adora. What good is you learning how to open a portal if you can’t even stay conscious to open it?”

“No, Catra-”

“Shut *up,* Adora.” Catra sighed, “Now we have to waste time getting your strength back.” She seemed to pause, deep in thought. After a good moment, “Is…, is this you coming to me? Are you ready?”

The talk. Adora hesitated with her answer. She hoped the month away from each other was enough time to establish needs and what they were both willing to offer. It was time to see if they could have a nurturing relationship and, if not, understand and

accept they needed to sever any hope of salvaging it. She spoke quietly, “Can we talk in the library? My notes are there.”

“Notes?” Catra raised a brow.

A few nods to affirm, “I don’t want to make any more mistakes or miscommunicate what I’m trying to convey. You deserve my complete honesty.”

She scoffed, “Once a nerd, always a nerd. Fine. Can you walk?”

Adora made an effort to get out of bed and stood up. A mild dizzying but it quickly passed. “So far so good.”

~oO0Oo~

Adora stared at her notes. They were split into multiple sections and subsections: Honesty, Whole Truths, Wants, Needs, Understandings, Questions, Regrets, Other. Each one having a list detailed with events of their lives and how it correlated to the present. She also had a list of what she was willing to give up but she would save that for last. The problem now…

“Um Adora?” Catra was getting impatient at the length of time Adora took to collect her notes.

“Just a sec.”

...where to begin?

Adora uttered a soft, “Shit.”

Catra prodded her more, “Missing something?”

“No, I just…,” her eyes darted around. She’d stack one page on top of another only to reorganize it elsewhere. Another, “Shit.”

“Adora!”

“I want you! I want you in my life!” she turned around and looked directly into her eyes, “But, when I tell you everything, I need you to believe me. I’m scared you’ll think this is just some manipulative plan to get you to like me,” Again, her eyes darted around while holding her hands slightly raised, “And I’m going to say some hurtful things and I need you to listen to all of it because there’s more to it than just what’s first said.” A beat, “Will you listen?”

Catra gave a slight smirk, “Only if you do the same for me.”

Without hesitation, “Of course!”

“Good,” she sat on the bed, “Get on with it.”

Adora finally picked a starting topic. It started with Regrets, most of which Catra had already heard before but there was one in particular that somewhat miffed her, “I regret trapping you here thinking I could force you to forgive me. But…,” Adora’s pause was longer than usual, “I…,” nervousness rose in her voice, “don’t regret trapping you here with me.” Adora gave a moment to Catra. She watched Catra close her eyes in disbelief, open them, and then blink repeatedly to process. That news hit hard. Adora went on to explain that no matter how angry Catra was, the level of destruction, the number of casualties, and the years of pain she caused could not go uncontained, not necessarily unpunished. The point of it all was rehabilitation. She also explained that she would never have this conversation with her if she didn't. She felt guilty but didn't regret it had to come to this. She tried reasoning as those clawed fists were fighting not to swing at her. Catra remained in control but not happily.

Adora moved on to Understandings. She spoke to her notes as she read them to Catra and tried to empathize with the abuse. She blamed Shadow Weaver and the Horde for manipulating both of them. She theorized that Shadow Weaver knew of the ‘She-Ra prophecies’ and tried to utilize that for her own gain, to explain

why she was treated so differently. She understood Shadow Weaver was “Mom” despite the things she did to them. The abandonment wasn’t just to the Horde, it was to her family. She voiced that she wanted to know what Catra thought, that it *might* be plausible, that it *might* explain the mistakes she made. Catra only replied with a simple, “I'll consider it,” to which Adora was unsure how to take that response. She wanted a conversation but it appeared that wasn't coming. She awkwardly dismissed it with a soft, “okay,” as she looked to the side.

Then Adora went on to Honesty and Whole Truths. Much like the regrets, she admitted that she *did* think there was a veil over Catra’s eyes that only she could lift with nurturing affection. She admitted that part of the reason she didn't regret trapping her there was because she was happy to finally spend time with her despite how hard it's been. But she also continued to say that she would never stand in Catra’s way ever again. She described the version of Catra she thought was in front of her. Smart, witty, teasingly fun, and tried to bring up the numerous things they enjoyed together. With their history, she wondered, how much had changed. She never held the violence toward her against Catra. They were both soldiers. They both had worse growing up.

Then she spoke of Wants and Needs. She explained that she absolutely could not be with her if she stayed with the Horde. She needn’t fight along with her, but she was not to align with those responsible for so many atrocities. That wasn’t the Catra she believed she knew or could love. Catra gave very subtle, barely noticeable, acknowledging nods. She explained she no longer needed Catra to forgive her, that she understood that some things just can’t be, but it was certainly on her wants list. She did, however, need Catra to stop holding the past over her head. She needed Catra to recognize she was trying to be better by recognizing Catra’s perspective and making sure she doesn’t repeat those mistakes. Lastly, she needed Catra to understand that her time trapped with her doesn’t make up for the cruelty she consciously committed and that *she* needed to travel the path of redemption with her.

She wrapped up with Other. Simple appreciations while they were together in that temple. The brief joy she felt when they slept together. She emphasized she'd free Catra because she believed she'd do the right thing even if forgiveness was not on the table for her. Finally, it was time for questions. The first was the most important, "Catra, I need to know, where do you stand with the Horde?"

A moment later, Adora felt a pit in her stomach. An unbearable nausea consumed her as words and all sounds blurred to Catra's answer. Catra was shouting at her, but she wasn't sure what she was saying. All she could hear was, "I can't leave the Horde." Adora groaned painfully. Her heart shattered as she collapsed to the floor. How could it be? How could she be so wrong about Catra?

"ADORA! I SAID YET! ARE YOU LISTENING!?, ADORA!" Catra slapped her face gently and rapidly, "SNAP OUT OF IT!"

"W-what?" Adora was slowly coming back. Catra's face was so angry.

"I SAID," again Catra shouted, "I CAN'T LEAVE *YET!* "

Adora placed a hand to her reddened face, "Wh-what do you mean?"

"FINALLY! JEEZ ADORA! You said you would do the same! You said you would listen!" Catra released an exasperated and overemphasized sigh. She sat beside her on the floor. "I gave you three hours. Three hours! I couldn't even get three seconds!" Catra threw her hands up.

Adora sat up, her nausea had slowly dissipated. She grabbed Catra by the shoulders tensely, "Catra, I'm sorry, but what did you just say. I'm listening."

Catra stood up completely and outstretched a hand to help Adora off the ground. She pointed to the bed, "Sit." Adora did. "Are you

really going to *listen* ? She glared until she received a 'yes'. "And are you going to let me finish and believe every word?" Again, another 'yes'. Catra hesitated and then sat down on the edge of the bed with a hard thump. She, too, didn't know exactly where to begin.

"When you left," she picked a place to start, "I thought you knew of the lies, the corruption, the destruction, all of it. Shadow Weaver showed me things that I thought she showed everyone. And she hurt me *all* the *time.* I thought you knew and you still tried to please her," she paused, "I guess I got numb to it all." Catra questioned how Adora could still want to please a person like that and *then* to leave the Horde, to leave *her,* for strangers she only knew for a few hours, it was absurd! *You'd just BOND with anyone you JUST met?* She *JUST* figured out the Horde *hurts* people. It bugged Catra to no end but she calmed her thoughts so she could continue.

When Adora left, Catra was mocked. Shadow Weaver threatened her with death or torture as she had throughout her life. Her teammates thought she needed Adora to save her. To pull that heavy weight of failure across the finish line. And then Catra explained how she proved everyone wrong and that she needed to punish everyone. The attack on Bright Moon, years ago, was to punish Adora. It was to show her what failure felt like, to be *second* best, to be in someone else's shadow, to know what it felt like to watch and get hurt, to know what it felt like to be threatened with death. She didn't care who she hurt so long as Adora was one of them. And proving that she was better off without Adora, climbing the ranks, only solidified her belief she was right not go with her. Catra wanted Adora to understand how betrayed she felt, not when Adora left, but how her entire time with Adora felt like a lie. That Shadow Weaver only allowed her to exist because Adora wanted her, as a pet. She watched Adora hang on to every word with teary eyes. Adora shook her head subtly. She had already explained that she never felt that way but hearing it directly from Catra wrung her heart especially with how Catra was emphasizing her dialogue in front of her.

But when Catra stopped talking about her struggle she moved on to talk about Shadow Weaver. How pathetic her abuser was. Venting her failures on the people under her. It was clear, then, that Shadow Weaver served no purpose. That she would only get in her way. And, as she no longer feared her wrath, she removed her.

Everything seemed fine with Hordak. She became second in command, prepared his armies better, became stronger. But then everything changed after one small victory against the Rebellion. She spoke with a frowned sneer as if the words left a bitter bile in the back of her throat, "He touched my tail." Adora was instantly furious. She knew what it meant and it was unnecessary for Catra to go into more detail, "So I got rid of him, too." But things continued to spiral downward. His brother, Horde Prime, took over. Far more malicious and power hungry. It was only then did Catra understand the true nature of the Horde. It wasn't just a war for power, it was genocide.

Then came her plans. To strike at the Horde. But she couldn't do it alone. The amount of power and sorcery, the level of intellect and technology that Horde Prime possessed. There were no allies she could even hope to call upon to help her. Bright Moon, Mastacore, Kingdom of Snows, Salineas, *all* of Etheria were too weak to stand a chance. Catra needed to get them stronger and prepare them for an impossible battle. She strategized her attacks to be near overwhelming but winnable.

Adora was having trouble listening to this. All Adora saw in her mind were the number of casualties only to be pointed out that if the Horde had been permitted to attack more strategically, Etheria would be the Horde's to control. Adora swallowed hard. She couldn't help but think and question, why not join the Rebellion and simply train them. But the answer was obvious, Catra was the only one preventing the Horde from overwhelming them. Then why not at least tell them? The answer was reduced to a simple, "Horde Prime has eyes everywhere. I can't risk having you hold back. I can't risk *you* failing. So…, I can't leave the Horde…, *yet* ."

Adora was still processing and rubbed her face in tense, circular motions. How much longer before they could be together? How many more casualties? But right now there was a more important question on her mind. A question she *could* do something about *now* . “Catra, you still haven't told me what you want. What do you need?”

Catra was left speechless for a moment as she gazed blankly to the floor, “I don't know, Adora. Our past was so manipulated and… fucked up. How much of it was real?” Catra turned her head to meet Adora’s face. That month to think made her uncertain of herself. Of Adora. Who was it did she once see as her best friend? Who was it that broke her promise? She could see Adora wanted her to say that she wanted her. That she needed her. After everything Adora just said, she didn’t know what she wanted. And she questioned if they’d ever be on the same page ever again. “I don’t want to live a lie anymore.” She was pensive, “Every day, Adora, I wanted to go back to the way things were,” she then clarified with a sternness in her voice, “Not when you thought you were helping me. I mean when we were together. When only you and I mattered. I don’t know if I can change.”

Adora understood. That bond, the one established since childhood, had been severed. Completely irreparable because *that* bond was based on manipulation and lies and there was no way Catra could just let go as if it never happened. But Adora could not give up, “What if…,” she placed her hands on either side of Catra’s face gently, “What if we try again? What if we don’t hold back being completely honest with each other? That past is still there but it doesn’t have to stop us, right?” Her voice plead desperately, “I want to try, Catra. Can we do that?” She was getting teary at her own lack of confidence. “What’s the worst that can happen? We become allies and that’s all? That’s not so bad, right?” Adora’s brows seemed to quiver the more she looked into Catra’s eyes.

It was pitiful but she wasn’t wrong.

Catra felt the warmth from Adora’s hands. It had been so long since she had affectionate contact. Catra took Adora's hands down and then into hers. Her voice was flat as she spoke and she seemed almost expressionless, “I don't want to be hurt. I can't do that again.” She didn't want to reveal, for Adora's sake, but it was the betrayal.

Adora's eyes saddened further and she gripped Catra's hands tighter, “Do you really think what we're feeling *right now* is better? I won't make the same mistakes again. You know that.”

Catra was silent as she looked back. She fought herself. The pain of the past lingered but she couldn’t bring herself to hurt Adora any longer. She kept looking deeper and deeper into Adora, *What you did, hurt so much. But why do I want to make you feel better?* Their history, manipulated or not, Catra loved Adora’s personality. Could she just forgive her? That pain still lingered, no matter how many times Adora apologized. But what of their future? It could be brighter. It *could* be better. Catra leaned her forehead against Adora’s and closed her eyes, “I want this,” she opened them again, “I do...”

Adora cringed slightly, “But?

Catra shook her head against hers, “No ‘buts’.” She seemed to roll her forehead upward and pressed her lips against Adora’s. “No ‘buts’ Adora,” another kiss, “Okay?” Catra didn’t smile. She was unsure if she was reacting to being kept in solitude for a month. But right now, Adora seemed to be the most right person to be with.

Adora hugged her so tightly back and nodded into her neck. Adora was ecstatic. After everything she said, Catra still wanted to try. She began to relax and almost lean all her weight onto Catra when she closed her eyes. Exhaustion from studying, from poor diet, from forcing portals into existence, from all the emotional stress, Adora could not force herself to stay awake for much longer. She finally had an understanding with Catra. She finally

had her in her arms. She sniffed a deep breath and tried to hold herself up again, “I’m sorry, I’m just-.”

Catra pushed on her back to allow her to rest on her again. The bags under Adora's eyes, the weight loss, she was surprised Adora lasted this long, “Sleep.” Catra tipped her to the pillow as she went down with her. She suddenly felt Adora’s arms give her another squeeze. “Talk more later, Adora.”

“I'm not letting you go, so get comfy,” Adora took one last look into Catra's eyes, now seeing she was finally smiling back at her, and gave her another kiss. Adora sighed into it, her eyes closed once more, and she made extra sure Catra couldn't escape her softly giggling grasp before falling asleep.

~oO0Oo~

Adora woke only an hour later even though she was still quite lethargic from the past couple days. She would close her eyes only to open them slowly to look at Catra's gently-snoring face. Catra's hand draped over Adora's neck and jawline lazily while Adora's fingertips softly stroked Catra’s ear. Again her eyes closed. She fought to open them again. Adora just didn't want to lose this moment. She was unsure of how the rest of the evening would pan out. Their talk was certainly fruitful but there was still much between them that needed to be settled. But now, at least, they could work on it together. Adora could feel herself failing to win the fight against more sleep and decided to kiss Catra’s forehead before it was too late. No sooner did she press her lips did Catra pull Adora in tighter, almost reflexively, and kissed her chin in return. They snuggled close and Adora let sleep take her again.

~oO0Oo~

" *Just* wear it, Glimmer." Queen Angella placed a hand to her wrinkled brow as she was handling yet another petty argument in front of her royal guards. Aunt Casta had made a sweater for her niece but this one was different from the others. It was enchanted with protection spells. It was light purple, like a lavender, with a line of pearls that ran down the sleeves. The chest, too, was patterned with pearls in the shape of her father's staff. The back of it was intended to shape the pearls in the form a portal but unfortunately looked more like an oval target.

" *Mom!* I'll look so stupid! How am I supposed to *command* looking like… like… *this!* " Glimmer held the rather heavy sweater in front of her, nearly begging her mother to reconsider.

Angella leaned forward in her throne, "I *rather* you looked *stupid* than *dead!* " She's had so many arguments in front of her guards she no longer cared of her composure.

Glimmer flipped the sweater to show the back, "Because having a target on my back is going to increase my chances of being alive when I turn around!"

Angella slammed a fist down on her armrest, "THEN DON'T TURN YOUR BACK ON THE ENEMY!" Angella was now far past being a mother tolerating her child. She walked to her daughter and steadied herself. She spoke calmly but with a hint of a growl. "You are a commander. You will make use of *any* advantage you can. Whether it's the Horde's *bloody* uniform or your aunt's armor. It doesn't just protect *you* , it protect those nearest you. Now…, act like the commander I trust you to be. Am I *clear* ?"

Glimmer pursed her lips. Frustrated, she just couldn't understand why Aunt Casta couldn't make something more bold looking or threatening to the enemy. Something that wouldn't earn her muted chuckles when her back was literally turned to those she commanded. Something that wasn't a *sweater.* She gave a lazy

bow dripping with disrespect, “Yes, your majesty.” After her bow she turned to leave but not before her mother had a final say.

“And Glimmer?” A more cheerful tone, “Be sure to thank your Aunt Casta. She put in a lot of effort for you. She deserves more than just a simple ‘thank you’ this time.”

The sound of defeat came as she slouched her shoulders, “Got it, Mom.”

~oO0Oo~

Glimmer slowly paced in front of her small squad of royal guards while wearing her new sweater at the Kingdom of Snow. Princess Frosta had provided a private war room for Glimmer that housed extra coats, thermal boots, gloves, and hats. She did her best to accommodate their needs as she was well aware no one was comfortable with chairs, tables, and rooms made entirely of ice. Furniture made of wood and extra blankets were provided as well. Only ten of Bright Moon’s elites were at Glimmer’s availability as she received good word that armies of Horde soldiers were going to strike. A distraction to force the Rebellion to weaken themselves by sending more and more of their support to a far off location when another, larger, wave of Horde forces would swoop in. The idea was that the Horde would attack in waves and motivate Frosta to ask for more help. What they were attacking with was still unknown. Glimmer and her elite team's was to serve as backup only. Princess Frosta would lead her forces as much as she could and direct Glimmer to the best of her abilities. Glimmer would take her team to high vantage points acting more as magical sniping units. Bow, who was staring at Glimmer with stars in his eyes, was to stick by Glimmer’s side. Not only would he act to protect her but they were a perfect team together.

Bow had also been given a special gift before leaving for this mission with Glimmer. A special arrow, forged with fragments from Bright Moon's rune stone and enchanted with an ability to return to its owner. It was to be used as a last resort, when all other arrows were depleted, for if the arrow was lost, the materials could end up in the wrong hands.

Glimmer was authoritative with a straight back, a stern voice, and direct with her briefing, "This is the Evil Horde's only entry point," she pointed to a map on the wall. It showed all of Kingdom of Snow and the direction of the Horde's forces. "Allow me to rephrase, this is the only *known* entry point. All other areas here," she pointed to a massive glacier, "and here," she pointed to an area that only had frozen wasteland that could not be accessed by any ship or vehicle, "would be suicide to attempt to venture through. But…," a slight hesitation, "we know they have First One's tech. So be prepared for anything." She faced her team and looked them over quickly. Each one willing to sacrifice their lives for her and for Bright Moon. "Does anyone have any que- Bow stop staring!"

Bow quickly stood straight and reflexively put a saluting hand to his brow. He cleared his throat, "Sorry!"

Glimmer turned back to her team, "Does anyone have any questions?" None said a word and remained motionless. "Get ready to move out!"

When all ten soldiers had left the room, Glimmer glared, "Bow!?"

Bow shook his hands emphatically at Glimmer, "I'm sorry! You look so good in that sweater! How can you not like it? I wish your Aunt Casta gave me one too!" He offered a small pout.

Glimmer only rolled her eyes at the compliments, not quite believing his overdramatic display of affection. "Oh come on Bow, it's just a sweater. It's no big deal…," she paused to think about those words, "I mean ya…, it has enchantments to support five people, but it still has a giant target on my back!"

Overly shocked, “That's a target!? I thought that looked more like a portal.” Bow put a hand to his chin and craned his neck to look at Glimmer’s back while squinting an eye.

Glimmer appreciated his efforts and it earned him a growing smile. She couldn't tell if he was being sincere or if her mother had asked him to downplay the ‘kill-me-here’ symbol on her back. Either way, she was happy Bow was there to help her stop worrying about it. She dismissed any thought of it looking stupid and, finally, realized her mother was right, the power it held was more important. She gave a subtle laugh, “Alright Bow-”

Glimmer was interrupted by a howling growl, terrifying in every sense of the word, just before the ground had shaken with a terrible tremble beneath them. Glimmer and Bow were in a daze and completely overcome with fear. No weapon or magic had they ever heard a sound like that. Both of them had quickly realized the battle had begun. They had quickly left the room and exited the halls of the castle. Glimmer held onto Bow and teleported to a high tower to see the armies ahead.

Rows upon rows, as far as the eye could see, the Horde was upon them. Overwhelming abundance of soldiers, vehicles, and tanks came ever nearer. They would arrive at the border by nightfall, a time span too short to call for more reinforcements. It was a sobering shock that so many had made their way, that despite the information they were told, they were still severely outmatched. Glimmer was seen frozen by fear, “There’s-there’s so many Bow! What do we do!?”

Bow tried to instill some confidence even though his was quickly deflating, “We stick to the-”

Another howling growl, like a demon belching whimpering wolves. The beam of green light was massive as it hit the castle walls and caused them to crumble on contact. The castle’s defenses would not last long and the bigger question was where that terrifying strike came from. None of the tanks had fired and no vehicle

within their line of sight was large enough to generate that amount of destruction.

Glimmer trembled for a moment and then pulled herself together. “We have to retreat, Bow, we have to leave, NOW!”

Chapter End Notes

> Saucy things come in Chapter 7... but after I stomp on your hearts first.
>
> Just know, the more feedback I get, the better I can make this story :)

Chapter 06

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Throughout the castle rooms and halls at the Kingdom of Snow, Glimmer and Bow blinked in and out of existence in search of Princess Frosta. The search went rapidly while Bow tried to calm Glimmer and warn her not to use too much of her magic. It seemed, however, that her magic was not affected. The enchanted garment she wore, the pearls that covered her, were what kept her powered, but neither of them knew of its limitations. Bow didn't want to find out just yet.

"Glimmer!" Bow tried to get her attention with a jostling of her shoulders. She was nearly reaching hysterics trying to find the princess. "Just breathe for ONE second…, PLEASE!" his voice cracked with his plea.

Glimmer stopped a moment with eyes widening as she took a deep breath. She immediately glared at Bow on her release while he tried to explain it might be easier to just ask one of her guards. She did not reply to this suggestion. She simply took one more breath, held Bow, and disappeared to appear directly in front of a charging soldier that was leaving the castle walls to guard it.

She shouted with urgency, "Where's Princess Frosta!?" she huffed hard and was already far beyond losing her patience.

He was startled but held his composure. He held his staff upright as he spoke to them, "Her Majesty is likely deep in the castle with her Rune Stone. Now, make way!" He rushed off to join the other forces before Glimmer could ask where 'deep in the castle' was.

Glimmer grunted her frustration and released Bow. She was scared and she wasn't sure how much more time she had before the next devastating strike. People were going to die and she needed Frosta to gather her people and get them ready to leave.

She curled her fingers out of frustration and blinked out and appeared one more time in front of the guard, “AND WHERE IS THAT!?”

He didn’t stop this time. He only shouted back while attempting to get to his squad as quickly as he was ordered, “LEFT HALL!”

~oO0Oo~

Glimmer and Bow finally found Princess Frosta with her arms held towards her Rune Stone and sweating profusely. She was managing and repairing her castle. She could feel the Horde closing in. Her perception of where they were marching was enhanced through the power of the stone. She took a very quick glance over her shoulder to see Glimmer and Bow trying to keep their balance over the ice as they headed towards her. The speed in which they approached was a little too fast and didn't look like they were capable of stopping. They continued sliding as they attempted to back peddle to no avail until the ground suddenly rose upward and allowed them to successfully slow to a stop.

Glimmer spoke quickly, “Princess Frosta, the-”

Frosta acknowledged and dismissed, “The Horde is attacking, I know.” Her voice was dry and mildly strained.

Bow tried to clarify, “Right but the num-”

With more irritation, “I *know.* ” Frosta remained focused on the task at hand.

Glimmer was lost, “So, how are you telling everybody to retreat? Is it-”

“ *Don't* insult me!” she started with a growl, “I have worked *too hard* to keep this kingdom standing.” She began to take a stance

to balance herself. Her hands came to her hip and slowly came around to above her head. She tightened them into a fist, "I will defend…," she pulled her fists apart in a violent motion away and released a grunted, "Hah!" The deep croaking of ice breaking apart could be heard in the distance. "...until my very," she flicked her fingers upwards, "LAST…," and finally a violent smash of her hands together, " *BREATH!* " Frosta heaved her breaths heavily.

Both Bow and Glimmer were not aware of what just happened. Had they looked out towards the incoming invasion they would have seen the immense destructive power that Princess Frosta possessed. While there were some armies still making their way forward, a seemingly impossible number of them have now painted the snow and ice in red and green. Thick spikes had impaled vehicles, tanks, and the like. The ground displaced and scarred with a jagged trench. For any of the soldiers Frosta had missed, her squads were already upon them and finishing them off.

Princess Frosta came down to a knee while catching her breath. The beads of sweat had dripped off her face as if feverishly ill. Bow rushed to her aid with Glimmer quickly teleporting to her side to help. Not much either of them could do but wait to see what she'd want them to do.

"I… will *not* dishonor my parents." A promise she kept to herself after her parents were lost to battle. A battle at a time when they were the few who remained with the Rebellion. Frosta took a moment to recover. She felt strange when Glimmer came beside her. An odd replenishing of her magic and feeling less like she needed to push herself beyond her limits. She swallowed and stood up again, "I think I'm alright now."

"A-are you sure?" Bow asked with concern. Frosta gave an affirmed nod but was still lost. Bow excitedly surmised, "Glimmer, your sweater. I think it worked!"

Frosta raised a curious brow. Glimmer explained the sweater as she stretched the beaded threads towards her and how it might

have helped her recover with quickened speech. She voiced her continued concerns of the Horde even though it was quite clear Frosta did something to reduce their numbers. The 'how' was what was most baffling. When questioned, Frosta smirked, "I took care of it." It didn't help clarify anything but Frosta's smugness was enough to return some confidence to the two guests who both returned an awkward chuckle.

Frosta instructed Glimmer to stay near as her next task was to repair the damage to her castle. Ice slowly re-encased the entirety of the damaged area. Unfortunately it was short lived, as yet again, came that hellish growl followed by its wave of trembling devastation. All three held onto each other with that frightful quaking. When it settled Frosta gave her first order, "Find out where that is coming from and destroy it!"

Glimmer looked to Bow, her face came to a worried frown, "Let's go Bow." She told herself if it weren't for that sound she'd be able to bear it. It shook her to her bones.

Bow nodded, "I'm ready."

With her arms outstretched to the Rune stone again, Frosta concentrated on fortifying her castle walls once more but not before wishing them luck and letting them know, "Be quick."

~oO0Oo~

Hunger. Nothing was more clear to Adora than the sheer emptiness of her stomach. She wanted to let Catra continue sleeping but she didn't want to leave her side. Oh the hunger and how it nagged. Adora outstretched a hand and hovered over Catra's face. She hesitated and remembered how her hand was swatted away. If Catra did that again, now, Adora would be crushed. She retracted her hand and opted to whisper instead, "C-Catra?"

“Are you finally awake?” She rolled in place to face her with a subtle smirk, “Thought your stomach would never wake you up.”

Adora’s voice rose slowly, “You were awake this whole time?”

Catra shrugged, “Like five minutes. Let’s get some food so I don’t have to listen to that loud gurgling.” Adora playfully shoved her and got up.

~oO0Oo~

They both walked down the halls slowly in silence. Catra seemed far less hateful and it made Adora nervous. Catra may have even been considered happy. She was walking so close to her to a point where their arms would brush up against each other. Adora glanced away for a moment and assessed. She then decided. On the next brushing of their arms, Adora slipped her fingers through Catra’s which earned her a mildly startled, “Hm?”

“Too weird?” Adora expected a ‘no’.

Catra looked away while her eyes slowly circled around with mild nervousness, “I mean…, kinda. I just…,”

“Oh…, right…, I’m sorry…,” Adora was embarrassed. All the blood in her body seemed to rush to her face. A little pained by the reaction but it didn’t hurt as much as how stupid she felt. One afternoon to discuss the past was not an everlasting band-aid. *Don’t rush it! Idiot!* Adora pulled her hand away but Catra didn’t let her.

“It just caught me by surprise,” Catra’s hand firmly held Adora’s and only loosened to something more comfortable when she felt Adora’s grip return. “I really like this but I don’t want it to be something we’re doing just because we need it. I don’t…, I don’t want it forced.”

Adora understood, “We still have a lot to talk about.” She tried to make herself sound more affirming but her voice carried the sound of defeat. The only thing that gave her a little more hope was that hand gripping hers back. *Then what was that kiss? An empty desire? A reassurance? A longing need for a warm body?* Adora was overthinking and was oblivious to how visible she made that appear. She kept her eyes unfocused and Catra could see them shift from side to side when she kept having another thought. Catra rolled hers and bumped Adora’s shoulder causing Adora to utter an “Uh?”

“Can you stop? What do you even see in me?” she smirked at her, “I like you. There. You got me to admit it, okay? Doesn’t change the fact you’re still an idiot.” Adora’s eyebrows raised, happily, and a relaxed smile grew. “Don't get too happy, I'm still really pissed. I just don't want to be angry right now.”

Adora's smile fought a frown. The emotional roller coaster was taxing, “Catra? Can *you* stop?” she huffed a nervous laugh to offset the seriousness of her request but she'd really like to have a steady rest of the morning, or night, she wasn't sure which it was yet.

Catra glared, rolled her eyes once more, and gave a final smirk, “Fine.”

They continued down the hall in silence while still holding hands until they reached the supply room to get food. They slid the large door down together as they refused to let go of each other. It quickly became a game to see how much they could accomplish whilst their fingers laced. Adora was Catra's right hand while Catra was Adora's left. Catra complained it wasn't fair since she wasn't left handed but Adora said to suck it up jokingly. They did, however, agree that Catra would get the first dish.

~oO0Oo~

Adora couldn't stop smiling. Catra wanted to end the challenge but Adora held tight to Catra's hand as she fed her forkfuls of food with the other. That wasn’t to say Adora didn’t steal a few bites for herself too.

It wasn't a smile, it was a sly grin, “Come on Catra, open the hangar door for the skiff!” She even made shushing sounds to imitate the vehicle. Catra was tight lipped and glaring. Adora snickered, “Okay, okay, too far,” she looked away briefly, “I still want to feed you.” She angled her head down and looked up to her with playfully pleading eyes.

When Adora thought Catra couldn't glare harder, she was surprised to find there was yet another achievable level of ‘do-not-want’. But Catra couldn't refuse Adora's plea and decidedly opened while still holding that displeased face that was also hiding a contained laugh. In went the fork and Catra chewed with a failing angered frown. Adora burst out laughing and kissed Catra's cheek and Catra couldn’t help chuckling in return. It wasn’t long before Adora fed herself with Catra by her side. She was forced to eat more than just a single serving even though she said she couldn’t fit it. Her protests went to no avail.

Catra was left pensive again when Adora finished her double serving. Adora prodded, “You okay?”

Catra’s eyes drifted slowly to meet Adora’s, “Um, your friends,” her eyes then drifted away, “what’s so great about them?” Adora somewhat froze to the question and wondered if it was in some way Catra comparing herself to them. Or wondered how it was possible, the enemy, to befriend her. She opened her mouth to speak but froze. Catra knew this was classic Adora, “I’m just wondering, Adora,” she said as if it were nothing but a casual question.

She gave a thoughtful nod, “Th-they’re nice…, do you want me to… actually talk about them?”

With a nudge of head and widened her eyes as if it was obvious, “Uh yeah, it’s why I asked.”

Adora spoke of them a little nervously but as she saw Catra was really paying attention, she relaxed into expanding into more specifics. She told her of the times that whenever she had a problem, they would always insist on helping but gave her space when she needed it. Adora inserted, quickly, it was mostly about how she missed Catra and other pains. She moved on to tell her about some secrets about Glimmer.

Catra was in disbelief, “No way! Glitter girl has a secret weapons cache?”

Adora giggled to the question, “ *GLIMMER* , yes, she has a secret weapons room that even has some old Horde weapons.”

Adora continued with Bow and his, sometimes, overbearing need to right every wrong. She liked that everybody was so supportive despite her background. She then quietly suggested that Catra would get the same treatment.

“Pff! Like I’d want it!” Adora only tilted her head and glared. Catra tried to quickly dismiss the accusation that she’d ever be open to the overwhelming hug-fest that were her friends, “Whatever.” Adora playfully nudged her with a smile, “What!?”

A little smug, “I thought we were going to be completely honest with each other.” Adora got up with a rising finger to pause the conversation while she filled a cup of water. She could feel Catra's angry eyes on her back. When she returned to the table she waited to see if Catra would reveal any truths.

“I am!” she glowered, “Your friends sound annoying!” and there was a moment of pause before she sighed, “They do sound annoying,” more calm, “but yeah, I guess it would be nice to have it then not.” She looked at Adora, “You look dumb with that smile, Adora, if I’m being completely honest!”

A small chortle, “Fine, I’ll wipe it away.” The smile remained but was less complacent, “What about you? How’s Entrapta? And… Scorpia? I know you had a thing for her, or is it still *have?* ”

That question took Catra by surprise. Catra blinked in confusion and brought her head back to think about it. Then came her guffaw when it hit her and then she finally wheezed into a cackle. Adora stared at her while slowly getting offended by the seemingly unnecessary need to make her feel stupid. Catra shouted out, “MISSION FUCKING ACCOMPLISHED ADORA!” She continued her laughter, “I'm now marking that as my best mission *ever!* ” A few more bouts of laughter until she saw Adora moping without a smile to be found, “Come on! I wasn't her *date!* ” A few more huffs and finally the laughter dissipated to something more serious. A chuckle that lead to a soft but stressed sigh, “Hey,” she poked Adora, “that night was awful for me.”

A stern look from Adora, “Because you had to see me?” It came out as a saddened grumble.

“Well…, ya,” she spoke without jest. Every word was sincere. “It hurts. Still. You were my *everything.* ” Her eyes drifted away and felt it was stupid to admit such things.

Adora tried to assure her, “I can still *be* that. I'm trying to be bet-”

“I know, I know. It's just that lingering question, ya know, How could you possibly think I could come with you when Shadow Weaver had her fucking shadow-spies up my ass the whole time?” her voice then whispered stressfully, “How could you seriously not know?”

Adora closed her eyes a moment. Guilt washed over her. She grabbed Catra's hand, “I swear I'll make up for it, because…, *you* are my everything.” She stared into Catra's eyes trying desperately to show her sincerity. To show that she will do everything within her power to keep that promise. A promise that was slipping away because she was sure Catra had no expectation Adora would keep it.

Catra sniffed as she was beginning to feel that familiar sting in her nose before an abundance of tears were to flow. She wouldn't permit herself, "Well, we'll see, right?" another sniff to recover, "Did you ever have a thing for Princess Sparkles?"

Adora couldn't help fight her own battle with her tears building. She sniffed into a chuckle with an incredulous look, "Princess Sparkles now?" She began, softer, "No…," she gripped Catra's hand a little tighter, "Only one person matters to me," she looked at Catra suggestively, "And that's-"

"Ugh! Don't say it. You're such a nerd!"

A subtle smile, "You."

Catra's tears flowed silently. She tried to hide it by croaking a, "Whatever," but it did little to mask her pain. Catra wanted to believe every word and all of Adora's new promises. What a fine fairy tale to imagine.

"You don't believe me do you?" Adora responded with disappointment hanging heavily on her voice. "Why do you think I made this stupid mistake?" She outstretched her arms and looked to the ceiling. "I really am sorry for all of this, it was selfish, but…, damn it Catra," a brief pause. She suddenly felt she took a step backwards. "Do you think we would ever…, like *ever* , talk like this if I didn't trap you here?" She facepalmed, "I'm sorry, I wasn't trying to say-"

Catra interrupted, "We wouldn't." There, she admitted it. The single benefit of being trapped together got them to talk. But was it manipulative? Absolutely. Was there another way? Catra wasn't sure. It took them months to even get this close. What, then, would have been the alternative?

They spent a little more time in silence, and for the both of them, that was okay. Adora still held Catra's hand and it seemed Catra didn't mind. Eventually, Adora suggested relaxing in the pools to which Catra was actually thankful for. She was bored out of her

mind with nothing productive to say and if they were going to do nothing, they could at least enjoy doing that in an ancient, mystical pool.

~oO0Oo~

Both Catra and Adora had discarded their clothes before entering the calm and cool pool. Catra sat at a corner and invited Adora to sit on top a little shyly. A brief smirk came and went as Adora approached her. As she turned she gently leaned back but Catra's brows knitted immediately, "Whoa!" She placed a hand on Adora's back and felt terribly displeased at the sight.

"What? Did I step on you? I'm sorry!" Adora looked through the rippled water and wondered what it was.

"No…," a little calmer, "no, I'm fine. Show me your back again." First Catra's eyes and then her fingertips had traced Adora's scars that streaked vertically down to her hip. Adora straightened her back at the ticklish and gentle touch. A mild shiver followed. Catra felt disgusted with herself. She didn't remember how deep she clawed She-Ra back then. What she did remember was the rage. "I really gave it to you, didn't I?" Her voice lacked any emotion. Adora displayed other scars from the battles they fought but the ones her back were the most crude.

Adora, equally as stoic, "It happened. Don't focus on it." She quickly leaned back into Catra so she wouldn't see. Adora grabbed Catra's hands and wrapped them around herself, "She-Ra's got thick skin."

Catra wanted to say she was sorry but there was a reason those wounds were there. The memory slowly became more vivid in her mind as if the recollection forced the thought to remain. The imagery echoed and repeated until it was finally interrupted.

Adora rubbed Catra's hands with her thumbs, "Stop thinking about it, Catra." Catra forced herself to relax, not realizing how tightly she held her. She released a gentle, albeit distressed, sigh and leaned her head forward against Adora's shoulder.

They both rested there and wanted to talk more of what was between them. It was long overdue, and yet, too soon to start that conversation. For now, they settled on going through the motions. They tried to push their memories away. Adora, the betrayer. Catra, the vengeful.

~oO0Oo~

Glimmer and Bow finally found the source of the horrific blasts that scorched the castle walls in the Kingdom of Snow. It seemed so impossibly far. Glimmer had teleported so many times and so far with Bow that the vibrant colors of the sweater seemed to fade. The magic was wearing away.

They hid behind what appeared to be discarded machinery that had either been blown up by the Rebellion, or perhaps target practice for the Horde. It was far away enough from the Horde base that they could think of a plan. Except, they had none.

The cannon was massive. They expected something huge that could deliver such a blast, but this, this was an abomination's creation. Their eyes traced the scorched ground from miles away to the artillery that caused it. The muzzle of the cannon towered over them. The back protruded with glowing tubes and cables. The sides to the base had six large rods that were slowly receding into the machine. The bottom was most inserted and the second was the one in motion. Bow and Glimmer could only assume, that once all six rods were locked and loaded in, the monstrosity would fire again. They could already feel the heat that was building from where they were. The ground was shaking a steady rumble and it

was only now they realized they were far too close to be considered in the safe zone.

Glimmer looked around for a better location. The next best area was behind a skiff that was parked near a large squad marching away. Neither of them had any better ideas and Glimmer teleported with Bow to it. They both looked around and saw they were generally in the clear. They weren't comfortable with the marching squads exiting the barracks nearby but they seemed to face the direction they were heading in unison. Bow took his quiver off his shoulder and looked through the available arrows he and Kyle made.

The second rod screamed a loud, metallic whine as it ground tighter into the device and came finally to a loud thunk. Squads ahead cheered its progression with a barbaric hollering, "TWO DOWN! TWO DOWN! FOUR TO GO! HOO-AH! HOO-AH! HOO-AH! HOO-AH!" Both Glimmer and Bow were overcome with anger, disgust, and fear. For a moment, the hairs on their arms had stood on end.

Bow stared at his quiver and spoke very quietly to Glimmer, "I-I could throw all my arrows in the opening of the rods…, I-I don't know." He slowly looked up and hoped Glimmer had a better idea.

Glimmer quickly disagreed. There was no guarantee it would work and if it did, the blast would be so huge it would likely be a massacre. They needed to find a power source. They had no choice but to follow the large tubes and cables.

~oO0Oo~

Bow and Glimmer snuck around corners for some time and decided against teleporting so Glimmer could reserve what was left of the power in her sweater. The fourth rod was closing and near completion. The cables and what seemed like endless tubes

wound around to various rooms until they found the source, the Black Garnet. The rune stone no longer shined a ruby red. It had blackened as if the stone itself had been poisoned. It had cracked and grown tiny shards like mold infecting its surface.

They needed time to think. Time they certainly didn't have with another rod about to close. Any damage they do would only be temporary. They needed reinforcements to do something more permanent. Temporary would have to do for now. Bow took a quick look around the area. It seemed completely unguarded which was very strange. The Horde was indeed sending their troops for a massive attack on Bright Moon which may have explained the deserted room.

After a quick discussion with Glimmer, they both agreed Bow would set a few cluster spark arrows at key points around the room. When all was set, he'd set off a chain reaction that would render cables and consoles completely useless. It would give them time to organize a separate mission to attack the monstrosity that was currently damaging Frosta's kingdom. It would be a first, in a long time, to organize a strike against the Horde.

Bow planted his arrows and was very careful about the level of noise he was making. That was until he was startled by that awful squealing of scraping metal when that fourth rod came to a close. He could only then shudder at the sounds of the distant troops cheering even louder as the railgun was nearly ready to fire. How could they glorify such awful devastation? It was sickening. After he was done he headed back to Glimmer who was not found where he expected her. She lain on the floor unconscious and Bow immediately panicked. He readied his bow and arrow and tried to find the culprit responsible. He tiptoed slowly towards his friend, wanting to be beside her immediately but was forced to scan the area. He didn't even hear it happen. He chastised himself internally for not protecting her but it was not the time. He needed to get to her and help. She had been set down next to a stack of crates. Bow was nearly there and yet still didn't see anyone.

He knelt down next to her and thankfully found her still breathing. He continued to search the area. Still nothing. He whispered, “G-Glimmer?” He rubbed her shoulder, “Glimmer, please. wake up. What happened?” Now he wasn’t sure if it was an issue with magic. Maybe a limit with the sweater that finally caught up with her. The next question he had to answer was how to get her home safely. They were so far, his only option was to steal a skiff.

Unfortunately his plans would have to wait. A glowing stick crackled above as a scaly Horde soldier came down. Bow rolled away, dizzying himself briefly at the speed of his dodge. At least now he knew how Glimmer was stunned.

The Horde soldier was fast and followed up with another attack. Bow continued to evade his fists, his legs, his thick tail that nearly took his head off. The soldier gave a deep, guttural growl filled with a hatred Bow hadn’t encountered before, “DIE!” He spun with his electrified stunner and managed to tag Bow’s leg and made him roll to the floor.

Bow groaned hard, “Hnnngg!” Even through the thickness of his coat and thermal pants that last strike sent throbbing pains through his knee and shin. The soldier was a lot tougher than he looked and he looked tough.

The soldier leapt up and came down with an overhead strike. Bow quickly used his weapon to block with wide eyes. Another hateful taunt, “I’LL MAKE SURE YOU DIE FOR KILLING KYLE! ALL OF YOU WILL *DIE!* ”

Bow thrusted his body off with as much force as he could muster and backpedaled away. He was shocked, “Wait, Kyle-Kyle? You think he’s dead?” The soldier roared loudly and charged at Bow with everything he had. Bow did his best to dodge and block, but every strike was getting to be too much and he faltered to the floor. His vision blurred, his heart pounded in his throat, and it seemed all the sweat in his body poured out. Just before another strike came, he spoke his name with a strained voice, “You’re Rogelio, aren't you?”

Rogelio stopped, “How do you know my name!” he hissed.

Bow put up his hands in defense, “He-he talks about you…, a lot!”

“TALKS!? Rogelio raised his weapon.

“HE’S ALIVE!” Bow defended. “He’s with us! I can show you! I can prove it!”

He roared again, “LIAR!”

Bow then watched him nudge forward and then fall to the ground. Confused and astonished. An image slowly came to focus. Someone was waving.

She leaned in, “Hey Bow!” Scorpia said with her usual cheerfulness. “Got good news and bad news,” she frumped her face a little to show that the bad news did not balance out the good news in the least. She raised her claws a little, “Good news is, looks like I’m part of the Rebellion, so there’s that,” she then muttered to herself, “thought I could last a little longer but,” she returned to her normal volume, “OH WELL! Bad news, I set bombs all over this side of the place so uh,” she gave a small chuckle, “ya, we gotta go.”

Bow could only moan what seemed like some form of acknowledgement to about half of what he actually heard. He felt his body being lifted and carried. When he was set down again he felt two other bodies placed on either side of him. Motion rocked him as he heard an engine of some vehicle carry them away. Were they getting help? Were they going to be imprisoned? Bow wasn't lucid enough to be sure.

Scorpia shouted back, “You might want to brace yourself!” After about a minute, it became clear as to why she gave the warning. Explosive bursts could be heard in the distance. The groaning of large metal pieces collapsing beneath its own weight shook the ground. Heat, despite traveling as fast as they were away from the Horde base, that heat could still be felt. A terrifying thunder rippled through the air.

The shaking seemed to have woken Glimmer up. She squinted hard and held her head. She looked to her right and blinked her eyes open. She gasped, “BOW!” Her eyes traced over every bruised and battered bone on his body. He shift his head to his left and gave a weak smile. “Wait, who’s-”

“Hiya!” Scorpia announced.

Glimmer was startled and fell back on the floor of the skiff, “AH! WHAT ARE YOU DOING HERE!?”

“Uh, saving your ass?”

Glimmer noticed the unconscious Rogelio, “AND WHAT’S *HE* DOING HERE!?”

Scorpia rolled her eyes, “Could ya maybe calm down a little?”

Glimmer grumbled a moment with fists fully tightened and unsure of what to do with herself. She was definitely not being detained but the unknown in a hostile environment made her snap, “WHY IS BOW HURT!?” She glared at Scorpia like her mother had during their last encounter.

Scorpia tried to calm things, “Alright! Alright!” she hit a few controls on the dashboard to maintain speed and turned halfway to face her. One eye on Glimmer, the other on what was ahead. Scorpia explained how she found all of them. When she was setting bombs around the base, she saw Bow and Glimmer enter the room with the Black Garnet and was going to greet them sooner but Rogelio caught them first. Bow was about a foot away from discovering Scorpia but before she could warn him of a trap, he had already went over to Glimmer. Having overheard Rogelio’s cries over Kyle, she explained she couldn’t help but stab him to which Glimmer shared a stressful and confused look. “So they could meet!” she exclaimed, “And he was about to make your battered friend here dead! Why aren’t you thanking me!? I’m doing so many good things!” She sniffled and Glimmer couldn’t

tell if she was feigning her emotions but she had otherwise looked very sad.

Glimmer threw her arms up, "Alright, I'm sorry." A brief hesitation, "Thank you." Glimmer told Scorpia to head to the Kingdom of Snow before heading to Bright Moon. She told her that her mother would likely be furious to see Scorpia again and should instead seek help from Princess Frosta first. She told Scorpia to explain in better detail what was going on since they last met but not at the moment. Her head hurt too much to discuss anything and preferred a much safer environment.

~oO0Oo~

Catra and Adora felt they've spent a long enough time in the pool while also not wanting to move. Catra was the first to break their silence though, "Look, Adora…," that pause was agonizing.. Bad news was coming and Adora braced herself for it. "My left thigh and my right butt cheek fell asleep. And I'm starting to cramp in the other thigh." A hidden smile tugged on the corners of her lips while Adora released a soft burst of laughter and was relieved it was nothing serious.

Adora got up so Catra could walk around. And she did. She shook and stretched her legs this way and that until Adora suggested, "I can um, I can massage it if you want." Adora meant nothing more than that. Just a massage. She'd been sitting on her legs for a lengthy duration and she felt she owed it to her. Catra thought about it. The lump in her thigh wasn't getting any better and nodded in agreement with a bit of a cringe. The cold temperature of the water likely wasn't helping.

Adora gestured to the massage table. When Catra lain on the table, face down, she spoke before Adora could get the oils. "I think we should talk every day," a beat, "about…, about us."

Adora acknowledged with a quiet “Mm,” and proceeded to warm the oils in the bubbling bath. When she came back, she thought about those words. How Catra meant them. She nervously placed her hands on Catra’s affected thigh and tried to keep her voice steady, “Are we going to fight again?” She felt the knot and fanned her thumbs over it while squeezing with her fingers.

Catra tensed a moment from the brief pain each time Adora’s thumbs went over the area. A soft and quiet sigh, “Probably.” Her thoughts were interrupted by the intensity of Adora’s massage, “T-too much…,” she felt Adora hold back more. “That’s good,” she retraced her thoughts, “Adora?” her voice remained gentle, “Whatever happens…, I’ll try.”

It wasn't just a ‘try to talk to her’ or a ‘try to rekindle their relationship’. It was a try to see things through Adora's lens and try forgive her. She'd try.

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you so much for the recent feedback. I can understand that plot B is less popular and I'll try to work it so that it's less invasive going forward. I do want to keep Plot B going though. I mean, at least stick around for Scorpia.... IT'S SCORPIA.
>
> Anyway. Chapter 7 is completely Plot A and will be posted on Monday evening, US Eastern time. Depends on when I can get work done, so no specific time, usually 9PM-ish And then I'll be all caught up with the chapters. I will try to get the remaining chapters written on a weekly basis but due to life being as busy as it is for me, it may be every other week.
>
> THANKS!
>
> Also, if you read chapter 7, you are REQUIRED to review :P There are some erotic bits that i need to make i got right and it's important to me even if it just fluff

Chapter 07

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Another four and a half weeks drift by. No arguments arose and no other conflict between Catra and Adora. Time was set aside for studying and a separate block for talking and just spending time with each other in the evening. The month had gone well. But this was generally due to avoiding the issues they had. Their conversations revolved around fantasies,

“Hey Catra, after the war's over, what do you want to do?” Adora played with Catra's hair from behind. They remained in the library and relaxed on the bed as they never moved it back to Catra’s room.

Catra hummed a chuckle, “You mean after I conquer all of Etheria?” She spoke as of it was obvious and her tone flat.

Adora snorted a small laugh, “Sure, let's go with that.”

A wave of her hand, “I'd obviously have to manage all my subjects. No time for anything else. I am supreme ruler after all. What about you?” Catra arched her head back to look up at Adora behind her with a soft smile.

Adora huffed, “Obeying all of your commands, apparently.”

“Ha! Good answer!”

They soon spoke more seriously about the question. Adora wanted to learn how to bake. The amazing food she had at festivals and even her every day meals brought her such euphoric joy. She wanted to share that experience with Catra.

Unfortunately, Catra wasn't sure what she wanted to do. War seemed to be her purpose. She never really thought she would

survive but Adora encouraged her to think about it. She didn't want Catra to think she had a meaningless life after the war ended. And she was confident Catra would, in fact, see the end of it.

Outside of fantasies they marked the walls of the temple with various graffiti. Catra drew Adora's face with her claws and added the caption, “I'm a dumb face.” Adora drew Catra, crudely, with her sword and added, “I purr in my sleep.” Catra didn't find it as funny as Adora did and slowly stepped away from Catra with a tight smirk. Catra tried to claw it away but Adora's sword had etched it so deeply the words were still very clear. And for some time, Adora was chased around the temple for refusing to erase the words. Her giggles filled the temple halls. Eventually Adora gave in and handed Catra her sword but Catra only rolled her eyes and dismissed it with a, “Whatever.”

Occasionally - only twice that month - Adora had started their block of time together with a kiss, a stroking of Catra’s ears, and tight hugs. Not much had been spoken between them on those days.

Catra first reminded Adora, “We're supposed to be talking, Adora.”

A soft kiss on Catra’s cheek and another on her chin, “We are talking.”

Catra closed her eyes as soon as Adora's lips reached her neck. She spoke softly, trying to encourage a conversation, “Adora?”

Quickly, “Communicating. We're communicating.”

Catra kissed her back, *Damn it.* “Adora…,” she lingered on her name. *Damn it.*

There were even days where Catra had developed enough interest in the shapes on the walls and books that she asked Adora to teach her how to read them. She was told that the shapes didn't represent language but phonetics and could be used in most languages. Adora decided to expand on the history of First One’s

language at another time since she wasn't quite sure of it herself. She only saw that some of the ancient scriptures in the library used the language of old and some were of the language that was commonly spoken. And Adora *insisted* that Catra be taught while leaning against her while she taught over Catra's shoulder.

But, eventually, all good things had to come to an end. The fantasy - the idea of their relationship being without issue - had to end. Adora expected to delay the inevitable for just a little bit longer. But, after those four and a half weeks, Catra had looked at Adora as if she caught her sneaking to her bedroom long after curfew.

Adora briefly face-planted into her hands and dragged down, "It's now, isn't it?" She watched Catra give her a slow bobbing nod from the edge of the bed. She spoke weakly as if the following, serious conversations would end their relationship, "N-no matter how bad it gets..., i- *if* it gets bad," she tilted her head, slightly, one way, "unless it's *just* really not possible, I still want us *here* , on that bed," she pointed to it, "every night." Although it was a statement, she was looking for approval.

Catra nodded again, "We can do that," she spoke almost authoritatively. But she also had her own condition that sought approval, "I want the same time to talk as you." Adora nodded emphatically to a point where Catra could almost hear her say, "Of course!" She twitched her brows as if to reply, "We'll see," but she readied herself by sitting straight and wrapping her tail around herself, "Go ahead."

Adora stood by the library table and stared for a moment and took a breath. She always had a lingering question that she repeatedly suppressed. A quick swallow and she finally spoke, "These past few years have been pretty awful between us…, obviously. You've gotten... *really* close to killing me." A beat as she watched Catra tense, "If you had another moment, another chance, would you really have done it? Or was it all just to hurt me and scare me? Was it just a show of dominance or would you have really gone so far as to end me?" Adora swallowed hard again and feared Catra's

answer. She believed Catra never would. Certainly not intentionally, not consciously. But, over those conflicted years, she saw a very different side of Catra and she wasn't completely sure.

Fear and uncertainty were in the eyes that looked at Catra. She couldn't look at them and instead looked to the side. She gave a gentle, "I don't know."

Adora snapped, "What do you mean, you don't know!?" She felt she deserved a much better answer than that. Catra furrowed her brows at her while Adora forced herself to apologize for what she thought was an understandable outburst, "I'm sorry...," she calmed, "I'm sorry. Can you please elaborate?" Adora pulled over a chair from the table and sat. Her heart beat just a little harder in her chest.

Catra attempted to look into Adora's eyes again, "I don't know how far I would have gone. There were times…," even Catra was afraid to say it, afraid to admit it. She became quiet, "I might have," quieter, "I don't know."

Adora hated this. She thought Catra was just beating around the bush. So, she recalled past times when she thought Catra was going to kill her. She recalled the time when she was searching for Light Hope and how Catra had deliberately cut the mucus-like binds so she would fall to her death in the ancient ruin.

Catra gave a soft huff, almost a laugh which caused Adora to sour as if thinking a painful and unwanted death was laughable. She still remembered the fear she had. Catra didn't mean anything by her reaction. It was just exactly that, a reaction. She raised a hand as if to apologize and answered, "I knew you'd be fine. I wasn't *as* angry with you then."

"How could you *possibly* know?" she shook her head and looked at her in disbelief.

Catra tapped next to her eye twice, "I can see in the dark, remember?" she flexed her brows, "We've fallen onto- we've," she

huffed again, this time more of a scoff, "we've been *thrown* onto garbage as punishment in the Fright Zone!" She paused for a moment, "I was upset and angry with you. That place showed me every moment how *conveniently* oblivious you were, how you just *get a pass* ." Adora wanted to emphasize her current efforts but Catra stopped her, "I know, I know, becoming better." She closed her eyes at the remembrance, "It wasn't then."

Adora concentrated on Catra's reply. The implication she could have ended her at some point. She brought up the first attack on Bright Moon, "What would you have done if you had won? What would have done with *me?* "

Another quiet, "I don't know."

There it was. That indecisive 'maybe' that challenged her. It brought silent tears to her eyes. "I was disarmed," her voice shook subtly, "electrocuted, and bound while watching the world freeze and burn around me, Catra." She sniffed and leaned forward, "What were you going to do to me?"

Catra looked at her knowing Adora wouldn't allow her to look away. Tears of her own trickled down her cheeks and her voice cracked a whisper, "I don't know."

Adora snapped again, "How can you-" she stopped herself and slammed her fists on her thighs out of frustration. She looked away and tried to calm herself but she was only getting more worked up with the thought of her life ending by the hands of someone she thought she loved.

Catra pleaded, "I couldn't NOW! Isn't that BETTER!? Wouldn't *you* end *me* after what I did to your *friends!?* After what I did to your precious whispering woods!?"

Adora's head snapped to look at Catra, "I *NEVER* had that *thought!* THIS, CATRA!" she threw her arms up to refer to the temple that imprisoned them, "THIS IS THE WORST," she cringed, "this is the worst I could do to you." A breath, "And *if* we die here,

it’s because I fucked up. But I *never* intended to harm you. You are my *everything!* ”

Catra had looked at her with a bit of disgust, “You don’t even know what ‘everything’ is.”

Adora looked at her, confused, shocked, and offended, “How can you say that?”

Catra got up and walked past to the table behind her. She grabbed a wooden chair and raised it over her head. With a breath, she grit her teeth and smashed the legs first.

Adora was caught off guard, completely baffled by the sudden destruction, “What are you-”

Catra slammed the other parts of the chair repeatedly until it was in pieces. And while Catra needed to vent and release her bottled anger, there was another purpose. “Come here and *look* .” Adora cautiously walked over. Catra then slapped a piece of the chair onto the table. It clacked loudly that echoed in the room. “You were the closest thing to protection I had,” she slammed another piece on top of the other, “You were my warmth when I was cold,” another, “my *only* friend,” another, “my help,” and another, “the only person who kept me alive.” She looked at Adora directly, “And then you found that fucking sword.” She pushed all the pieces to the floor with a loud clatter. She glared at Adora, “ *That’s* everything. But you wouldn’t know because without me, you still had all those things.” Catra walked past her again to sit on the bed. She faced away and hugged her knees.

Adora nodded into a hard frown, “Fine, that’s me, right there,” she pointed to the floor despite Catra unable to see it. She didn't agree that Catra needed to destroy a chair for the analogy but it was what it was. She picked up and tossed a piece of the chair on the table, “I have my sword,” Catra rolled her teary eyes to the sound of a piece clunk on the table, “I have friends who I love,” Catra immediately got up to leave the library. It was like Adora was mocking her. But Adora screamed at her, “You will let me

finish!” Catra stood still while her tail twitched. She hadn’t heard Adora shriek like that before and could only turn half way to look at her. “I love my friends, okay?” Her voice getting more hoarse as it was harder to contain her cries, “if anything happens to them, it hurts me so much, just like you wanted! All these pieces,” she shook them towards Catra, “are the people who took me in, gave me a place to stay, fed me, and gave me a chance even though I was their enemy! But YOU, you are NONE of these pieces!” Catra cringed hard and headed for the door again. But again, Adora shrieked, “YOU AREN’T PIECES CATRA! YOU’RE THIS FUCKING TEMPLE! YOU’RE ALL OF ETHERIA! YOU’RE EVERYTHING TO ME!”

Adora’s outburst kept Catra frozen in place again. Adora swallowed her cries so loudly Catra could hear the throaty gulp. They both took a moment to just breathe. Catra responded with a cracked whisper, “Why?”

Adora couldn't bear Catra just standing there. She went to her quickly and intended to pull her back to the bed but was compelled to hug her instead. She cried over her shoulder and tried not to be too loud and muffled them. Catra hesitated but returned the hug just as intensely. When she was able, Adora spoke again, “Because you took care of me through my entire life. Because you understand me. You get my dumb jokes. I can do anything with you and you just… you just *get it!*” Adora used Catra's shoulder to wipe a tear away. She hugged her tighter and gripped Catra's shirt, “I am so empty without you.” Adora gave a frustrated groan, “Why does this have to be so hard to explain?” She loosened her hug a little to look in Catra's eyes, “I’m not right without you. I wish I never found the sword. But I also wish we were never in the Fright Zone.” She took another moment to look at Catra and breathe. “I need to sit down.”

Adora grabbed Catra's hand and brought her back to the bed. They sat together in silence. If they were to say anything they'd likely fall apart again. Neither of them could understand how they could care about each other so much and yet have so much between them.

Catra mustered enough courage to finally admit it. That awful truth she herself feared. She groaned out, “I would have…,” she groaned into another cry, “I would have regretted it!” She closed her eyes and gripped the sheets. Her claws effectively ripped holes in them. “I would have buried you and slept next to you until I died! I have no other purpose! And you're stupid to even trust me!”

Adora hung her head. She suspected Catra was leading to this with her unbelievable, ‘I don’t know,’ but actually hearing her admit it was devastating. She was overcome with a sickly turning of her stomach. The only thing that stopped her from getting up and leaving was the fact that Catra stated she would have regretted the act. She trembled a brief moment. She didn't want to ask but somehow the words slipped out, “H-how?” She didn't really wish to know.

Catra hated herself and couldn't speak. Too busy holding in her sobs to the very vivid image of Adora dead, she lifted her head slowly. She was ashamed she could even go so far. She lifted a trembling hand and without a word poked two fingers just below Adora's left scapula. She'd stab Adora in the back with her sword.

Adora shuddered to her touch and released a shakened breath, “Right…,” she said softly, “Because that's… that's what it felt like to you…, didn't it?”

Catra hugged herself while trying not to gag on every pained sob. She forced a nod. She ran tense fingers through her hair and got up to head to the door quickly.

Adora couldn’t bring herself to say the words out loud, *Don’t you dare leave! Don’t you dare!* But no words escaped her lips. It wasn’t until she heard the library door shut to a close did something come out, “Don’t-”

~oO0Oo~

Adora searched for Catra down the halls and glanced around each room. A glance, only because she was sure Catra was in her own room. Several hours passed since their talk - their fight - and she was tired but she'll be damned if she was sleeping alone even if Catra had the ability to push the extreme over the edge. There was reason and she needed to tell Catra.

She stood in front of Catra’s door and without hesitation, knocked on it hard. “Catra?” No answer led her to knock again. “Catra!?”

“Go away, Adora!” came the voice of someone who had given up all hope.

“Come to bed!” Adora demanded.

Catra groaned out of frustration, “Stop being such an idiot! We won't work! I'm not good for you!”

Adora hesitated her reply, “Okay! Come to bed anyway!”

Catra cringed in confusion, “What?”

“I'm coming in!” Adora slid the door down.

The room was very different. Books covered the floor, claw marks had etched every reflective surface, pillows ripped and de-feathered and de-fluffed. Anything that could have been lifted had been thrown. Everything that could be broken, was. Even Catra had hurt herself and it took a moment to notice with everything else that took Adora's attention.

It wasn't severe but Adora was sure it was undeniably painful. Two of Catra’s fingernails looked as it folded against itself. Not so far as to rip it off the nail bedding but enough to need some tender loving care. “You're hurt. Come on, let me-”

“I'm fine! Go away!” She hid her hand as she folded her arms.

“Prove it!” Adora held out her hand as if to shake Catra's.

“You'll leave if I do?” Adora nodded. “Fine.” She approached Adora and outstretched her hand but before she could grab Adora's, Adora had grabbed her wrist tightly and began to drag her out of the room. Catra tried to resist, “HEY! WHAT ARE Y- LET G-”

Adora held on with all her might to Catra struggling against her, “I’M LEAVING… WITH YOU!”

“ADORA! STOP IT!” Tears began to pool in her eyes.

“You're the idiot! Just stop…, just stop fighting me.” She still would not loosen her grip. “Either I'm going to fix your fingers or She-Ra is.”

~oO0Oo~

Adora kissed Catra’s bandaged fingers gently. The whole ordeal took less than five minutes but Adora pretended to observe them a bit longer to ask one simple question, “Do you want to sleep with me or She-Ra tonight?” A mild smirk crossed her face.

“Adora…,” finally a tone that was more calm and reasonable, “What's the point?” Adora glared at her until she received the answer to her question. Catra sighed with her eyes closed, “You.”

Adora smiled, “Come to bed, then.”

~oO0Oo~

Catra was the little spoon on the bed that night. Adora ran her fingers through Catra's hair. It felt good for the both of them.

Adora kissed Catra's shoulder and gave her a loving hug.

Catra couldn’t understand why Adora was being so affectionate. It didn’t feel right. Fearful of the answer she still whispered her question to it, “Why?”

Adora didn't answer right away but she adjusted herself a little bit to run her hands up Catra's back from under her shirt. Catra straightened her back to the sensation, both ticklish and pleasing. Adora spoke softly, “Would you let anyone else do that to you?” Catra shook her head ‘no’. Adora dragged her hands down this time to free them from Catra's shirt and then moved her hair so she could kiss Catra's neck. She kissed several times, as lovingly as she could, down to the nape of her neck. “What about that?” Catra released a breath she'd been holding and, again, shook her head ‘no’. Adora then traced her fingertips from Catra's shoulder to her spine, all the way down to her hip and briefly stopped, “Would you *ever* let anyone else…,” Adora focused greatly for any of Catra's feedback and slowly and gently let her fingers follow the length of her tail. She pulled the tip to her lips and kissed it. Adora continued, “...do that?” Catra gasped and tensed a little which caused Adora to think she crossed a line but luckily Catra shook her head again. Adora snuggled in close while wrapping an arm around Catra’s waist. She sighed softly into the back of Catra's neck, “I have more reason not to give up and I already had a lot to begin with.”

That she did. Adora reasoned to herself that after all that was said, Catra would have taken her life out of passion instead of vengeance. A past as tortured as theirs, as *Catra’s* , Adora could understand more than she'd like and it was enough to convince her to keep Catra close. After all, Catra would have regretted following through. The guilt that consumed Catra was obvious and she even admitted she couldn't bring herself to end Adora's life anymore. It was progress. It was growth.

~oO0Oo~

They continued their routine. Each morning, they'd wake. If Adora woke first, she waited for Catra with a smile to which Catra had often shoved her face way - gently, mind you.

Catra groaned, "Adora! Stop doing that, it's so creepy."

Once, when Catra woke first, she glared wide eyed at Adora. It had scared her off the bed with a startling gasp when Adora woke.

Adora curled her fingers in the air, "ASS!" Catra couldn't stop cackling.

They raced around the temple after breakfast to keep their bodies healthy but some days were skipped in order to maintain their food supply. Most of the day had been spent with Adora pushing herself to make portals larger. Catra read more First One's books the more she got the hang of the phonetics. She'd even discuss some of the philosophies with Adora. Sometimes she'd find out more about the temple they were in.

"These, doors…, Adora…, these *doors* are designed this way because these stuck up First Ones wanted their slaves-"

Adora corrected, " *Servants* ."

"How do you know? They sound like slaves, Adora. Anyway, they wanted them to BOW *every* time they open and close the doors for them! The *Horde* doesn't even do this!"

They continued their talks in the evening. Arguments were fought but not as hard as their first serious talk. Although, one had come close. Catra had brought up, on more than one occasion, how Adora effectively ruined her progression with the war. Each day that went by made her less confident she could go back to Horde under the guise of her allegiance. Adora tried to state the obvious that she didn't and couldn't know with Catra killing Rebellion forces. Catra would then retort that people wouldn't die if Adora

actually knew how to lead. They spent a few long hours apart after that. They came to realize that they were accustomed to using words that hurt rather than ones that would resolve their conflicts. Catra was still angry but she agreed to hold her tongue if Adora did the same. It took Adora admitting she really didn't know what she was doing as a leader to start the conversation again. It was the only way to get Catra to return to bed those nights. She told Catra that she hadn't been able to think clearly since they broke up.

"I told you, Catra, I'm not right without you."

That wasn't Catra's problem to fix and Adora knew this. Adora tried to explain that it wasn't the reason she was trying to reconcile either. Catra seemed unconvinced but dismissed it.

In three months time their discussions were gradually becoming less like work. They were getting closer. And the biggest news was Adora was ready to try the next experiment.

Catra looked at Adora with a questioning brow, "You're *sure* you can hold it open?" The concern was clear to both of them. The "chair test" didn't fare so well three weeks prior. If anything were to touch the edge of the portal it was cut through without resistance and Adora, or rather, She-Ra would feel a sharp pain in her mind. It was difficult for her to describe as it was not the physical pain one would expect. It disrupted her magic "painfully" and Adora had no other way to communicate the unpleasant nature of that interaction. Luckily "chair test three" was successful.

"I can do it! I wouldn't ask you to try if I wasn't sure. Come on, I held it for like fifty seconds last time. I'm feelin' good!" Adora did look confident with that smile. She looked strong and ready for anything.

"Alright, just so we're clear, the plan is, you transform, you open the entry-portal on *this* side of the door," she pointed to it, "you

open the exit-portal on the *other* side of the door. When you say, 'go,' I go through it as fast as I can."

Adora nodded and added, "Without touching the edges, so tuck your-"

"I got it."

They got ready. Catra stood next to Adora who then transformed into She-Ra. Catra then crouched down to a ready stance and faced the closed door in the Library. Her tail seemed to twitch nervously and she kept adjusting her feet in small nudges. Adora noticed the tail, "Are you gonna tuck-"

"On the jump, I need it out."

"Okay," a breath, "Here we go." She-Ra exhaled slowly and poured her energy into an entry-portal. "I'm gonna make the exit portal point down the hall so you don't run into the other wall."

"Keep it simple!"

"It's fine!" She began to grunt into the exit portal and Catra watched the view in front of her to align slowly to the hall. "I-is that good?"

"Just say 'GO!'"

"GO!"

Catra kicked off the ground hard and darted for that portal. *I will beat your ass if I run into this wall, Adora.* Catra was increasingly getting nervous as the size of the portal began to slightly grow and shrink to her approach and to the sound of She-Ra groaning louder. *Fuck it!* She sprinted harder, jumped while her arm quickly brought her tail in, and held her breath.

She-Ra felt a surge through her body and she could no longer hold the portal open. She seemed to cough out a hefty grunt, "HA!" and fell to a knee. She transformed back to Adora

completely out of breath and dropped her sword to the ground. “Catra?” came out softly. There was no answer and Adora’s concern grew exponentially. True panic rose in her voice, “ *Catra!?”*

The door slid down and the sound of a guttural chuckle came with it. The tightness around Adora’s heart loosened and she fell backwards to the floor with a smile of relief. Catra came in running towards Adora and pounced on her with a brilliant smile, “YOU DID IT!” She immediately planted her lips on Adora’s and kissed her. She ran her hands through her hair. She kissed her cheek, her jawline, her neck, her shoulder.

Adora returned a laugh, “Catr- AH!” she hummed more laughter into another one of Catra’s kisses. In the brief moment they separated, “Catra, I can’t move.”

“Perfect,” she said with a devious smile and went further as to lift Adora’s shirt up a little. Catra’s lips peppered Adora’s ribs, her waist, her navel, and so long as Adora was still giggling, she didn’t stop.

Every kiss, every dragging of Catra’s tongue, every soft suck, heated breath, and gentle clawing of Adora’s sides sent her heart racing. Adora seemed more out of breath than before, “C-Cat-t-rr-HAA!” Adora’s mind dizzied from Catra’s relentless attacks. She wanted to retaliate with her own barrage but her fatigued and damnable limbs just would not move. She was forced, happily, to endure Catra’s onslaught.

Catra leaned over her with a subtle grin, “Hey, Adora.”

Damn that delicious voice of hers, Adora thought.

“I think you should come to bed,” that grin getting ever wider. Adora's eyes fluttered briefly and she took a breath. She was completely speechless and nodded her reply. Catra gripped Adora’s shirt and the waistband of her pants and proceeded to lift her at ease to the bed. Catra brushed the back of her fingers

against Adora’s cheek and then felt her lips with her thumb. She looked into Adora’s eyes again, “Are you actually okay?” Her concern was casual but sincere. “You up for this?”

A surge of energy to the question came over her. She quickly placed her hands on Catra’s face and kissed her back. She flopped back to her pillow, a little breathless, “I seriously can't move any more,” she exhaled into laughter. “But I *really* want to.”

A gentle finger had traced the line just above her waistband, “Then I guess I'll have to punish you for failing to serve me.”

Damn that seductive voice. Damn those hands getting dragged down Adora’s thighs. But that damned tongue of hers, that gets a pass.

~oO0Oo~

Strength returned to Adora’s arms. Her legs still trembled lightly and the bite marks on her inner thigh were still sore. It was only two, Catra defended. She rested on top of Adora, teasing with hot breath on Adora’s neck just behind her ear. To which that ear received gentle licks on the edges that sent shivers down her body. Adora would narrow her eyes each time, *Just a few more minutes, Catra, just a few more.* But Catra knew what she was doing. She knew what buttons to press and where they all were.

A hidden grin appeared on Catra’s face. She gently mocked a whine in Adora’s ear, “Adora?” She swore she could feel Adora’s heart beat harder against her. “When is it going to be *my* turn?” She couldn’t help release a laugh against Adora’s tightening hands around her waist.

Adora did a hard sit up, forcing Catra backwards. An evil grin grew on Adora’s face, “You think you’re going to get off easy?” Catra thought it was all talk until Adora gripped the base of her tail. She

pressed both her thumbs gently on the underside of it and dragged to the tip. Catra's brain ceased to function to the sensation. She could hardly breathe against the repetitive tugging. Adora leaned towards her and giggled into her ear, "You're not the only one that bites either." Adora proceeded to softly kiss Catra's cheek and lips. She made her way to Catra's collar bone and to her chest.

Catra's head finally caught up with her when Adora's breath had reached her breast, "A-Ad-dora! I'm really-," Adora's mouth had already planted itself, "d-don't bi- AH!" She moaned to those teeth gently sinking into her. As if Adora would be so cruel as to actually bite hard. Catra pressed Adora's head into her chest to a point where Adora had to actually resist with further giggling. Adora forced Catra's arms above Catra's head and laced those fingers with hers, "I didn't get a chance to use my hands, so neither can you."

Another soft grin and Adora continued her assault.

~oO0Oo~

Both lain on the bed as neither of them cared to do anything else. Adora was compelled to massage Catra's head, her arm, anywhere where she could reach with soft and loving touch. She just didn't want to separate.

Catra breathed in slow and exhaled just as slowly, "Sorry about the...:," she waved a finger over her arm. Catra's nails had dug into Adora's shoulder during one of Adora's invasive attacks. The light breaking of Adora's skin was something Catra could not care to focus on as the barrage of sensations had her mind elsewhere and nowhere. "I'll cut them next time."

Adora hummed a chuckle, "Next time?"

Catra rolled her eyes, “I said it before Adora, you look stupid with that face.”

Another louder, hummed chuckle, “You’re not gonna have time for ‘next time.’” She snickered as she leaned over to lick behind Catra’s ear.

“What’s wrong with y-ho-MMmnnGggHA!”

~oO0Oo~

“Hungry!” Adora shouted, “MAKE ME SOMETHING!” Nothing but an incredulous look from Catra. Her narrowed eyes seemed to burn into Adora but it hadn't stopped Adora from laughing. “Please?”

Catra playfully shoved her, “You go, I'm pretty sure you’re *my* dumb, obedient servant.”

Adora held a shocked smirk and shoved her back, “Come on! I’m tiii-errrd!” she whined. She mocked cried and pouted while shaking Catra’s shoulders.

Catra exhaled through her lips and caused them to flap while she looked up and away from Adora, “Ugh! FINE!” She sat up and scooched to the edge of the bed to put on some pants. After months of wearing Bright Moon’s clothing, she actually wasn’t sure she could ever go back to wearing her tattered Horde uniform. “Which bland crap do you want?” She walked around the other side of the bed to grab a shirt. She let her tail curl around Adora’s face.

“AH! Tickles.” Catra smiled to this. Adora didn’t care what Catra would give her, anything they had to eat tasted nearly the same. “Mm surprise me.”

With a smirk, “Idiot.” Catra walked away as her tail dragged across Adora’s throat.

“Tickles! Tickles! Tickles!”

~oO0Oo~

Catra lowered the door to the supply room. She hadn’t been there herself for months and it was daunting how bare the shelves were since the last time she was there. Isle after isle of just nothing besides the settled dust. A tinge of worry at the sight came over her but quickly vanished. She began walking in and considered spending some of her days moving the inventory from the far end of the room to the front so it wouldn’t be such a task to get it. It wasn’t like she didn't have the time.

As she approached the twentieth isle, the base of her tail began to bush and a peculiar scent waft in her nose. It was faint where she was but it grew stronger as she neared the end of the room. She quickened her pace and the smell became more distinct. Panic began to race Catra’s heart and her eyes darted everywhere searching for the source. She curled her fingers angrily knowing the scent now. Urine. She saw small spots on the floor littered with tiny feces. She came across a shelf still stocked with boxes and looked through each. A hole in the sides. She picked one up and saw only crumbs. She threw it to the floor and picked up another. Again, crumbs. She raced down the isles searching until she finally heard it. That squeak that just decided their fates that day. That squeak that decided its fate.

She found it and she darted after it quickly. She crashed through the shelf and onto the other side and chased it as it serpentined this way and that to get away. She gained on it and took anything off the shelf, a box of rations, and threw it hard. It was a miss but it was disoriented enough for Catra to pounce.

She held it in her hands as it tried to squirm free. It tried to bite but it could not angle its head down enough to sink its teeth into her. It couldn’t even scratch with it’s arms laced in Catra’s fingers but onward it tried to wriggle away to no avail.

Catra stared at it. She resisted the overwhelming urge to squeeze the life out of it slowly. Her arms flexed and her face cringed with anger and fear at the thought of no longer having enough food to last until Adora is able to get both of them out. She was so angry at Adora for putting her there. Angry at herself that she just couldn’t forgive her. Angry at the rat that had no other purpose other than to consume. But Catra will give it purpose. She placed the claw of her thumb on its head, “If it weren’t for Adora,” she glared with tears pooling in her eyes, “if it weren’t for Adora, I’d open you up and make you watch me pull out your insides you FUCKING ASSHOLE!” She sniffed hard, “You will thank her for her mercy,” her hands trembled, “with your worthless life!”

It gave a final squeak as Catra pressed hard and pierced its brain. Its body, limp, its heart, still, and its mouth never to eat any remaining morsel in the inventory ever again. Catra took a breath and left with the rat in hand. She headed towards the kitchen to give it purpose.

Chapter End Notes

> If you've read this chapter, you are REQUIRED to review :) ... please. I think there's some rough patches especially with the whole, chair breaking scene and I just.. meh. BUT what I'm most interested in is if I've done the erotic fluff properly (18 or older users only please - I do not wish to converse with underaged readers who shouldn't be reading this). Anyway, yes it's fluff, but it's fluff i want to get right. It will be something I will rework if I got it wrong
>
> Having a smidge of trouble with the next chapter. SO, I have a cliffhanger for my A Plot in mind BUT I need to wrap up some stuff with my B Plot. Do I start Chapter 8 with what's happening with Glimmer, Bow, and the gang so I can end the

chapter with the A Plot cliff hanger? OR do I start with the A Plot so it's a continuation from this chapter and I don't interrupt the flow? This would leave the cliffhanger right in the middle of the story - OR - I could continue the hanger at the end of the chapter but then it gets messy.

So this wasn't as heart stomping as I intended. The cliff hanger in chapter 8 should do it but still working on it :/

Chapter 08

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra had spent the time skinning, carving, and cooking the rat by thinking about how she was going to tell Adora the news. She was going to take time tallying how much food remained but she couldn't delay any longer. She came to one conclusion, there was no good way to tell Adora that she had even less time to get them out. She silently tensed and groaned in her mind. The rat was ready, “Fuck, fuck, FUCK!” There was nothing good to come from this.

~oO0Oo~

Adora sat on the bed and relaxed with a smile while Catra was out. Unfortunately, Adora had a knack for overthinking. She thought that Catra had only showed affection because Adora was closer to getting her out of that temple. That the sex was meaningless. Pent up passion just waiting to be released with another warm body. Familiar words rang in her mind, *It doesn't mean I like you* . But, damn it, she already admitted that she had. She scolded herself, *STOP THINKING, ADORA!* She scratched her scalp as if there had been a terrible itch and forced herself to relax. She decided to get up, get dressed, and sit at the library table. Luckily, there were still five other chairs available for smashing.

Catra eventually came into the library holding the hot meat. She was deep in thought and Adora was beginning to think she was right about Catra's affection. No smile. Stoic as ever. Got hopes up for nothing.

Catra placed the food down and tried to force a happier tone but her voice was flat, “Enjoy.”

Adora tried to lighten the mood and buried her nose in the food. She took a large whiff, and while she thought to be sarcastic about how good her usual bland rations smelled, she was actually surprised that it did. She looked up at Catra, “Wow, what did you do? This smells wonderful.”

Catra raised a brow. To her, the scent was quite potent, “You couldn't smell it from where I came in?”

Adora was reluctant to answer at first, “I haven't been able to smell since Shadow Weaver's punishments,” she wanted to quickly get back to her question, “Seriously, what did you do to make it smell like this?” She took a bite, again expecting the tastelessness, “Catra!” her eyes widened, “You are a natural chef! Hey, you know what this reminds me of…?”

Catra certainly had an idea, “Burger from the Fright Zone?”

Astonished, “Yes!” She threw her hands up, “Exactly! You know it's impossible to find this in Bright Moon or, like, ANYWHERE! How did you make this?” She took another bite and then thought to offer some to Catra, “Here, open.” She smiled at her and waited.

Catra really needed to get the information out but she opened her mouth regardless. The flavor was incredible compared to the dried rations by far. She forced herself after a hard swallow, “Look, Adora-”

Adora thought it had to come sooner or later. She sighed quickly and dropped her shoulders. You could see the disappointment on her face, “I get it Catra, you don't have to say anything. ‘It was fun but don't look forward to more,’ I get it. Please just let me enjoy this?” Her eyes plead.

Catra closed her eyes to process, “What? No. Idiot. I'm not talking about…,” she groaned a frustrated sigh briefly and pulled Adora

into a kiss and released, “That,” she pointed to the bed, “was great and real.” She gave Adora a moment and continued, “I need to tell you something and you need to listen. It's bad, not us-bad, just…, shut up and listen.” She took a deep breath, “I-I found it in the inventory room. I-I mean,” a heavy sigh, “It tastes like the food we used to have because it essentially is.” She watched Adora try to put the pieces together but was too impatient and just came out with it, “A rat, I found a rat.”

Adora turned white and swallowed the piece of food that was in her mouth. Panic and fear, as Catra had, washed over her like embers from hot coals. She grabbed her sword that laid on the table and ran to the supply room abruptly and swiftly.

“Adora!” Catra wanted to calm her down but there was no way of doing that in this scenario. She rubbed her face, uttered another, “Fuck,” and got up to go after her.

~oO0Oo~

Frantic, Adora ran down the isles to look for more vermin. She cursed herself for not even considering that wildlife could get in before she trapped Catra. She cursed herself for ever having conjured the idea. Tears built as she angrily searched. She was so furious at herself. She kept thinking she just killed Catra. Her breath became heavier, and the more she went through the isles, she felt her heart beat so hard it was dizzying.

Catra came in the room and searched for Adora. She tried to think of a way to calm her down but unfortunately no ideas came. She needed her calm so they could make a careful count of what was left. “Adora!” she called out.

Filled with panic in the distance, “IF THERE'S ONE, THERE'S MORE! HELP ME LOOK!”

The fear in Adora’s voice was almost contagious. Catra forced the feeling away and caught up with her. She stepped in front of a distraught face peppered with sweat. Tears streamed down Adora's cheeks and she tried to push Catra out of her way to continue her search but Catra firmly grasped Adora's shoulders, “Adora! Not all of it is gone! We need to calm down.”

Adora spoke hysterically. Every word came with such vigor, “I JUST KILLED US! HOW THE FUCK CAN I CALM DOWN!? I CAN’T DO IT, CATRA! I NEED-” she struggled to get air in her lungs.

Catra pat her back, unsure if it was really helping, “Breathe, Adora! Just breathe.”

After several gulping breaths, Adora finished what she was saying, “I need more time, Catra. I wasn’t even sure I could do it with the time that we *had!* ” Adora screamed a quick and hard, “ *FUCK!* ” Her scream filled the room and throughout the halls.

Adora was completely out of breath and knelt to the floor. Every single one of her muscles wanted to destroy something in the temple; namely everything. Catra didn’t have much leverage for consoling but she gave it a go anyway. With a calm voice, “Alright, so we’re fucked. Let’s just get over it.” She received an incredulous, cringing glare and even Catra thought the words she chose could have been better. “Look, I’ll give you as much time as I can. We’re both gonna have to cut back but I’ll do it more. I don’t want you to give up. You’ve gotten so far and I want to see it ‘til the end,” she paused a moment to make sure Adora was listening, “But I need to find out how much we have left…, okay?” Catra waited for some form of confirmation.

Adora rolled back to a sitting position and her breath slowly became more steady. She gave the nod that Catra was looking for and spoke quietly, “We still need to see if there's more.”

“I didn't smell any but I'll make sure when we're going through inventory. Go back and eat.” Catra did her best to give her some semblance of hope but it generally wasn't her field of expertise.

She had no other words of comfort and if she continued she might have said, “Try not to think about how fucked we are.”

Adora squinted hard with fists even tighter and then released. Adora grabbed Catra's wrist, “You're eating it with me.” Adora's eyes were fierce. Catra had no choice but to follow her back. Adora was far too distraught to say ‘no’ to even though Catra thought it would be wiser to have Adora finish the meal herself.

When they sat together, side by side, Adora divided the meat in half. Catra tried to protest but was quickly silenced. Adora made her point, “I won’t stand for you to have less than me. Bare minimum, Catra…, bare minimum we split everything equally. That’s all I ask.” Her voice was almost a whimper. Adora took a stab at the meat and handed the fork to Catra, “C’mon, I don’t get any more than you do.” Catra was hesitant to take the fork. The sound of Adora’s voice fighting her tears crushed Catra’s heart. Catra no longer thought that Adora was just going to cry then try harder. Adora gave up.

“Only if you’re willing to keep trying. Otherwise, I’d rather quicken the pace.” Adora looked at her with panicked eyes and startled gaze. Adora looked down with those eyes widening and with quickened breath. “Adora, there’s no point if you don’t try. I believe you can do it. I really do, Adora, but you gotta try,” she placed a gentle hand on Adora’s face and lifted it up slightly, “We’ll take inventory, do the math, and then do what we can.” Catra stayed calm. She knew if she gave into her emotions she’d be feeding the fire. She looked for acknowledgement but before it was given she took the bite as if she forced Adora’s hand to sign a contract. “Now you have to.”

“Catra-”

Catra quickly placed a finger on Adora’s forehead, “Nope. Just eat. When we’re done, inventory. That’s it. Keep it simple.”

Adora closed her uneasy eyes and swayed her head left and right once. With a breath she gave a subtle nod.

“Good,” Catra handed back the fork.

~oO0Oo~

Adora was still clearly distraught. She was unfocused as she stared blankly at the empty shelves with a hand resting on a bare ledge. Catra decided to give her simple tasks to keep her moving and occupied. Catra would actually do the count while she made Adora move the boxes that contained food closer to the door. When Adora wasn’t looking, Catra would discard the empty and chewed up containers.

It went on like this for hours. Catra’s hands were drying out from the dusty preservatives in the boxes. And, each box was checked to see if some portion of food, if any, could be salvaged. She felt nauseous from the scent of urine and droppings behind her. And the rate in which Adora had moved the containers and come back was faster than Catra could actually find food for her to move. She needed Adora to stay positive with the idea of, “Look at all the food we still have” but it wasn’t enough to make that kind of impact.

When it was all complete, they both walked to the front and looked at the remainder. It was more than they expected but far less than they needed. If they were to continue their diet as is, they’d have about a month and a half before it was completely consumed instead of the four months and a week they originally had. If they were to both cut back equally, Catra could give Adora another month. If Catra sacrificed a little more for her, she could give two and a half.

Catra grabbed Adora’s hand to get her attention, “Hey…, we’ll have to be smart about this. Cut back slowly. But we can do it. The upside of this is that we don’t have to worry about water.”

" *You* thought of an upside?" Adora tried to laugh. What else was she going to do? She was beginning to accept what was in front of her. Other thoughts had invaded her mind but the core conflict in front of her was no longer worth the effort to weep another tear.

"Pff, fuck you." Catra tried to smile but what came was just a gentle raising of her brows. "Come on. Today we rest. We don't need to keep staring at this."

They left the storage room. About halfway to the library, Catra's hands bothered her with an increasing dry itch that went beyond the point of toleration. She let Adora know that she was going to stop at the pools first since it was closer and let Adora head back to the library. Adora looked away with her acknowledgement and Catra wasn't sure why. Catra knew she wouldn't be long and thought to attack it later. Adora was vulnerable and needed support but the itch was persistent.

The moment without Adora gave Catra time to wonder why Adora wasn't angry with her. The reduction of food would not be a problem if Catra would just forgive her. Why then? Why wasn't Adora furious? It bothered her. It was unfortunate for Catra that trust was always in question. Shadow Weaver still haunted her and Adora would occasionally trigger those trust issues in particular. She questioned if Adora's lack of fury was a means to manipulate her. To convince her with insincere kindness. Catra quickly suppressed the thought as she often did. If it weren't for Shadow Weaver, Catra wondered if she'd be able to be a better person like Adora.

She swirled and clawed the water in the pool. Her hands began to feel refreshed and the itch dissipated quickly. The crisp coolness from the residual water traversing between her fingers sent a slight chill as she shook the droplets away. She rubbed her hands quickly, a final shake in the air, and dried them on her pants. She looked around once and decided to head back to the library.

~oO0Oo~

Catra pulled the door to the library down and, ever since she learned of the First One's servants, she made a conscious effort not to bend too lowly. As she let the door drop, Adora lightly gasped at her entrance and quickly wiped away tears that had been pooling in her eyes. Catra's pillow had been tightly wrapped with her arms. She quickly flipped it to hide the teary wetness she had left behind.

She took a big sniff through her nose and tried to normalize her voice as if nothing happened, "Hey," another sniff and a quick exhale, "you're back?" She gave a light cough to clear her throat and forced herself to steady.

Inquisitive eyes looked at Adora, "Am I not supposed to be?"

Adora sat up on the edge of the bed and placed her hands between her knees. She shook her head subtly, "I just thought you wouldn't want to see me. I thought… you needed to be away…," she came to a whisper, "after everything I did."

Catra returned a smirk as she walked closer to her, "That was always your problem, Adora."

Adora lifted her head to look at Catra, "What is?"

"You *'thinking'* never did you any good." She sat down next to her. "I'm done being away from you."

Another subtle shake of Adora's head. She just couldn't understand. Joking aside, Catra was unexpectedly gentle. "Why aren't you furious with me?" Her fingers began to grip the folds in her pants tightly.

A soft huff. The irony. Catra leaned backwards on the bed and threw her hands up into a shrug and then let them drop to the bed, "I don't know. I really don't have anything else left to lose

with you here.” She then outstretched a hand to Adora's shoulder and pulled her backwards to have her lie next her. She turned her head towards Adora, “Hey…, I'm sorry I'm so damaged. I just… *can't* forget. I really am tryi-”

“Don't ever apologize for that,” Adora turned and leaned on her arms over Catra, “That is *not* your fault.” She stared into Catra who was a little startled by the seriousness of her tone. Adora blinked into her realization that it may have been too dramatic. She rolled back to the bed and spoke quietly, “It just isn’t.”

Catra bumped her hand with Adora’s and spoke with the same solemn tone, “Thanks.”

~oO0Oo~

Each day, they cut back just a little more. Hunger was their biggest enemy besides time. Catra ate the same portions as Adora every time they ate. It was a promise to Adora she kept but she was going to have to put her foot down soon. Catra couldn't stand seeing Adora put all her energy into her magic while she simply rested and did nothing. Adora was definitely losing weight faster than Catra and she had enough.

The next meal, Adora was given her cut-back portion plus Catra’s half. Adora furrowed her brows at her. Catra glared back without a word at first until Adora was about to pull the “promise” card. Catra put her hand on the table and leaned in, “We can waste time fighting about it and I force feed it to you or you can simply accept that what's in front of us is actually equal. You need it, Adora. Eat!”

Hunger had left Adora emotional. Catra's logic was hard to refute but seeing how much smaller Catra's portion was to hers had brought tears to her eyes. She wanted to fight back but she had nothing left to fight back with.

“Adora,” she placed her hand on Adora's cheek, “don't worry about me. This is enough. I sleep all day, remember?” A slight tilt of her head asked for Adora's affirmation. She received the nod she was looking for. “Good.” She gave Adora's cheek a kiss and started to eat as soon as Adora took her first bite.

~oO0Oo~

Time was quickly running low. Only two weeks were left until all food was depleted. Adora trained hard while Catra did her best to support Adora. Besides providing more and more portions of her food, she massaged her head, she made sure she was well enough to continue. And, there were breakthroughs! Two chairs and a bowl had made their way outside the temple. Catra shouted and cheered, “I KNEW YOU COULD DO IT! I KNEW IT!”

Unfortunately, Adora needed the entire rest of the day to rest. She was brought to the medical station on several occasions. Adora’s head was always in pain. There were days where she had even lost her appetite and Catra had to sit with her to eat slowly. And, every day they needed to count how much food was left to keep track of time as the days began to blur.

~oO0Oo~

Once, when Catra had bathed alone, Adora opened a portal near herself as She-Ra. She tried to place her fingers through it. The surge was unlike anything she felt before. It was if she had poked her own mind with her fingers. The portal collapsed quickly and nearly took her fingers with it. She gave a few dry heaves as the sensation caused her stomach to turn sour. Nothing had come up as there was nothing left for her to puke. The taste of acid was

left in her mouth and she doubled over clutching her stomach as if she'd been punched. That was it. That was her answer when the time came.

She turned on her back and took deep breaths. The air had filled her lungs slowly, and luckily, she began to recuperate. The nausea went away but the pain behind her eyes remained. She panicked, *I don't want to die. I don't want to die!* She went through stages of anxiety quickly and tried to calm herself before Catra could discover her. She had to. A few more deep breaths and a decision. She wouldn't tell Catra.

~oO0Oo~

Three days left. Adora was confident she'd get Catra out. She was able to hold the portal open for a couple minutes now. She tried to convince herself that if she just ran through with Catra, it'd be worth the overwhelming negative consequences.

"I promise, you'll like Bright Moon, Catra. First thing you're gonna do…," she gave a soft chuckle, "you're gonna eat a feast." She smiled brightly on the bed. She was face to face with Catra with an hand underneath Catra's arm. "You're gonna meet everyone and you're gonna love 'em."

Catra scoffed with a smile in return, "Pff, ya, I'm sure they'll love me too." Catra's looked away, "Adora, when we get out, I can't-"

Adora rolled her eyes, "I'm pretty sure I destroyed all your plans with the Horde, Catra. We'll figure it out. You aren't leaving me." *I'm just going to run through it. No matter what, I'll do it. I just need to push myself.* "There are so many things I want to show you." If Adora started talking about the Horde, she was likely going to break down again. She needed the positive reinforcement.

Catra was having trouble reading Adora. She couldn't tell if she was excited or bordering hysterics. The pressure to get both of them free was clearly on Adora's mind. It was the one thing Catra couldn't relate to. Magic was out of her hands, an extension of the mind that she could only imagine. A tinge of jealousy lingered but otherwise she didn't care to possess the power herself. Especially with the indescribable "pain" Adora mentioned was something she was alright to be without. The physical pain and mental torment that Shadow Weaver inflicted was more than enough knowledge to discourage any curiosity about what Adora was going through.

Catra was getting the hang of her attempts at encouragement, "I know you can do it, Adora. But, if you don't, it's okay. And I know you don't want to fail, but I know you, you're going to beat yourself up until the very end. Don't." She hesitated a moment to catch one of Adora's tears with her thumb. "Just remember…, that's *my* job." She brought herself to smile and to laugh at her own silly joke. "You're gonna do great. And when we get out…, I will cut you up if you tell anyone I was this nice to you." This time Adora laughed. Catra leaned in to kiss Adora's lips and said those helpful words again, "You're gonna do great."

Adora nodded emphatically to agree with her. Adora brought her in close and hugged her to sleep. *I'm gonna do it.*

~oO0Oo~

"We have another day, Adora, are you *absolutely* sure?" Catra and Adora both stared at the last two boxes of food in the inventory. They haven't had a full serving of food in two months. They could either make it last one more day or settle their hungry stomachs for once and get out.

Adora hesitated her reply. She then grabbed both boxes and handed one to Catra, "One day isn't going to make a difference

and a full meal is something we need." Adora stated this firmly but she was overcome with profound nervousness. Those two boxes, that's it. A literal "do or die" scenario. The emergency gardens meant to supply extra food when all supplies were depleted were still two months away from fruiting. Any existing vegetation just wasn't consumable.

~oO0Oo~

They sat, side by side, at the small dining hall. Adora couldn't stop staring at her food with anxious breath. Catra placed an arm and her tail around Adora's hip to calm her, "You'll be fine," she gently pulled Adora's face toward her, "I'm not wrong." A not-so confident nod. "Do you want me to feed you?"

A nervous huff, "No…," another, "I can manage." She broke off a piece and ate it, "See?"

Dripping with sarcasm, "So proud." Catra really did try her best. The night before, while Adora was sound asleep, she placed her hand on the force field only to feel it's bite. Catra's memories still cursed her thoughts of ever being able to forgive Adora. She wanted to forgive so desperately but every time the thought were to announce itself, nothing but anger erupted. She couldn't understand it and she wanted to tell Adora but it was not a time to focus on the negative. She especially didn't want to surface the idea that neither of them knew the status of the war or who might be left alive. Lift Adora's spirits and continue to work on forgiveness after they get out, that's the goal. "Hey Adora, don't let your friends hug you for too long, I might get jealous." A smidge of a smirk to a grin tugged the corners of mouth.

A subtle laugh, "Only if you tell Scorpia the same thing."

Catra nearly spit her food, "You think I haven't already? She is a very aggressive hugger!"

Adora began to relax a little but unfortunately she was only trying to delay, "Did you ever hug her back?"

Catra looked away only to roll her head back to Adora, "Like once. I think I broke her." Adora chuckled at this but panic was still in her chest and tightened around her heart. Only a few bites left. Her breathing was starting to get erratic again. Catra quickly tried to soothe, "Hey, hey, focus on me. Look at me," she said calmly. Adora turned her head and focused. Catra continued, "I'm going to say something very serious, alright?" a brief pause, "If you can't do it then you can't do it. And I've been trying. I really have Adora. There's something wrong with me and I'm just fucked up." Adora tried to disagree but Catra quickly carried on, "Just listen. During the time between now and when we just *can't* go on, focus on me. We try the original plan and we break the barrier together." Catra slipped her hand into Adora's, "I want you safe and out of here. So, come on, I don't want to spend the rest of the day wondering if it's going to be spent in or out." Adora began to nod slowly and then quickly pulled Catra in by the collar and kissed her. Catra held her close in response.

She released, "Okay, let's get ready." She shoved the remainder of her food in her mouth and swallowed. She refused to look at her plate and got up. She took Catra by the hand and went to the Entrance hall.

~oO0Oo~

They quickly discussed the usual plan. The entrance portal, obviously, being on the inside of the temple but placed very close to the barrier as to reduce the distance between it and the exit portal. The exit portal, similarly, would be placed outside the barrier. Adora was actually unsure how far that was exactly but two of the chairs in previous tests she sent through answered that question. Catra would sprint through the portal and Adora would

attempt to hurl herself through it regardless of the consequences. Adora and Catra spent the next ten minutes mentally preparing themselves.

Catra went to the library to get Adora's sword. When she came back, she tilted the hilt towards Adora, "Let's get out of here." A reassuring smile as she squeezed Adora's arm when she took the sword.

Adora quickly wrapped her other arm around Catra, "I, um, just whatever happens-"

Catra sighed into her shoulder, "Don't worry Adora."

"Just know that I really did try my best." Adora kissed her cheek and released. She took a deep breath, "I'm ready."

Catra readied herself with a smile. She squat down and faced the doors of the temple. She shifted her feet like she had before to make sure they were secure and wouldn't slip on the kick off. She was much closer this time, only a few arm lengths away. She nodded at Adora.

Adora positioned herself very close to the adjacent wall. Only a hair away from touching the barrier herself. She changed to She-Ra, "Only when I say 'go.'" Catra gave a nod. Another deep breath, *I can do this.* She pointed the sword to the doors, grit her teeth, and released all that she had to creating those portals. She pushed the exit portal farther and farther to ensure Catra could not be hurt by the barrier. "GO!"

Catra kicked hard. She pushed herself as quickly as possible. Anything to give Adora more time to get herself through. Before she knew it, Catra was tripping on thick foliage. Her heart pounded into her throat and she was breathless, "I'm through. ADORA! I'M THROUGH!" she turned around to face the exit portal quickly.

Adora tried to take a few running steps. Sweat poured out of her face and she was horrified to find that the portal wasn't big

enough for her. She froze and closed her eyes, “I-I-I ne-” she was so tired, “make it bigger,” it came out as a whisper. She gave it another push. It widened as she groaned in pain. She opened her eyes and could only see darkness. Blank eyes searched for the portal but nothing revealed itself. Her chest heaved with panicked breath. “Catra! I-I can’t see!”

“Adora! COME ON!”

Adora felt the portal closing again. She just couldn’t hold it any more. “Catra!” her voice shrieked with fear, “CATRA, I LOVE YOU!” Smaller and smaller the portal went. Her voice screamed a whisper, “I’m sorry!” The portal simply disintegrated to nothingness. Adora fell backwards. The world felt as if it had slammed into her. Darkness enveloped her. Sound ceased except for the whispering breaths escaping her lungs. Her arm, now pressed against the barrier, but no resistance came from it.

~oO0Oo~

“ADORA! ADORA! NO!” Catra clawed at the air as if to try to physically open the portal again. She couldn’t believe it. Her whole body trembled. *I should have pulled her. We should have gone together. I should have- “ADORA!”* Her shrieking voice echoed through the air. Birds quickly fluttered away. Sounds of life scattered through the nearby leaves and vegetation. A whispering cry, “Come back.” *I have to find her. I have to get her!* Catra looked ahead. Only trees and bushes and intertwining vines. There was no temple. She clawed at everything in her path. She climbed over and under frantically. Thorns scraped her body. She didn’t care. She scrambled. She lost her sense of direction. Any direction she chose was just more woods. “LET ME GO! LET ME HELP HER!” She screamed harder. Her voice cracked to the horror of losing Adora again. She beat on everything around her to no avail until she just couldn’t any longer. She leaned against a tree trunk, “I love you, Adora.” Blood dripped from her arms, legs, and

her hands. Thorns stuck to her and went deeply under her skin. She didn’t care. She didn’t care about anything else.

Chapter End Notes

So I obviously decided to go with a 100% Plot A on this one. I must apologize though. I felt this chapter was a little more sloppy than my previous ones. When all is written, I do plan to go back and do some clean up work and make it better. This one, I think, is going to be a little tougher to fix.

I will need two weeks to get Chapter 09 out. I've been near some sick children and I can already feel the grossness shrouding my weak crap-body. If by some miracle, I will post an update on Twitter and only twitter. If you don't know, I'll be participating in phase three of the tumblr protest. Follow @logoffprotest for better details but the short of it is, log off tumblr for a week from 12AM Feb 1 to 12AM Feb 8. And lastly, my twitter is https://twitter.com/AmbiguousThe

Chapter 09

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

~oO B Story Oo~

"ADORA!" Swift Wind startled everyone near him. The Rebellion was preparing to defend another attack. This time, it was Plumeria. Bow was helping Swift Wind with his armor but nearly took off his own toes with the heavy plate falling in front.

Bow gasped, "Are they free!?" His starry eyes glowed big, "I can't wait to tell Glimmer!" He seemed to squeal his excitement. Horde forces were still fast approaching but hearing of Adora was uplifting.

"WAIT!" Swift Wind demanded. His eyes started to shift around searching. He took several agitated steps around then left Bow hanging. "Adora's in trouble."

Bow's face immediately dropped, "Let's go!" In a hasty effort, Bow attached Swift Wind's breast plate. He attempted to climb on Swift Wind's back but a colorful wing had pushed him to the ground. "Hey!"

"I… don't know where she is." His hooves stamped the soft ground in the stable and kicked up small, little plumes of dust. He shook and twisted his head, "I-I can't find her. I lost her."

Bow shrieked on the ground with a screech to his voice, "WHAT!?"

Swift Wind turned to Bow, bringing the tip of his horn within a hair of Bow's head. He spoke slower and enunciated, "I… lost… my *connection* … with… Ah- *dor* -ah."

Panic, worry, fear, and all such emotions that would turns one's stomach and made him lose the color in his face. "Is…," his voice trembled with a squeak, "Is she… dead?"

"I don't… think so?" He twisted his head as if to question his assessment.

"Swift Wind, you are… KILLING ME! What do you know?"

Swift Wind heaved a breath with a bit of irritation. A quick, glaring, pause, "Bow, I like you, but you have to understand, when I say I don't know, I *really* don't know. When she's in that temple, I can't read anything about her. I felt something and now it's gone like before. It's like she stepped out and went back in. That doesn't make sense, so, again, Bow, buddy, I… don't… know."

His feeling not any better, "Um, ALRIGHT!"

~oO A Story Oo~

Light crept through Adora's eyelids again. Her vision was still obscured with an unfocused speckle of colors. Her arms and legs were still paralyzed from fatigue. She could hear the sound of each breath taken so acutely in the overwhelming silence of the temple. She could even hear the soft thudding of each heart beat in her chest. She called out, "C-Catra?" The sound of her desperate voice carried through the empty hall.

A sudden realization of how empty the temple felt consumed her. A realization the temple was now her tomb. Her breathing, now more erratic than ever, had been loud enough to echo. A vicious reminder she was going to die alone. She groaned with a mournful cry only to hear it echo back at her as if to taunt her inevitable death. She fought against the weight of her own limbs with no success. Everything was against her. She whimpered.

Tears streamed down the sides of her face. Between her sobs she called Catra's name again and she knew it would go unanswered.

Internally, she screamed at herself, *STOP IT! STOP IT! YOU DID IT FOR HER! ACCEPT IT! ACCEPT IT!* She swallowed a sob only to cough it out again. *ACCEPT IT!* She forced slower and deeper breaths. *Just go to sleep. Just go to sleep and don't wake up.* Another uncontrollable cringe twisted her face. Another burst of tears escaped her eyes. Another gasp until she forced it away once more. *Sleep.*

~oO0Oo~

Catra couldn't open her eyes but she could hear muffled voices. She couldn't tell how many. The language was unknown or she was too out of it to recognize the twisted tongues. In a flash it became no concern to her as something greater took precedence. There was an alarming amount of pain. Something was being ripped out of her. It was then followed by the sound of a light "clink." She whimpered to another sharp tugging. The pain went from a five to an eleven in the next heartbeat. It became so unbearable that she tried to flail her arms at whoever or whatever the source of it was. She felt hands press and force her back down on whatever it was she was lying on. It was stiff and uncomfortable. Her resistance was subdued and rendered futile when a bitter scent was blown into her face. She tried to struggle against the intoxicating fumes. but in several short moments, she was unconscious again.

~oO0Oo~

Soft voices murmured around Catra. She couldn't pick up any of the words and yet they felt familiar. It reminded her of First One's books she attempted to read at the temple library. She tried to focus on each word but was then distracted by her acute awareness of flaring pain all over her body. Fiery patches on her arms and legs itched with an immense burn. She howled her discomfort. Luckily it had not been long before those howls were answered. Her skin was enveloped by a chilling, but far better, sensation. She felt thick brushes slapped and dragged down her arms and legs.

"It's only temporary, deary," came the voice, "We'll have to keep applying it until the thorn venom goes away." A gentle cackle was the last thing Catra heard before the voice spoke in a different language again..

Catra was still too weak to see who was in front of her or figure out where she was. The thorns she rushed through in an attempt to get back to Adora had secreted a toxic enzyme. It wouldn't be an issue had she not gone through the dangerous shrubbery more than once. Unfortunately, there was enough toxin in her to kill several vermin.

~oO0Oo~

Another cooling ointment had been applied to her skin once more. It had woken her up enough to gain some of her senses back. After a stuttered breath, and a brief shiver, she managed to mutter out a coherent question, "Wh-where am I?"

The old lady caring for her tried to tell her, "Why, you're at Ma-"

Panic thrust itself upon Catra, "ADORA! HOW LONG!? HOW LONG HAVE I BEEN OUT!?" Catra sat up with an abrupt, upward springing and knocked her head against the hanging jars above her. She flailed her hand at the obstacle but the dizzying effect

from sitting up caused her to lose her balance. She fell off the table hard. She was still very weak and her attempt to get up failed. Her arms trembled when she tried to push herself up off the ground. Her heavy breath against the dirt floor blew back at her, “There’s no time. Take me back. I have to find the temple! I have to-”

Magnified eyes stared with an awkward curiosity, “Calm down, deary, calm down. Madame Razz will take care of you. You must rest first.”

“No!” She pushed herself up harder and leaned against the closest shelf that was beside her. “I need to save her!” A moment to catch her labored breath, “Or die next to her... I-I need to be there!” The weight of her own head felt so restrictive. Each turn on her neck felt like an ocean wave in a storm crashing inside her skull. She pushed herself through it, “Take me back to Adora.”

Razz summoned her broom with an extended arm and it gravitated towards her hand. She began sweeping the mess around Catra and tsk'd several times at it. The dust from the ground kicked up enough to cause Catra to cough. Catra sneered at the broom as it brushed her. Razz patted the side of Catra's leg twice, “Could you please move out of the way deary?”

Catra glared hard, “No…, Obviously!”

Razz leaned toward her with a smug-like grin, “Then how do expect to get back if you can't even get up?” She straightened her back to the best of her ability with an emphatic “oomf.” She resumed her chore of sweeping.

“Then how did I get here? When?” Catra’s arms were limp as was most of her body. She wondered if this is what Adora felt like after She-Ra sapped the life from her. The constant brushing around her was making her uneasy. It was as if this was a task that *had* to finish first before they could go save Adora. *If* they could.

Razz chuckled, “My friend Loo-kee told me there was a dumb girl eager to scratch herself with toxic thorns. That was...," she thought a moment, "about a day and a half ago. You should be so lucky he found you.” Razz continued to chuckle. It was gentle and quiet and then muttered to herself, “Stupid girl.” Razz spoke to her again, “I carried you! Mind you, I’m just an old lady! Don’t expect me to do *that* again. OOF I can’t!”

Catra continued her attempts to pry more information out of her. To her dismay, she was met with more ambiguous answers that led nowhere. “Please!” she reluctantly begged, “Adora has no food. She is completely sapped of energy. She opened a portal for *me.* She let me escape! And now, she’s trapped behind a barrier that can only open if I forgive her.” Her eyes immediately tightened and her voice whispered her cries, “And I don’t even know if I can!” Catra didn't even know who this woman was. She couldn't think well enough to explain the situation to her. Razz stopped sweeping to the sound of Catra’s moans and whimpers. Catra continued, “And if I can’t, please let me die next to her. Just let me die there.”

Razz placed the broom back in a closet with a thrusting of her hand and she turned to Catra. She adjusted her glasses on her face and saw the wetness on Catra’s. She let out a loud cackle. How could she find this so humorous?

Catra hissed a, “Fuck you!”

She laughed into her words, “Oh, oh deary, you’ll have to forgive me. You speak of forgiveness and it sounds like you already have! What is so hard? Saying the words? Angry over the past? Let me ask you this. Did she try to get better?” She was clueless who Catra was talking about but the name "Adora" rang a bell. Every time Catra said it, she thought of Mara and wasn't sure why.

Those teary blue and yellow eyes stared back at Razz with a scornful look, “Yes.”

“And do you believe she’ll continue to be better? Hmm?” Raz moved to a table and decided to grind miscellaneous vines and leaves from her cupboard.

“Adora changed…, I guess..., I guess I did too. But, how I supposed to forget the past?" She closed her eyes with a frustrated squint, "Why are you asking me this? Are you going to help me or not!?”

“Stupid girl. You cannot ever forget the past. That’s not forgiveness. But when you see a person’s growth,” she grunted at a particular vine that wouldn’t break apart, “Ah there. Growth and change are what’s key, deary. You don’t forgive the past versions of ourselves. You forgive the people for who they become!” She sprinkled and poured various powders together. An invasive thought kept nudging her to ask, “Adora's the girl with my Mara's sword, right?”

Catra's could only move her eyes and narrowed them at her, “How should I know?" A frustrated sigh, “Does it matter?”

She poured her mixture of powders and crushed vines and leaves in a cup and stirred it in front of Catra. She didn't like Catra's rather disrespectful attitude. “These woods told me about you, you know. You are *very bad* .” Catra’s eyes shifted away and then back as if to ask, “What of it?” Madame Razz did continue, “And yet they told me to help you. Tell me, who will forgive *you* ?”

“I wasn’t looking for anyone to forgive me, old woman. All I care about is Adora.” Catra wished she didn’t feel so heavy. She was wasting time and felt she could have made more progress o her own. Every moment counted and it was being thrown away at the whim of a woman that looked to have one foot in the grave. Then again, she wasn’t completely out of the grave herself either. “What do you want?”

A soft and muted chuckle, “I want you to go away! But…,” she bobbed her head to the side once, “that’s not up to me.” She put the powdered mixture aside a moment and poured another liquid

in a different cup. She took the cup and carried it to Catra, “Drink it.” Catra’s tight lips refused and gave an untrusting gaze. Razz narrowed her eyes, “Deary, even if this were my piss, you will drink it because I am the only one who can take you back.” paused to let it sink in and then encouraged her once more, “Drink.”

Not an ounce of trust were in Catra's eyes but Razz was right, she didn't have a choice. Any motion from her head sent the room spinning. What's more, she still couldn't believe how incapacitated she was. Catra sneered at first but ended up complying. When the cup neared her lips again the scent under her nose was completely foreign. Mixed metals, honey, and bile seemed like the closest match. She hesitated to open her mouth but her lips parted. Razz had pulled back Catra's head with a bit of a forceful jostle and in went the mysterious fluid. Razz covered Catra's mouth. Her hand tightened around Catra's jaw and she watched Catra's eyes water. Despite Catra struggling against that hand, there was nothing Catra could do about it. Her stomach flexed hard as if to heave into her closed mouth. She screamed and moaned at the vile taste until Razz finally let her vomit the fluid. Razz held Catra's head forward as not to get any on herself.

“Alright deary, breathe now. Let it in, let it out.”

Catra's stomach still quivered, “What the fuck was that!?” The flavor coated her mouth with every heavy breath she took to recover.

“You have your senses about you, now, don't you?” A clear smugness was in her voice. Was the flavor a means to punish her or was it only the taste of the herbal medicine? Razz wouldn't ever tell. “Secret recipe deary,” she chuckled, and with a gentle hand, leaned Catra back to the shelf. Catra's head no longer swam but she was still very weak. She watched Razz pick up the bowl of mixed powders, “Ready for this one?” She seemed to grin at Catra with those big, enlarged eyes.

“Whatever you're gonna do to me, just fucking get it over with,” seething hatred seeped into her voice. She could tell Razz was going to enjoy every minute of what was to come. Some of Catra's wounds were still exposed and she assumed that was what Razz was going to target. She braced herself.

Another chuckle as Razz held the bowl close to her mouth. She let out a heavy breath and a thick cloud of white filled the small room. Catra tensed as the denser fog came nearer. Her head turned away and she lifted her arms slowly to her face. The cloud seemed to get thicker and thicker. She was breathing it in and feared the consequences. Her knees seemed to gravitate to her chest and she tightened her arms around them.

Razz chuckled louder, “No matter how strong we see ourselves, we are like scared children. The unknown is, indeed, very scary.” The cloud dissipated and Catra was left unharmed. “Your wounds are still open. If you leave now, you risk infection.”

Catra’s hands flexed outward and inward. A tinge of lethargy remained but she could move unassisted now. “I don’t care. If I can get in the temple, I’ll treat myself there. If I can’t, then I can die close to her.”

Razz shook her head in disappointment, “I put a lot of effort into fixing you. What good is it if you’re just going to throw it away!?” she threw her arms at Catra and huffed a sigh filled with annoyed anger. She began stuffing breads, nuts, and berries into a basket, “Come.” She walked over and handed Catra a handful of the same nuts and a roll of soft bread, “Eat and then we leave.”

Catra picked herself up off the floor while nibbling on the bread with a slow aching of her muscles. As soon as she finished the handfuls of food, she tried to wipe any of the vomit she splashed on herself away. It stung brushing her hands over her wounds. The thorns left small puffy patches of red over her arms and legs and were very sensitive to touch. She assessed how well she could move. She then considered her recovery would not be possible without Madame Razz’s help. A small, hissed grunt came

out and she said the words she hated the most to her, “Thank you.”

A hidden smirk came from Razz, “Try to keep up, we must move quickly. And, do not let your eyes wander off of me. These woods play tricks.”

~oO0Oo~

Catra was surprised at the old woman. They’ve been briskly climbing over stones, hills, branches, and winding paths for over an hour. Too many thoughts roamed in Catra’s mind. How the hell was the old woman so sprightly? Why did it seem she was going faster than her? It seemed like Razz was getting farther and farther away from her. She adhered to her suggestion to not look away. But, in the corner of her eye she could have sworn they passed the same vine at least six times. Sweat went into her eyes and she was getting tired of this, “Are you *sure* you know where you’re going!?” Razz called back but Catra had trouble hearing it. Shushes could be heard all around her. They became more distinct and Catra finally heard what legends told.

Haunting whispers got louder. Catra tried to stay focused. It was difficult. With a sudden moment, she felt the breath of an angry whisper brush against her ear, “Why did you… FAIL!?”

Catra spun and clawed at the sound but struck nothing, “FUCK YOU!” Her chest tightened in a panic. She lost Razz. Trees surrounded her. She covered her ears but she could still hear the taunting whispers in her head.

The voices hissed and spoke as if passing through her body. They began distant and quickly loudened only to dissipate again. “She’s dying…,” it echoed, “She did everything… for YOU!”

Catra shrieked, “SHUT UP! I’M TRYING! SHUT UP!” *They’re only tricks. Get a hold of yourself!*

The whispers seemed to hiss and overlap in unison, “You let her die when you could have saved her!”

Catra howled into the air, “I’M TRYING TO SAVE HER! JUST LET ME THROUGH!” She released a pained scream. Birds and squirrels scurried away. “WHAT DO YOU WA-” Catra was interrupted with a sudden pat from a broom on her back. The startling touch made her spin away from it. Even though she had her claws ready to strike, she was trembling like a leaf.

Razz rummaged through her basket and ate a few berries in front of her. “You feel guilt?” she asked with an empty stare.

Catra wanted to tear her head off at the question, “Of course I feel guilt! I *hate* myself! I hate these *fucking* woods. Adora is probably already dead! And I might have been able to save her! But-,” she moaned out. Again, memories of Adora being complacent with her abuse filled her mind. She forced it away with what Adora became. The act of Adora sapping her own life to save Catra echoed in her mind. But, she also thought it was Adora's responsibility to get her out. How could she forgive, right now? Another distressed grunt, “I don't have enough time to figure it all out!” She huffed a few times, “Yeah, I *feel* guilt.”

“Good,” Razz saw the absolute hatred in Catra's eyes. “That is good deary,” she waved a hand to have Catra follow. “I will walk slower but you must stay with me or we'll never get there.” She walked towards Catra and then past her. When Catra turned around, there was a new path she did not see before. Catra was dumbfounded but she followed none the less. Razz continued, “When my Mara left me…,” she cleared her throat and failed to finish the thought. She redirected her train of thought. A gentle voice, “What's important is that you must recognize her effort. And…,” she paused again, “You have to show her yours.”

~oO0Oo~

Another hour of winding paths but Catra didn't lose sight of Madame Razz. Slowly, the path in front of them began to widen. And Finally, she stood in front of the door that trapped her. The door that she slammed She-Ra's body against and had reminded her of the anger she had. It reminded her how badly she wanted to hurt Adora. Hurt her physically, emotionally, and everything between. And she remembered why.

Catra was taken out of her thoughts. Razz stopped and turned to her, "It is safe now. Here," she handed Catra the basket of, what was essentially, trail mix, "split it between the two of you. Now," she looked around, "go." She swept her hands forward to encourage Catra to confront her fate.

"I…," she looked in those enlarged eyes. They always seemed to stare blankly into nothingness, "I think I need to be alone now." Razz could see she couldn't utter the words, "thank you," but it was also obvious she was grateful regardless. Catra waited until she was out of sight and approached the barrier. She couldn't see it but sound seemed to deaden in front of her.

Catra raised a finger to the barrier. A tingle washed over her. It was of fear and worry. The first day flashed in front of her eyes again. She looked away from the door. That awful reminder. She took a breath and touched the barrier. It sung and fought her. She tried to push in to it harder but the pain, it was so intense. "NO!" she picked up a rock and threw it at the force field, "WHAT DO YOU KNOW!?" Her breath shook. She tightened a fist and then released. *Forgive who she's become.* "Easier said, old woman."

She closed her eyes. *She trapped herself. Fuck!* A sudden realization. Yes, Adora trapped herself. It wasn't only stupid but she did it to be *with* her. She could have been outside the barrier. She could have been her warden. Adora gave up her life in Etheria for Catra. It didn't matter how confident she was that Catra would

ever forgive her. They're was *always* that chance Adora could fail. Adora failed so Catra could succeed.

Her eyes darted around and a breath escaped her, “I forgive her.” She caught her breath again, “I actually do. I forgive her.” She placed her trembling hand up once more. But this time, when she pressed firmly against the barrier, it did not bite back. Instead, it burst into a bright mist, raining blue and white. She shudders briefly. *Was that it? Can I enter?* Catra cautiously waves a hand in front of her. Nothing. She shook her astonishment away and sprinted to the entrance. “I’m coming, Adora!” She tried to slam the entire weight of her body against the door but she only hurt herself in doing so, “COME ON!” The door didn’t budge. It was so heavy. She dug her feet into the ground and pushed hard. Her blood rushed to her head and the dirt beneath her feet was being pushed away. She grunted harder and repositioned her feet as they slipped. Finally, finally it began to move. There was now enough of an opening to get an arm through for better leverage. It opened more, little by little. And then Catra saw her when she tried to wedge her head through the opening, “ADORA!” She still couldn’t get through. She jabbed her body against the opening again to try to reach her, “ADORA! I’M HERE!” Adora was unresponsive and it threw Catra into a greater panic. She wedged her shoulder threw and placed her feet on the door and pushed hard. A guttural scream as her muscles burned to the extra stress. When it finally opened wider, she quickly fell to the floor. She didn’t care, “Adora!” She quickly picked herself off and knelt beside her, “Adora?”

Chapter End Notes

> I really wanted to add more B Story in here but I kept it to a minimum since CatrAdora is the main thing that people want. It's sort of ruining the flow for Part B and I'm having a harder time trying to finding a good place to fill in the widening gap of what's happened. Sigh, oh well.
>
> Before I get chapter 10 out the door, I'm gonna do some minor chapter edit/clean up to fix up all the adverb abuse

AND THEN, well, Chapter 10 might be the last chapter - When chapter 10 is released (2-3 weeks) I'll need you to tell me if I ended it well or if I need to answer some lingering questions and possibly post an epilogue chapter. Feel absolutely free to tell me what you want to see. Even if you think you know it'll be covered in the next chapter, I'm still curious. :)

What I WANTED to do but couldn't was reunite Rogelio and Kyle, I wanted to expand on the princess alliance. I wanted to tell you where Entrapta is. I wanted to give you a reaction-story that revolved around Entrapta. Maybe I can do a separate story entirely for this but i don't know. Not sure how many would actually be interested and I'd have to start with some redundant story points that I put in here. I WANT TO SHARE! oh well.

I know I've been failing to give replies to comments. It's been incredibly busy on my side. Every time I want to thank someone on feedback, I get sidetracked with work.

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora's lips were cracked and shriveled into her mouth. Her entire body lost all color. Her eyes seemed to have sunk a little more into her face. But, with Catra placing a close ear to Adora's mouth, Catra heard soft breaths. Dry shushes that whispered a desperate call to life. And a life that was ready to leave.

Catra was already exhausted from her trek through the woods, the exertion from opening the door, and while Madame Razz did well to remove the toxins from her body and gave her food, it wasn't enough to completely recover. But if Catra didn't try to move Adora to the medical station, they were both dead anyway. Catra forced an arm behind Adora's back and another under her thighs. Catra took several not-so-confident breaths and lifted to the best of her abilities. Her thighs trembled and couldn't hold Adora up higher than a squat. She paused to groan, but again, she struggled harder to lift. Just so long as she could get to a standing position, she knew she could move her. Her muscles were so sore, so tired, so unbelievably weak. Even her arms gave her such an uncertain rumble that she considered simply dropping then dragging Adora. The consideration was quickly dismissed, she was already halfway there. One more grunt got her up and she carried Adora.

~oO0Oo~

There, Adora rested in the med station's bed. An I.V. attached to her hand and her color was returning, albeit too slow for Catra. A few false wakings alarmed Catra. Adora would mutter Catra's name but she did not respond to anything Catra questioned. She

would not eat the berries that was pressed to her lips and it was dangerous to force it.

Catra spent time treating herself as well. And despite her gained knowledge of First One's writing, some of the vocabulary was still out of scope. She understood "inflamed" but the topical ointments didn't look like it specified if it remedied or warned of it. With a couple unfortunate tests that caused an unbearable itching on the wounds she applied it to, she did find the one that cooled and reduced swelling. She drank her fluids and she went through her portion of food Razz had given her little by little. She changed her clothing from the cabinets on the far wall of the room. She shook her head at herself for eating. She wanted all for Adora but she knew it would have been stupid if she didn't try to take care of herself as well.

She sat in a chair and leaned over to kiss Adora's fingers. She ran a thumb over them. They were warm and soft to hold. Catra whispered to herself, "Wake up you asshole…, wake up."

~oO0Oo~

Bow was having trouble aiming his arrows while riding Swift Wind. He kept turning unexpectedly and had almost thrown Bow right off his back. Bow's thighs were definitely going to hurt later.

And over the roars from the Horde below, Bow could barely hear the agitated and whining whimpers that escaped Swift Wind's throat. Trees split and crunched against the forces that broke them as if to scream in their own agony. Each bellowing groan of a falling tree seemed to invigorate the army with bloodlust.

A particularly more stressful moan from Swift Wind finally raised Bow's concern to ask, "You know where Adora is, don't you?" While the Horde sent grinding tanks through the woods that was clearing paths, Bow watched Perfuma try to entangle them.

Unfortunately, even she was not strong enough to overturn them. Her thorny vines, no matter how thick and armored she made them with bark, they only managed to slow the machines a little. She received support from the rest of the Rebellion, and together, was able to push them back. Bow was the only one that could take an aerial approach and did his best to immobilize the onslaught.

Scorpia tried her best to pretend she was still with the Horde and ordered troops down a different path. Many did, in fact, follow her orders. It seemed it was too much of an embarrassment to let anyone know someone could potentially defect from such a high ranking position. She, for a short time, was successful in confusing them.

Glimmer noticed the flailing actions from Swift Wind and teleported on his back, “What's wrong? Are you guys okay?”

Swift Wind dipped a few leg lengths in the air at the unexpected weight. He whined further but finally came out with it, “Adora's free! I know where she is! But we're needed here! Mmmmmnnnngg!”

Glimmer tried to reason, “That's great news! She should be fine! If the barrier is down, it's because Catra forgave her right? She's not in any danger so just focus on the battle!” Glimmer threw a giant ball of light that brightened on contact to angry squads below.

Swift Wind whimpered further, “NNngggggg kind of! She needs help!”

Bow and Glimmer simultaneously, “WHAT!?”

Swift Wind paused a moment before answering. He questioned if he had an accent or if he was talking too fast. He thought he got to the point very clearly and was unsure how to expand. He questioned if he always needed to talk slower at all times. He

questioned if he needed to repeat himself. Did Bow and Glimmer just need more time?

Bow saw how pensive and distracted Swift Wind was, he understood, “I… I get it Swifty. You don’t need to explain,” he turned to Glimmer, “What should we do, commander? We know that temple has everything they need, do you think they can wait?”

Glimmer pondered. She still wanted a more detailed answer. To what degree is Adora in trouble? Did Catra do something to her? Did she break everything? She had to stop herself, “I hate to say this guys, but the battle is here, now. Keep fighting. When Kyle’s spiders show up, we can go, but not until then!”

Both Bow and Swift Wind shared an unpleasant moan but agreed nonetheless. At least now, Swift Wind more focused and Bow was able to hit his targets. Glimmer disappeared and let loose a ferocious barrage of light against the oncoming forces. She had become strong enough that whatever she threw now had quite an impact.

~oO0Oo~

A saddened moan was uttered and the soft rustle of a turned head on a pillow woke Catra. Adora came to the realization she was still alive and moaned once more. She just didn’t want to *feel* any longer. She dared not open her eyes and she believed she was still lying beside the temple entrance. She heard Catra’s voice call to her and could only assume she was delirious. Tears began to pool in her eyes but she was still not hydrated enough to let them fall. A dry sob escaped her. She shared an angered hiss as she spoke to herself, “Why can’t I just,” a shuddered gasp, “die.”

Catra rubbed a gentle hand across her face. She didn’t want to startle her, “Hey, Adora,” she offered with a whispered voice, “I’m

here. You're not gonna die."

Adora opened her eyes, just a crack, and could only see a blurred image of the woman hovering over her. To Catra's surprise she groaned harder, "I wish you were real. I wish I could tell you how s-sorry I am. I wish," she gasped as her throat tightened, "I wish I had more time." Her voice cracked, "I'm so glad you're free."

"No, Adora," she tried to convince her, "it's okay, I'm here. Do you feel my hand?" She rubbed her palm against Adora's cheek again. "I'm here, Adora. It's okay."

In moments, Adora slowly began to believe. She really did feel a hand upon her face. She felt the bed in which she lain and a horrifying shock came over her. Her mouth became drier and a tingle crawled over her skin, "I swear I thought…," her heart ached so much more now, "I thought I got you out!" She was confused and distraught. She sobbed harder, "I'm sorry. I'm so sorry Catra!" She almost couldn't breathe. With shallow breath, "I thought I got you out! But it was just a *fucking* dream!" The groan that came out of her was haunting. The thought of such a failure was absolutely crushing.

Catra responded quickly to her anguish, "NO! Adora! You did! I was out there!" she cupped Adora's face with both her hands and stared into her eyes, "You got me out, I've got food, I-I got back in."

Adora's eyes wandered and it was so hard for her to process. She began to look around the room blankly. Her eyes then shifted back to Catra, "I-I don't understand."

"Adora, you will. You need to eat. I tried to feed you earlier but you were so out of it that-," Catra began to beg her, "Just eat this, *please* , and I'll explain."

Adora tried to sit up but was so powerless to move. Almost a reflex, Catra adjusted the bed itself, allowing it to incline until it was comfortable enough for Adora to eat. Catra reached into the

basket that Razz had given her and took out a few berries. With care, she slid a berry into Adora's mouth. The tart flavor rolled over Adora's tongue and she was left further perplexed. Adora kept asking where it came from only to be answered, "from outside." Catra observed Adora with each bite and thought it safe to leave to get water for her. When she came back, she asked Adora to take small sips. It was reminiscent of their first day there when she received the same care. It was a memory she'd rather not relive. At least, Adora seemed to adhere to Catra's instruction better than Catra had at the time.

After an hour, Catra explained what had happened and how she met Razz. She explained, "She led me back here and I didn't want to lose you. *Who you are* is so important to me. And I needed to tell you, Adora…," she wanted to lead to those words that would explain everything, "Because you didn't hear me say it when that portal closed, I love you..."

Adora looked at Catra, almost convinced what was happening wasn't real again, that her mind was playing tricks. "Catra?" came her uncertain voice.

Catra leaned in to kiss her cheek and gave her what she wanted most, "I'm here because I forgive you." Catra swallowed hard. It wasn't just forgiveness, though. "And um," her voice seemed to drop unexpectedly. She cleared it with a small gasp, "I'm sorry it came to this. I can't apologize for everything but I'm sorry it had to be like this." She wrapped her arms around Adora's shoulders, "I need you."

Adora struggled to return the hug but could only manage to grip Catra's loose clothing that rested on her hand. She shook her head against Catra's shoulder. Her struggle with reality continued. "C-Catra-"

"Just eat some more," she released Adora and continued to feed her in small amounts. "It'll probably be a day or so before I can get you outside. I'll try to get some more food while you rest." That was going to be a problem. She didn't tell her, but she would

need to enter the woods, potentially losing Adora all over again. Other issues rolled around in Catra's mind. They were both incredibly weak. They were in no condition to fight an army any time soon and would require much time to recover. She didn't know how but she needed to get Adora back to Bright Moon. But then, what would happen to her. She doubted any of the Rebellion would support her after the atrocities she committed. She forced her thoughts away and for now, she tried to focus on the woman in front of her.

~oO0Oo~

Several hours came and went. It was time to figure out how to get food without getting lost. Catra told Adora she'd be gone for only a little bit, but not to worry if it felt long. There was significant progress in those hours. Adora felt strong enough to move her arms and turn a little in place but it was still too soon to try to stand up.

Adora was still in a bit of a daze. She worked so hard to free Catra and only within a couple of days did she have the ability to forgive her. She battled her rushing thoughts. It was daunting that Catra could bring herself to forgive her. And now that she had, why couldn't she have done it sooner? What Catra did was liberating but also discomforting. She was free now and she knew all she needed to do was wait.

And then it occurred to Adora. Her friends were still not there. It's been almost an entire day since Catra broke the barrier. Maybe it was longer, she wasn't sure. Why weren't they there? She knew Swift Wind could sense her if the barrier broke. They should have been there within an hour. Panic was quickly settling in. Scenario after scenario kept cropping up. *I'm still trapped. My friends are dead. This isn't real.* Tears began to pool and fall. It had only been a few minutes since Catra left. If she was real, it had only been

several minutes. With great strain to her voice, she called, “Catra?” She sniffed hard when she heard nothing, “Catra!”

~oO0Oo~

Catra walked down the halls of the temple and began to approach the entrance. The door was cracked open and it gave her a sense of assurance she was still free. She didn’t want to leave the temple too far regardless. Equipped with the basket, she thought to step out and call out to Loo-Kee or Madame Razz for help. She was desperate and she didn’t want to chance getting lost again. As soon as she squeezed herself through the doorway she was about to shout out until she tripped over two baskets in front of her, “Gah! What the f-”

It seemed Raz or Loo-Kee thought ahead. Catra looked around but saw no one. She picked herself up with a bit of a sigh knowing that she needed to thank them. It seemed she now had a threshold she couldn't cross. Not thanking them *would* be too low for her. *Damn it,* “HEY!” her eyes darted left, right, up, and down and searched the thick woods in front of her, “... THANKS!” For all she knew, she spoke only to the wind.

Her ears perked up and heard the faint call from Adora. Catra grabbed the two baskets, not expecting its heavy weight, and strained a muscle. “Ow, shit.” A quick growl and she tried again and hustled to get back to Adora.

~oO0Oo~

“I'm here! What's wrong?” Catra looked at the indicators from the machines that were hooked up to Adora. With the exception of a

raised heart beat, she seemed physically stable.

Adora brought her hands to her face and tried to breathe, “Why aren't they coming? They said- they should be here by now. You- you broke the barrier,” she moaned a cry and gasped for air, “they should be here to get us.”

Catra provided as many excuses as she could to try to calm Adora. It was clear to her that she expected her friends to get her. “Look, Adora, priority one is you. Okay? We'll figure it out when we can walk out of here. They're probably just held up. And we'll be fine too. Nothing bad can happen to us if we stick together.”

Those words sent a chill down Adora's back. “I'm sorry, Catra, I swear I'll-”

“I know. Just..., know that I mean it.” Catra wiped away Adora’s tears with her palm, “Try to keep the liquid in you, alright?” Catra watched Adora huff a tiny laugh. She tried to distract her with more food and let her know she suspected Raz was keeping an eye on them. The baskets were full of bread, cheese, vegetables, and what appeared to be medicinal herbs. Catra immediately went for the cheese and it was glorious. A flavor that was even a delicacy is the Fright Zone There was a note stuffed between the vegetables, “Cook it,” and a recipe on the back. Catra quickly skimmed and concluded it was just throw it all in a pot with water and put heat on it for a while. “Hey, you trust me enough to cook this?”

Pleading eyes looked at Catra. After her panic just moments ago, Adora was afraid to be alone again. She attempted a calm and steady voice, “You don't need to go now,” but the fear still lingered. Hunger had dissipated for the time being. For the first time in months, their stomachs hadn't complained to them. Adora scooched to the side of the bed a little and patted the vacant spot.

Catra smiled, “Sure, just don't breathe on me.” She saw the offended look on Adora's face as she climbed in. A smidge of a

chuckle, “Your breath is so rancid, Adora.” She kissed Adora's forehead.

Adora buried her head into Catra's chest, “You are such a shit.”

A squeaked laughter, “I know.”

~oO0Oo~

Bow’s shoulders and arms writhed in pain. The cache of arrows on his back were all depleted but the one that could return to him. His fingers had blistered where it was not guarded and his aim was getting weaker. Each pull on his weapon sent shooting pains into his tendons. Swift Wind could no longer fly as his wings weakened with each strenuous flap. However, Glimmer kept ordering to press on. She knew those spiders were coming and she’ll be damned if she was going to retreat. She just needed to buy more time. But those mechanical creatures better come soon because she was unsure how much she, herself, could last.

The Heart-Blossom had taken a few hits that greatly affected Perfuma’s magic. She was a person of interest to the Horde since she was responsible for the Whispering Woods’ rapid healing.

Destroy the Heart-Blossom and the Horde would have a better chance to maneuver over the lands.

Glimmer and Bow had been quite thankful that the Horde had not rebuilt the rail gun they saw at the Kingdom of Snows. If they had, they were sure they would be done for.

Black billowing smoke poured from the downed tanks and armored vehicles. It seemed they were designed to pollute the area as much as possible. Spinnerella did much of the work to push it back but she, too, was weakening against the repetitive use of her powers. Netossa supported as much as she could. Her

method to contain the poisoned area and release it farther away. But, they were downwind and it would only seep back to them.

Royal Magi and Sorcerers lit the skies and rained fire and lightning when they neared the open battlegrounds. Every one of them slowing to the wave after wave of Horde soldiers and their tech to defend against almost everything the Rebellion threw at them. Those who looked far beyond saw no certain end of the Horde's forces. They simply stopped and shook their head in disbelief. No longer could they continue. They no longer had the energy to retreat. The simply fell to their knees and waited for death.

Glimmer looked around at her armies. She shouted at them, "PRESS ON! THEY WILL COME! KEEP FIGHTING!" Even Glimmer didn't believe her own words. She continue to scream her commands only to be looked at with apologetic faces ready to crumble beneath a losing battle. Tears built in Glimmers eyes as she felt the ground shake beneath her. Fear was overwhelming. Louder and closer the rumbling came. From where, she couldn't pinpoint. But it was nearing her. A lengthy scream at all around, " *FIIIGHT!"* Her vision was no longer focused and she began to hyperventilate. She could only think this was her end as the rumbling was suddenly beneath her. With no energy to teleport she only held her convulsing breath, closed her eyes, and braced for the pain.

But, no pain came. No more fear. No death. The rumbling had continued on. Violent screams were all that she heard. Not from her the forces she lead but the Evil Horde. Soldiers seemed to be almost sucked into the ground in droves. Tanks were shredded and its debris forced out from the holes. Glimmer began to breathe again. She slowly opened her eyes. She was in complete awe. She watched metal fly into the air in a daze. Almost hypnotised by the power of the mechanical spiders Kyle had tweaked. She watched the barrel of a tank fling high into the air and had quickly gone in her direction. She couldn't move. The last thing she felt was the impact of a heavy clawed woman push and roll her away from the wreckage, "I GOTCHA! I GOTCHA!" The clash that saved Glimmer had rendered her unconscious.

Scorpia picked her up and headed straight for Bow. They needed to get away from the danger zone as quickly as possible. Swift Wind, the other princesses, and the surviving royal armies were already out of harm's way. They watched anxiously as they saw Scorpia charge back to safety. She hurdled over fallen trees and the bodies that littered the ground. She dodged weapon fire and explosions. Her back was cut by the splash damage but she continued. The explosions kept getting closer even as she neared the allied forces. She carried Bow and Glimmer like grocery bags and shouted to the best of her ability, "MOVE! MOVE! MOVE!" She knew they needed to get everyone back. Those spiders were devastating and effective but messy. The crowd felt a chill down their spines. Scorpia was right, it was getting closer.

Anyone who could walk helped the injured and began to move back. Some of them claimed they could still fight and resisted the effort to be dragged away. Another rumbling wave shook the ground once more. It wouldn't be long before the ground caved beneath their feet and all decided spread out and attempt to retreat.

Glimmer began to wake again to the rapid jostling of Scorpia's sprint. Glimmer stared at the sky and watched pieces of the ground and rock fly up and head in their direction. She gasped and pointed to it, "Sc-Scor-SCORPIRA! ROCK! ROCK! ROCK!"

Scorpia took a glance and stopped herself hard and stared at it for a moment trying to find exactly where it was going to land, assessed, and sprinted again in another direction. Glimmer and Bow screamed to the quick jerking of their bodies. The rock shattered and exploded. Scorpia pulled Glimmer and Bow into a hug to shield them from the fragments and jerked to one landing in her back.

"SCORPIA!" Glimmer called out as she saw the pain in Scorpia's cringing face.

Scorpia took a struggled breath, "I'm fine," and began to move again. She was almost there but the shifting ground from the

second wave of spiders wasn't helping. With one last push she managed to reach the other squads. She dropped Bow and Glimmer on the ground and collapsed face-forward.

Bow finally saw the damage done and screamed for a medic. When one came they began to check him out but he quickly ordered them to take care of Scorpia first. The wound was deep. Alarmingly deep. They were informed Scorpia needed move her back to Bright Moon but doing so could possibly kill her in the process. Scorpia overheard and attempted a few last words, "Hey," she whispered out, "hey, guys…," shallow and quickened breath was making her speech difficult, "I just want to say…, sorry for all the shit," she wheezed a few times. "Tell Catra we're gonna win in the end." Her labored breath began to gurgle.

"Scorpia," Glimmer began to tear up, "you're gonna do it!" She looked at the medics, "She is priority *one* , get her help, NOW!"

~oO0Oo~

Rebellion forces continued their march back to Bright Moon. Glimmer was overcome with anxiety watching Scorpia lose more and more blood. She couldn't take it any longer. She looked towards an exhausted Spinnerella, "SPINNERELLA!" she had to shout as she was much farther ahead. Spinnerella quickly backpedaled to hear Glimmer's commands. When she arrived, Glimmer gave her an important order, "Get to Bright Moon, inform my mother to wait for me in the med station. Tell her to take me to recharge when I arrive."

"Glimmer, you don't mean-" Spinnerella was shocked Glimmer would consider teleporting someone of Scorpia's size, let alone herself, such a distance in her current state. Bow could only give a worried glare. He wanted Scorpia safe too but he didn't want to risk losing Glimmer either.

A very dark and angered expression appeared on Glimmers face. She was not going to let Scorpia die. She grit her teeth after being questioned, "Whether you get that message to her or not, I'm getting Scorpia there. Now go!"

Spinnerella pursed her lips with a disappointed shake of her head and conjured up as much of her remaining energy and magic to fly off. Glimmer gave her time to reach her mother. The castle was within sight but on foot. Glimmer looked to Swift Wind who was limping along the way. His wings were bound in place to reduce further damage to his muscles. Like Bow, he pushed himself beyond his limits and had torn several muscles. He looked absolutely miserable.

Glimmer took a moment to check on him. "We'll rest when we get back. We'll get you the best care, I promise. Hang in there."

He gave a sad kind of look, "Glimmer, I know what you're doing. You think I couldn't hear?"

"I'll be fine. I've done worse." She gave a forced smile, "Adora still okay?"

A very subtle nod as any more than that would send shooting pains up his back, "I don't know how but she's doing better. I think they're waiting for us."

"After we check you out, we'll go." She turned to Bow, "Hey, Spinnerella should be at the castle soon. After I recharge, I'll start getting others back, okay?" Bow shook his worried head at her. "Don't have much of a choice, here, Bow."

"Please be careful." His eyes begged. He wanted to hug her but his arms were too weak to lift. He offered a smile which earned him a kiss to his forehead. "Don't be too long," he reminded.

"I won't," Glimmer ordered the medics to place Scorpia down carefully. She told the medics that the rock shard couldn't be teleported with her, and asked what she should tell the medics at Bright Moon what to do. With a quick back and forth discussion

she was confident she was able to get out a few words. She placed her hands on Scorpia's waist. "Here we go," just the thought of what she had to do made her feel more exhausted but there wasn't much time. Glimmer began to groan and tense. Her breath quickened and she groaned out harder and louder. One more gasp and she gave it her all. She was gone.

~oO0Oo~

Scorpia landed on a gurney while Glimmer stumbled backwards bumping into wheeled carts and doctors until she collapsed to the ground. Her head was light and the world felt like it was swept from underneath her. She held her head and screamed out, "PUNCTURE WOUND TO THE LEFT LUNG! BLOOD LOSS!" And the last thing she heard was her mouth shouting her name before the everything turned black.

~oO0Oo~

That night Adora couldn't sleep. Her friends weighed heavily on her mind again as did the numerous scenarios she'd play out. She blamed herself for not being there for them.

Catra kept herself snuggled close and an arm wrapped tightly around Adora's waist. She wasn't quite asleep but wasn't quite awake either. She kept herself alert for Adora. That, and the front door was now unlocked.

"Catra?" Adora received a rising, albeit gentle, grunt. "I-I want to see."

With eyes still closed she sighed into Adora's neck. She knew she was going to have to get up anyway and decided not to delay. She began to push herself up, “Fine. But we sleep after, okay?”

Adora gave her nod.

Catra watched Adora’s feet touch the floor and was ready to catch her should her knees buckle. She was surprised how well Adora was doing. She went from near dead to being able to walk a few steps without support in less than two days. Catra held onto her waist and had Adora throw an arm over her shoulder. They took their time towards the entrance door. Step by step they got there. Adora tensed as she outstretched a hand. The door was open and sounds of crickets chirping and wind shushing through trees hushed through. All the evidence that the force field was broken and yet she still tried to feel for it. She had to confirm, “It was right here, right?”

Catra lightly huffed, “Yeah.” She turned her eyes to the door and the suggestion was noticed. Catra wanted Adora’s feet to touch the grass. It would be the one thing that would make Adora really believe. When they approached the opening, Adora stopped. Catra shared a concerned stare.

“What if…,” she gripped Catra's hand a little tighter, “what if this is a dream? What if this is just a hallucination? I can't do that to myself. I can't lose you. If this is my final moment, I'd rather spend it like this than find out it’s all a lie.”

Catra carefully stepped in front of her. A hand swapped to support Adora's shifted weight, “Adora?” she looked into Adora’s eyes. She brought her arm behind Adora's back and cupped her face with her other hand. A slight tilting of her head and a gentle softness to her voice, “If you don't step outside, I will toss you out there myself.” She pecked Adora's lips with hers, “‘kay?”

Adora hesitated. Catra gave her a moment to calculate as she watched Adora’s eyes shift a little. And then the moment passed. Adora felt Catra’s arm placed behind Adora’s thighs and she fell

backward into Catra's other arm. It happened so fast to her. Cradled in such a way and then taken outside. She quickly spoke, "D-don't actually drop me!"

Catra smirked as she carried her to a small patch of grass just outside the door. She let Adora's legs drop slow. She let her feet touch the blades and rustle between her toes. "Can you stand?"

Adora only let go of Catra and walked a step. She brushed her feet through the dirt. The eclipsed, moonlit night cast shadows of the trees ahead. A cool breeze suddenly wriggled through her fingers. Adora could smell the soil. The scent was so different she could even taste it in the back of her throat. She crouched down and felt the ground with her hands and shuddered. It was real. When she finished coming to terms with this truth she tried to stand up again. Her muscles were still weak and her knees looked as if to be rattled like a toy. Catra helped her up until Adora grabbed her arms, "I know I said it already, but I need to tell you. I need to tell you that it wasn't just the fact I thought I was never going to see you again. It wasn't just my final words... Catra, I love you."

"Adora…," while glad Adora was no longer questioning the reality of her freedom, Catra twitched her nose to Adora's exhaled breath, "I'm begging, brush your teeth so I can kiss you." Adora huffed an incredulous laugh in Catra's face to which Catra covered hers with both hands, "Ugh!"

After a brief argument on who was a bigger asshole, Catra helped Adora back inside. And more specifically, to the bathroom where Adora had done as requested.

~oO0Oo~

Glimmer sprang up as if awakening from a frightening night terror, "SHE'S PRIORITY ONE! I didn't say it!" she heaved a breath, "I

HAVE TO TELL THEM!”

Queen Angella had grasped Glimmers arms and tried to look her in the eyes. She was so furious. Her blood boiled at the fact Glimmer had nearly died. After hearing from her royal guards that Glimmer had been rescued from Scorpia because she stood there frozen on the battlefield. Furious she did not order a retreat. Furious that she nearly killed all the forces she lead. But she had to calm Glimmer down first, *then* scold her. “Glimma, they know.”

Panic remained, “H-how, how is-”

Angella did not look away, “They are still operating. And all squads made it back. The injured are still being triaged.” Glimmer was going to ask the obvious but Angella had cut her off before she could speak, “It's been eleven hours, Glimma. I didn't think you were ever going to wake up.” She stood up and turned away, “Are you eager to die?” Glimmer knew to remain silent having had danced to this song before, “I'm demoting you.”

She gave a very emphatic, “ *What* !?” and threw her hands to the direction of the battlefield, “I just saved Plumeria from losing a rune stone! Because of me I-”

“WEAKENED OUR ENTIRE ARMY! The Horde will strike again and again and now we are remarkably under prepared! The amount of time our forces need to recover will far exceed when they plan their next attack!”

Glimmer argued that they significantly reduced the Horde’s numbers and permanently. She argued that if she had not defended the rune stone, everyone would be out of harmony and the Horde would have a much greater advantage. She argued with great emphasis that Kyle's modified spiders was a huge success. But there was something else she needed to tell her mother. That Adora was free and now they would have She-Ra soon.

But before Glimmer could get the news out, Angella snapped. With tears that already streamed down her face when she turned to face Glimmer again, “THEN WHY DID YOU JUST STAND THERE WAITING FOR DEATH!? They told me you did nothing while Scorpia just tackled you! WHAT WERE YOU THINKING!?”

Glimmer wasn’t sure how to respond but it needed to be quick. She didn't want to see her mother cry. It hurt. “I didn't see it. I was distracted. We all were.” She sighed, “Mom, there's something important I need to tell you. Ad-”

A tearful scoff, “Important? Glimma, nothing you say right now could-”

Glimmer's brows furrowed, “Adora is free. When Swift Wind is ready, we're going out to find her. Demote me all you want.” She got up and began to turn her back to teleport away until she felt her mother's embrace.

“I will go with you. I can't lose you. I can't stand it. I need time with you.” Angella pleaded with her tightening grasp. “Oh Glimma, I can either protect my kingdom or protect you, it's not within my power to do both! This war is going to kill one of us and I'll be damned if I let it be you! Do you understand?”

A mother's guilt had wrung Glimmer's heart. She placed a hand over her mother's, “I'm sorry.” She couldn't follow up with a more cheerful suggestion. Not this time. There was no room for bright-side antics. “I froze because this war still has things that scare me. That surprise me. And this time it came from *us.* For a moment I didn't know what I was looking at. That *destruction,* I’ve only seen from the Horde. The *evil* Horde. But it was us. I froze.” She paused to stop herself from getting too emotional. “Then we see people like Adora, Kyle, Rogellio, and Scorpia, all from the Horde and it's just- we shouldn't be *fighting* them, we should be *rescuing* them!” She wiped a tear that had escaped while her mother listened, “I didn't know what to do. I froze.”

Angella hugged her daughter once more and nodded into her shoulder. “I understand. I'm sorry I questioned your judgement. I don't know if I would, if I *could,* do anything differently. But Glimma, it scares me. I can't have situations like these. You can’t be out there and-” she stopped herself. It was silly to finish the sentence as she knew every battle would have situations like this. It was war. Beyond her control.

Glimmer understood but she admitted to herself that she’d never stop fighting so long as the Horde was a threat. And now, more than anything, she wanted Adora home. After a brief and pensive moment, she suggested to her mother to go with her to the infirmary. A quick agreement had them on their way to check on their statuses.

~oO0Oo~

Swift Wind had immediately noticed Glimmer’s entrance with her mother. He walked toward her with an awkward yet strut-like bounce to his step. His eyes seemed manic and dilated with his mouth grinning wide, “GlimmmeeeeerrRRrr,” he seemed to sing her name, “I’m FLYING!” He had a bit of a ‘hyuk’ in his laughter as he stretched out his neck and held very still, “OHhhh, I’m FLYING! Glimmer, I can FLY!” He displayed euphoric bliss as he stared at the ceiling lights.

It wasn’t until a doctor had come by to inform them that he was heavily medicated did either Glimmer or her mother lower their concern. The added weight of his wings and horn were the culprits to miscalculating his dosage. The loopy-high, the doctor referred to, would dissipate within a few hours. Due to his size, it was difficult to restrain him. Instead, the staff allowed him to roam the ward so long as he wasn’t blocking anyone from getting care. At the very least, he was polite. He would occasionally bump into a wall and apologize profusely to it.

Both Glimmer and the queen slowly walked away and tried to find the whereabouts and status of the rest of the team. Glimmer asked for Scorpia first. It seemed Scorpia was out of surgery and was left to heal. Asking around it seemed Scorpia had been stable for several hours. The surgeons responsible for putting her back together again mentioned that they never dealt with healing abilities like Scorpia's before. Apparently the wound would rapidly encase itself in a fluid and harden. While it sounded beneficial, the downside was that it was filling up her left lung and preventing it from opening. They had to cut and drill to remove the secretion so it wouldn't clog what was meant to be filled with air. The surgeon in charge ensured she'd be fine.

Glimmer celebrated with her heart racing. Unfortunately, she was denied seeing Scorpia and was advised to let her rest until she awakens. She agreed to let her rest and thought to visit Bow. A pit in her stomach made her realize that, until Swift Wind was less inebriated, she wouldn't be able to reunite with Adora. But soon, she told herself, soon she would.

~oO0Oo~

Catra snuggled close. Her head buried into Adora's neck as they hugged each other. The morning came and it was time to decide if they were both well enough to leave. Or, worst case scenario, well enough to fight if they needed to. Facing reality taunted the both of them. Between Catra's decision to truly stay with Adora or continue her mission with the Horde. And if the Horde wasn't an option, then how accepting were Adora's friends? They'd likely want some form of an apology. Some form of retribution. *Something* Catra was not willing to give. Adora was troubled with similar thoughts. Too much time had passed. Something went wrong and Adora wasn't sure how she was going to handle any of the news, whatever it may be.

Adora took a deep breath as soon a she felt ready to move, “We should leave now.” Adora was met with a light grumble in her shoulder. “I'm rested. Come on. I can navigate us back as She-Ra.”

While still groggy, Catra pushed herself up and opened her eyes. Just a narrow opening revealed their color. She saw Adora's inflexible decision translated into subtle but nervous teeth gnashing and unblinking eyes. A small smirk that carried the same level of anxiousness crossed her face, “Good. I'll bring the food.” She gave Adora a quick peck on the cheek and got up quickly.

~oO0Oo~

“Bow! Glimmer! Time to go!” a shifty-eyed, winged horse shouted down the ward. He was addressed as “sir” for the first time and was asked to calm down. He tried to shout again but luckily Glimmer had suddenly appeared in front of him. People around the hospital shared their glares but quickly moved on. While they all agreed Swift Wind could use some rest, they would not be disappointed if he left.

She placed her hands on his face to calm him, “Hey, hey, I’m right here. How are you feeling? Do you sense Adora again? Are you sure you can leave?” He seemed far more sober than before. His eyes were no longer so cavernous and dark. But he was anxious, more so than his usual prancing when he sensed Adora. She suspected it was because of his medication wearing off.

“Glimmer,” he stated sternly, “She’s moving. I’m as fine as I can be. I can’t fly but I can walk. Get Bow and let’s get going.” He huffed a breath through his nose.

Glimmer gave her affirmed nod, “Alright. My mom’s coming too. I’ll get Bow, wait here.” Soon Glimmer and Swift Wind turn their heads to orderlies trying to restrain Scorpia.

“Guys,” she lifted a doctor that tried to push her back in her room and placed him to the side. “I’m good! Thank you but I’ve spent enough time here.” She caught eye of Glimmer, “Don’t you leave without me! I’ve been moping over Catra for months!” She watched Glimmer suddenly blink out of existence only to feel her grasping hug. “WHOA!”

“You’re OKAY!” Glimmer shouted as Scorpia chuckled.

“HA! Look at that! You really are a hugger!” She returned the hug in kind. “What are you waitin’ for, get Bow!” Glimmer gave a joyful smile and disappeared. A moment later she heard a sharp and startled yelp from Bow in another room. But she stiffened at the sight of Queen Angella approaching her. Her last encounter was not of the friendliest. After escaping the sky prison, having used Glimmer as a means to get to the ground safer, had infuriated Angella. When Scorpia returned to Bright Moon to swear her allegiance to the Rebellion, Angella had thanked her for her alliance, the trustworthy information she shared, but not for the stunt she pulled. Scorpia was approached and then, in a flash, had found herself on the ground with an intense headache. The next thing she knew, Angella whispered threats of being force fed her own claws should she ever look at Glimmer, let alone touch her again. A mother’s rage was a force not to be reckoned with.

Angella had kept her distance to arm’s length, “You are looking much betta.”

With a slight nervous stutter, “Y-yes, heh well, I heal fast.”

Angella took a step closer, “And you wish to join us and reunite with Adora.”

“And Catra,” she cleared her throat, “Mostly Catra. B-but, hey, you know, Adora’s good too!”

“I see,” another step, “Very well then if you feel up for it.” Scorpia only gulped at how close she was. She was not ready to take another hit. “And Scorpia?” Angella received a near squeaked

“mm hmm?” and continued, “Thank you for saving my daughter’s life. For saving the lives of our army.” She grasped for Scorpia’s claw with gentle touch. “I owe you dearly. Please let me know if I can do anything for you. And I mean it, anything.” Angella stared into Scorpia’s eyes to show her sincerity and let go.

“Thanks. I uh, I mean, you’re welcome, err it’s a pleasure.” She gave a nervous nod and could only relax when Glimmer arrived beside her with Bow.

“Let’s go!” Swift Wind shouted with a smile.

~oO0Oo~

She-Ra had been walking for almost two hours with Catra on her shoulders. Catra carried a basket of food with her and would occasionally rest it on top of Adora’s head. Adora felt good as She-Ra and hadn’t mind. She wasn’t at her best but, as She-Ra, she was stronger. Catra didn’t know how to feel while on her shoulders. It was beneficial that she didn’t have to walk or risk getting lost in the woods but she felt as if reduced to a child and she didn’t know why. To pass the time, he was compelled to play with those long strands of hair as Adora navigated through the forest.

“Adora?” Catra tapped her tiara.

“Yeah?”

“I um, I didn’t want to say anything while we were in that temple. I was kind of afraid I’d get sealed up again.” She-Ra’s pace slowed. “I do forgive you,” that pace quickened again, “but I need more time to forget the past.” She-Ra came to a stop. “I’m not angry at you any more, I just don’t want to keep any secrets from you.” Catra raked more of her hair through her fingers.

She-Ra smiled. “Fine, I’ll admit something too.” A breath, “If you go back to the Horde, I’m going with you. Even if it’s as your prisoner. I’m not leaving you.” She shook her head slowly, “Never again.”

“Adora…, that’s really stupid. They’ll kill you on the spot.”

“Are you still planning on going back?” She-Ra’s brow twitched at her own question.

There was some hesitation. Catra leaned on She-Ra’s head, between the wings of her tiara while she held the basket behind her, “Nah.”

“Good,” She-Ra started walking again. “You don’t have anything to worry about then.”

~oO0Oo~

“That’s it! If any of you ask me if I’m sure I know where I’m going one more time,” Swift Wind snapped, turning his head like a springed weapon in their direction, “just *one* more,” he lowered his voice to a scratchy whisper, “I’ll leave you here,” he glared at everyone for a solid moment to drive his point. He turned his head forward again and spoke with a more sense of calm, “You know the legends of the Whispering Woods. The lands shift. Now, assuming I have your support, Adora is this way!”

The rest of the group wasn’t sure. They trusted Swift Wind but didn’t trust the medication he was on. They all looked at each other with uncertain panic but decided to let Swift Wind continue. Bow had both his arms in a sling. With rest, he’d recover quickly but until then, he won’t be able to operate his weapon. Scorpia pretty much good as new. She had a grotesque and hardened scab over her back. It was like a sheer yellow crystal and under the right lighting, you could see open flesh. You either stared at it

or tried to avoid it when it was in view. Scorpia was completely oblivious, she was just happy to be included.

~oO0Oo~

Adora couldn’t hold back a short giggle which earned a questioning grunt from Catra. Adora answered with a descalating sigh, “Nothing. You just seem to really like my hair.”

Another grunt, “It’s soft.”

“I know, right!? When I finally got the transformation down, I was brushing it for *hours* ! I was so sure someone would catch me but Bright Moon’s pretty good about privacy. I was not used to that.” Another soft and pleasant chuckly, “You know, you could have asked me when we were in the temple.”

“No,” her voice was a bit sour. Adora wasn’t sure why. “I hate She-Ra.”

“I don’t-”

“Because…, all of this started with She-Ra.” They were both silent for a moment. “I just need time, Adora.” Catra began to feel the sweat dampening She-Ra's hair, “Hey, you've been walking for hours, take a break. Eat.”

She-Ra contemplated arguing that she felt alright, but then again, Bright Moon was a long way off. And maybe, this was Catra’s way of telling her that she was hungry too. She stopped and came to a squat to let Catra down. She transformed back to her regular self, “Oof, alright, good call.” She didn't feel it while she was walking, but as soon as she stopped, that head of hers felt lighter than air.

Catra leaned against the nearest tree and Adora was right next to her and leaned against Catra’s shoulder. Soft whispers shushed

through the trees but they didn't appear nefarious as Catra remembered. It was as if they were filled with chortles and soft sighs. Light crept through the leaves as they tossed against the gentle breeze.

Catra booped Adora's head with a loaf of bread and passed a small cheese wheel. Luckily, Catra was also smart enough to pack water in the sleeves of some spare clothing like a makeshift canteen. Simply squeezing the sleeve at the knot let water drip out from the increased pressure. Both of them were enjoying the calm.

After Adora and Catra had their fill, Adora felt she needed to spoil the moment. She needed it off her chest and Catra to be fully aware of what was to come. "Catra? If it turns out things really went bad, you know I have to fix it, right?"

Catra huffed and leaned her head against Adora's, "What? No chance we'll come back to the woods and live off of berries? Maybe that old lady that lives out here will let us move in." A quick roll of her eyes, "I know, Adora. And I'll be right there, making sure you aren't going to do anything stupid. Because let's face it, you're kind of a dumb-fa-"

"Shh!" Adora grabbed her sword and sat up. Adora heard distant rustling. Catra grabbed and stashed the food and tried to listen with Adora. Multiple footsteps were approaching. They stamped with heavy marching. Adora closed her eyes and silently turned to She-Ra. She pointed to her back with her thumb to Catra. And even though she hated it, she followed through and they hid behind a tree.

~oO0Oo~

Swift Wind was getting excited, "Adora should be near. Keep an eye out, we might accidentally pass each other. Maybe form a line

and sweep the area."

~oO0Oo~

Adora decided to take the high ground and began climbing the tree she hid behind with Catra. If needed, the high vantage point would allow an easier drop on the enemy. Otherwise, they would remain hidden. Both of them had their eyes darting around in an attempt to find where the marching was coming from. And then they finally heard it. They heard their names. A collective and elongated, "Adora!" follow by an even louder "AND CATRA!"

She-Ra spoke over her shoulder, "Is that…, is that Scorpia?"

Catra began to snicker, "It sure is. Let's go."

She-Ra carefully climbed down and changed back to Adora. Neither of them could believe it. Especially Adora who could only think the worst with them not coming sooner. They shouted back with great excitement, "Over here!"

When they finally met, everyone seemed frozen. There was much to take in. Adora, who saw Swift Wind with his wings bound in place and Bow's arms in slings, was horrified they were so hurt. Angella, along with Scorpia's presence was completely unexpected. And Glimmer, who despite having building tears and a growing smile, seemed unusually tired.

And they, too, seemed shocked. Adora's thinned face and frail posture had them questioning what could possibly have gone wrong. They had two more months, there should have been plenty of supplies. And while they were still on edge with Catra standing there, it was Scorpia who nearly wept at the sight of her wounds. She was the first one to move - more like charge - towards Catra and lift her to a hug, "What happened to you!?" Glimmer then proceeded to teleport into a perfect hug around

Adora to ask the same question. The rest slowly gathered around them and had so much to say and ask.

All were overwhelmed. Catra had even returned Scorpia's hug and quickly found the scabbed wound. Questions swirled around everyone and it was Angella who had to put a stop to all the clamoring. She stepped in front of Adora. A gentle voice as always, "We are all so happy to have you back in our lives. Both of you look like you need much care. I assume Catra will be joining you in Bright Moon?"

Adora became stoic. She spoke as if her voice dictated law, "Yes. And she will serve no time for past crimes as she has served them already. She is an ally…," a brief hesitation, "your majesty." Her face softened, "I mean, I'm sorry, but I will defend her. I know so much more now and-"

Angella stopped her, "I understand. We'll talk later," she offered a smile, "After you've rested." She turned to Catra who was released from Scorpia's grasp, "It seems there is much for us to discuss." Only silence was her reply. "Catra, I am willing to give you a chance as I have with Adora, Kyle, Rogellio, and Scorpia. And if Adora believes in you as I have her, I will do the same. Do you understand?"

Catra continued her silence for a moment. She thought putting so much trust in someone who historically was set to destroy them was incredibly stupid. Then again, their faith was more in Adora than her. She wouldn't be in prison but she'd be surrounded by guards, likely under close watch. She had no weapons other than her own claws and Bright Moon seemed to be slowly flipping Horde soldiers. So long as she stuck with Adora, she wouldn't be threatened. "I do."

"Good," a slow smile crossed her lips. "Let's get you home."

Chapter End Notes

It is very likely I will add an epilogue to this to show how Catra is adapting to Bright Moon life. :)

Because I've been sick for the entirety of February, I didn't get a chance to do the chapter cleanup that I wanted to do. So, that will be something I'll be working on now. Please keep in mind, this is your chance to tell me what I can do to make this story better! I'm mostly going to be revising so my sentences read better but if there are some sections in there that you think would make you flip and give me a Kudos, PLEASE LET ME KNOW. :) Also, please give kudos =P

Hoping it wasn't too obvious but the ending gave me a bit of trouble. Not sure if this was good enough closure, you know? I'm gonna try to fix it up if I can. I'm just fresh out of ideas.

I'll be reading some of the many many fics that are far better than mine to see how I can improve. I also just need to decompress. For what it's worth, this is the first fic I actually felt really good about. My mind kept want to take it to very dark places and I said NOPE!

Epilogue spoiler, Catra and Adora prank Glimmer. Adora opens a portal to Glimmer's room and Catra goes through it. Upon Glimmer's startled gasp, nearly a heart attack, Catra just screams at her, "YOU LIKE THAT? YOU LIKE IT WHEN I JUST... APPEAR!"

No... friction... between them... at all :3

Wanna talk?
Twitter - https://twitter.com/AmbiguousThe
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Epilogue

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Integration with Bright Moon was far more difficult for Catra than it had been for Adora. Catra had quite a resume of atrocities committed while Adora had a far different experience. With no ability to turn into a chosen goddess with a sword integrated with a portable rune stone, Catra entered a world where she lost all the respect she earned at the Horde. All except Adora's, as if to come full circle to her upbringing. Once again, Adora gave her validation while everyone else saw garbage with claws. But Adora promised that would change.

As expected, Catra's arrival was met with sneers from royal guards. There were shocked faces from the public who sought chains to be wrapped around the woman rather than the bandages that aided her. The Princess Alliance looked down upon Catra and questioned Adora's judgement. When Catra passed through all of them, she thought best to keep her eyes averted. But Adora would not have it. For every sneer and glare in Catra's direction, she glared back harder and shared *her* disapproval and disappointment until she and Catra were escorted to the castle.

One of the biggest changes Catra had to adjust to was the unusual brightness. The kingdom certainly earned its name with rays of golden light beaming through every window. It reflected and shimmered off the walls and floors in brigantine colors of blue and purple. As they walked down the halls filled with murals, Catra was given the option to have her own room or to stay with Adora. The choice was hers. When Catra lain in Adora's bed, she threatened to change her mind if Adora didn't wipe the smirk off her face. Adora rolled her eyes dismissively but just the same, she did in fact remove the smirk with a kiss. She swore it was the only way she knew how.

The first month was the most difficult. The first few days both Adora and Catra were allowed to rest but soon after they were asked to be "interviewed." They swore it was not an interrogation and emphasized that it was only to understand what had happened. Adora and Catra were taken to separate rooms and questioned for hours. Queen Angella tried to make both conversations friendly. Catra's past had not made things easy. There were moments when Angella had to refrain from engaging for some of Catra's responses.

When Queen Angella was satisfied with Adora's answers, she was asked to assist with missions as She-Ra. However, doctors of Bright Moon had advised her not to proceed until her physical therapy was complete. They had not cared much for Catra but orders were orders and assisted her as well.

Glimmer was taking the reunion the hardest. Jealousy consumed her. With Catra around, Adora wasn't seen as much. She began to think Adora was going to forget about her. She made surprise appearances, and occasionally, not at the most appropriate times. Bow was the peace keeper. He made a lot of effort to try to welcome Catra. He wasn't happy with her past either but the fact that she was in Bright Moon meant she had changed - or so he hoped. It wasn't easy to talk to her though. Bow found that each conversation with her led to some dark memory of her past abuse. He began to understand why Adora said she had already served time for her crimes. He tried to explain this Glimmer but their conversations would often spin off to heated arguments about how her past is not an excuse for the things she did. Luckily, the arguments ended with them apologizing to each other.

When both Adora and Catra were given the approval to discontinue their therapy, Adora was immediately called for duty. And while Catra had no intention of joining the Rebellion or fighting, she would not allow Adora to go out on a mission without her. Catra also intended to remain quiet and not participate in any mission briefings. However, it wasn't long before she made herself vocal on how well each mission was planned. More often than not, Catra scoffed at them and sarcastically criticized how perfect their

plans were to get everyone killed. No one listened to her seriously until Adora asked her for suggestions. It wasn't long before they discovered that Catra was a far better strategist.

Food was something that overwhelmed Catra on an emotional level. Much like Adora's first experience with something that wasn't the Horde's bland rations, Catra couldn't hide her enjoyment despite all her effort. Adora had actually caught her with tears eating a seasoned and buttered fish. The unfortunate downside was that Catra often destroyed something for feeling weak. It took quite a large amount convincing from Adora that it was actually okay to feel. And even though Adora was somewhat successful, Catra had actually preferred something less flavorful. It seemed it was just too much to process until she became more familiar with the new flavors.

Then there were the nightmares between the both of them. Adora would sometimes cry in her sleep. Dreams of her last few days in that temple had haunted her. Catra did her best to awaken her and wipe the cold sweat from her face and neck. She'd reminded Adora of what happened the day before so she'd know they were no longer there. Catra's experience was a little more frightening. A loud sobbing groan woke both of them. It was the image of Adora not waking up. Those sunken eyes and dried lips were exaggerated in her mind. She blamed herself. She'd grip the sheets until they were torn. It took Adora several minutes to calm her as she forced Catra's hands to feel her face. Catra would then tighten Adora into an almost painful hug as she sobbed quietly into her shoulder. These nightmares lessened with time, and with help, sleep became more peaceful for the both of them.

Months went by slowly for Catra. Glimmer was still the most reluctant to give Catra even the smallest amount of leeway. It wasn't until Catra heard of Adora's birthday did Glimmer begin to soften. Like Adora when they first met, Catra never heard of what a birthday or a party was. Glimmer attempted to explain. A celebration by giving gifts to the person you care a lot about. To make them happy by showing your appreciation that that person was brought into your life. And then Glimmer was stunned by

Catra's reply, "Shouldn't you try to do that every day then? I mean, make them happy. I try to do that with Adora whenever I can. Why do I need to wait for a particular day?" Glimmer couldn't speak. It seemed like infallible logic. It was also the first time that Glimmer thought Catra had a heart.

The silence between them grew awkward. Catra took a moment to look around and began walking away with the assumption that there was no more. Glimmer stopped her, "W-wait! A-a party is also for friends to enjoy! You should come!" Catra could only think of the sneers. She didn't want to ruin Adora's party. She spoke over her shoulder, "I'll think about it," and left.

Catra would spend her idle days reconnecting with her old squad and occasionally watched Bright Moon's soldiers train. It became more of an interest to her. It was the magic. Powerful but was as if it were handled by children. The soldiers used it more playfully rather than as a means to defend or strike. Sparring with magic finished with joyful laughter rather than self-loathing misery after defeat. How much stronger could she make them, she wondered. She promised herself she'd check with Adora first before engaging but Adora just wasn't around at the moment. She couldn't take the lack of focus any longer.

She approached the training field. Sparring rings on the ground were decagonal. Staffs were held by the armored trainees. Short pillars that glistened with light hues of purple and pink housed their instructors. Catra opened with her most polite introduction, "None of you would last ten seconds on the battlefield!" She was met with expected and predictable narrowed eyed glares. And, of course, challenged from one of the instructors. She returned a smirk to the two instructors and four trainees. With a lifelong experience of fearing and outrunning shadows, she was pretty confident that four sloppy sorceresses wouldn't be able to land a hit. Again, as polite as she could, "Your failure to keep this squad disciplined will get them killed. Go ahead, let them all come at me. Pretend I'm a Horde soldier. Shouldn't be too hard." Catra scoffed at them as they surrounded her from a distance. She shook her head them knowing their weakness. They were unable to use

their magic at too close proximity to themselves. And the way they surrounded her, none of them would be able to attack as soon as she neared one of them.

It quickly began with a bright orange light that trailed her feet as she darted and serpentined toward her first target. She could feel the heat of the magical blasts licking her heels. And suddenly, the barrage of thundering light came to a sudden stop as Catra grabbed the collar of her first target, "When your weapon is dependent on range, don't surround the enemy!" She kicked a leg in and threw her opponent to the ground, "You just died." She claimed the staff she held and watched the other three change their formation to an inverted and spread 'V'. They honed their magic and fired forward towards Catra. She jumped high and ran towards the center trainee and dodged continued fire. When she entered the inside of the formation, she immediately threw the staff she held at the one to her left who errantly fired her weapon at her own squad member. The soldier in the center was Catra's next victim. She could see the shock on the woman's face when Catra punched her solar plexus. When she came to a knee, Catra used her as a shield, "Never believe your enemy won't fight dirty! There is no chivalry in war! The Horde will take your friends and torture them to lure you out!" She walked with the woman on her shoulder toward her last victim. The soldier didn't know what to do. Catra told her the answer, "Prepare to make sacrifices," when Catra was close enough, she tossed the shouldered soldier at the stunned trainee, "or prepare to suffer the consequences." Catra looked to the instructors who were ready to attack. She raised her hands to a shrug and grinned, "They're all dead." She watched the instructors seethe.

Unfortunately, that grin on Catra was fleeting to the sight of an angry Adora on the training grounds. It was as if Catra's grin was split in two and shared between the onlooking instructors. A swift and violent hand pointed to the trainees who were taking their time to recover, "Catra!? The fuck!?"

Luckily, the argument that followed didn't last long. A few minutes of, "It's not what it looks like!" and "What actually happened is up

for debate," came and went. The squad and leaders were beginning to see a different side to Catra. Adora eventually asked her if she was hurt, to which she replied with a simple, "No." She made sure Catra hadn't hurt anyone with anything more than a few bruises and maybe a few cuts to their pride. And when she took Catra's hand to go back to their room, they discussed what Catra wanted to do within Bright Moon.

When they were alone, Catra was far more honest. She told Adora that she wanted respect. She understood the difficulty with achieving that at Bright Moon or anywhere else for that matter. That was obvious. She just couldn't help compare her life at the Horde. Other than to exist for Adora, Catra felt her life purposeless again.

It was a long but thoughtful discussion. Adora gave her options and a potential opportunity to be a high ranking official in Bright Moon. She'd be able to command again but it meant that she would be called upon for missions that didn't always involve Adora. It meant that she'd have to be loyal to the Rebellion. And in time, Adora guaranteed she'd get the respect and validation she yearned. Still, Catra was on the fence until, "If you let me prank Glimmer ONCE, I'll do it."

The following day She-Ra looked at Catra with an uncertain disappointment, "Please don't make me regret this." Catra only grinned. She-Ra took a deep breath and now, with greater ease, opened a portal behind Glimmer.

Catra stuck her hand through and with a hard pat on Glimmer's shoulder, "HEY SPARKLES!" Catra retracted her hand and the portal closed. Both of them could hear Glimmer's startled scream and couldn't help laugh at the reaction. "One-ONE MORE," Catra could hardly breathe.

Adora gave a lengthy snort and then guffawed. When she could speak again, she tried to look at Catra as if authoritative despite her smile, " *Just* one, okay? Don't be mean." Making every attempt to hold in her laughter, Catra nodded. "Okay," she exhaled

a long breath to recover, “Last one.” Again the portal opened behind Glimmer who was frantically looking across the room.

Catra placed both her hands on Glimmer’s back, “BAH! You LIKE THAT!? JUST BAH! HI!” Again, she retracted her arms and the portal closed. “IT’S STILL FUNNY!”

Their laughter came to an abrupt stop when Glimmer appeared in their room with angry brows and arms akimbo. But, as quickly as their laughter stopped, the room then burst into a noisy eruption of cackles. Adora tried to the get the words, “I’m sorry,” out but only wheezing huffs and stuttered snorts were all that Glimmer could hear. Glimmer glared and gave a trilling groan in response. When Adora could speak again, and with tears and a smile, she went to Glimmer and gave her a hug, “I’m sorry.” Adora looked at Catra, “Catraaaaa?”

“Fine fine, I’m sorry,” Catra rolled her eyes and looked away.

Gimmer stiffened and boiled for a moment, “YOU CAN OPEN PORTALS!?”

Even during their “interviews” Adora and Catra didn’t speak a word of what happened within those temple walls. It wasn’t for anyone to know but them and so Glimmer’s shock wasn’t unexpected. Adora explained that she was learning something new about She-Ra every day and left it at that. She apologized again for the prank but went on to say that Catra was making a point. Glimmer’s powers, even after being surprised so many times, wasn’t something she could get used to.

Further into the year, Catra was given a chance to prove herself. Training, strategizing, and leading squads on the battlefield. And, it wasn’t just Adora vouching for her. Scorpia, Kyle, and Rogellio had her back too. Her missions revolved around rescue and conversion. It seemed Glimmer’s words had affected her mother very much. Members of the Horde needed to be rescued. They were all children once. Kidnapped and raised to pledge their lives to the Horde. And now, Queen Angella sent her orders for their

salvation. Catra made a starting list and Lonnie was at the top. Catra hated to admit it and would have liked Lonnie to eat a fart but Lonnie, for the most part, was just trying survive like everyone else.

After a year, Catra felt good for the first time. She saw progress. Not just with the war but with herself, her relationships, her life. Up until being brought to Bright Moon, her life was stagnant. The Horde gave her the illusion of respect and growth but now she actually had it. While no one could forgive her past crimes, she was starting to be seen as a hero despite it all. Catra was now the most reliable to pull people out of danger. She was the leader of the expert team to infiltrate, execute, and get out of Horde encampments.

But growth was seen even within Bright Moon and among the Princess Alliance. She even began to socialize with Bow and Glimmer more. Although, truth be told, she still preferred Scorpia and Adora to be with her. But, she did manage to enjoy some of the time without them.

And on one evening, in a scented bath with Adora, with a warm fountain pouring into the tub and the sight of glittery stars twinkling through the window above, she spoke without guard. She let her heart out as if to display every fragile emotion to Adora with a trust she never knew she had. Catra came to a soft whisper, "I… I know what I want after the war is over." She hugged Adora from behind, "I want to learn to cook with you. I, um, I want to eat the food you make," Catra leaned her head on Adora and struggled to find the right words, "I mean, I saw Netossa with Spinnerella out in the halls and I look at them and they're- Adora, I want to do it all with you. Do you want to do that with me, too?" Tense brows rubbed against Adora's back, "Do you want-," she sighed, "Do… do you know what I'm asking?"

She nodded tearfully and took a deep breath. She turned in place in that large tub and kissed Catra's lips, "Of course I know," she sniffled. Another kiss as she cupped Catra's face, "Of course."

A short huff behind that smile, “I love you, Adora.”

Adora kissed her again and again and then brought her into a tighter hug, “I love you, too. I love you so much, Catra.”

With eyes closed, Catra sighed happily, “Does that mean I’m going to be a princess?”

~oO The End Oo~

Chapter End Notes

That's it! =D

Thank you all for reading! Your reviews really warm my heart! While there are still a lot of CatrAdora fics that are better than this one, I still think this was a huge success. I'll still be doing some minor clean up before I set this to complete but this fic was extremely enjoyable to write! Your reviews have been so supportive and makes me so happy. I literally go back and read them when I'm feeling down. So thank you!

I love to interact, if you've got questions or want to discuss, feel free to hit me up. You know my twitter and tumblr too so if you want more dumb or deep SPOP thoughts, I'll be happy to lower your IQ :)

Some things to expect down the road are a few one shots based on really awesome CatrAdora art I've seen. If I get permission to use the art as covers for my fics, I'll post them on both FF and AO3

End Notes

Thanks for reading! This story was originally posted in FanFiction.net but was highly advised to post here, so here we are. I am still learning the AO3 interface so bear with me. More chapters coming.

Also, please let me know if this story doesn't interest you. I've encountered a lot of love from FF but those that didn't stay along for the ride just left without a word. Let me know what I can do better as a writer and storyteller. I won't hold it against you, I promise :)

I still have yet to polish this story but so far I haven't seen anyone mind.

I want everyone to know, this story does end happily - I'm just throwing in conflict because it's necessary to understand Catra's and Adora's perspective.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!